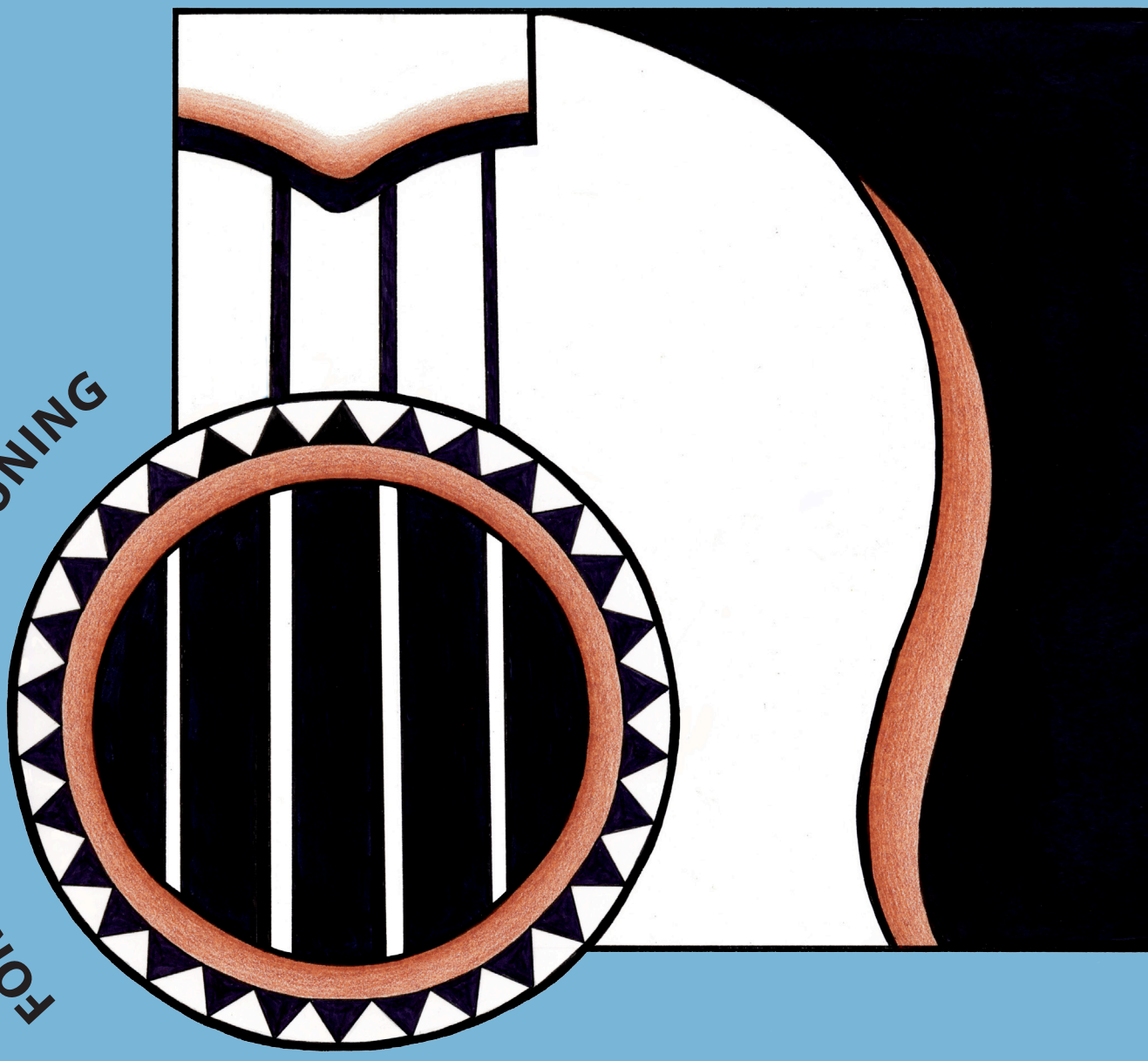
Ukulele
chord melody songs



FOR LOW G STRING TUNING

100 folksongs arranged by Elizabeth Ragsdale

A special thanks
to members of the
Madison Area Ukulele Initiative
www.mauimadison.com

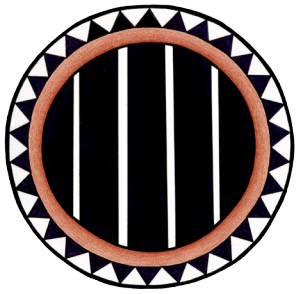


allelon music

© Copyright 2021 by Allelon Music
Madison, Wisconsin

Cover and book design by Elizabeth Ragsdale.

This book is being provided at no cost for personal, noncommercial, and educational purposes only. No portion of the book may be altered or sold.



Contents

GETTING STARTED 5
Across the Hall 7
All Night, All Day 8
Ash Grove, The 9
Ballad of Mary Hamilton, The 10
Baltimore Fire 11
Barnyards of Delgaty, The 12
Beans, Bacon and Gravy 13
Bendemeer's Stream 14
Billy the Kid 15
Bluebells of Scotland, The 16
Brown's Ferry Blues 17
Buffalo Gals 18
Buffalo Skinners, The 19
Bury Me Beneath the Willow 20
Camptown Races 21
Can the Circle Be Unbroken 22
Cirandeiro 23
Crow and the Fox, The 24
Darling Corey 25
Darling Nellie Gray 26
Down in the Valley 27
Drink to Me Only with Thine Eyes 28
Drunken Sailor, The 29
Earl of Errol, The 30
Erie Canal, The 31
Fair Harvard 32
Farmer's Daughter, The 33
Foggy, Foggy Dew, The 34
Freight Train 35
Gee, but I Want to Go Home 36
Give Me That Old Time Religion 37
Go Tell Aunt Rhody 38
Golden Vanity, The 39
Goodnight, Ladies 40
Greensleeves 41
Grind the Meal 42
Hard Luck 43
Honest Ploughman, The 44
Hudson River Steamboat 45
I Ride Old Paint 46
I'll Fly Away 47
In the Pines 48
Irishman's Epistle, The 49
It Takes a Worried Man 50
It's the Same the World Over 51
I've Got Peace like a River 52
Jam on Gerry's Rocks, The 53

▶ Easier songs, to get you started, are indicated in **bold type.**

Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Jesse James 54
John Henry 55
Johnson Boys 56
Kentucky Bootlegger 57
Keys of Canterbury, The 58
La Jesucita 59
Lavender's Blue 60
Lightly Row 61
Li'l Liza Jane 62
Little Sandy Girl 63
Lonesome Valley 64
Louisville Burglar 65
Lullaby, My Baby 66
Mama Don't 'Low 67
Mango Walk 68
Mermaid, The 69
Minstrel Boy, The 70
Nona Manis 71
Oak and the Ash, The 72
Old Gospel Ship 73
Old Gray Mare, The 74
Old Joe Clark 75
Overlander, The 76
Over the Mountains 77
Over the River and through the Woods 78
Portland County Jail, The 79
Rambling Sailor, The 80
Red River Valley 81
Riddle Song, The 82
Rock-a-My Soul 83
Roll in My Sweet Baby's Arms 84
Rosa 85
Sailing in the Boat 86
Schnitzelbank 87
She'll Be Comin' Round the Mountain 88
Shenandoah 89
Shuckin' of the Corn 90
Skillet Good and Greasy 91
Standing in the Need of Prayer 92
Stir the Pudding 93
Streets of Laredo, The 94
Sweet Betsy from Pike 95
Tell Me Why 96
There Is a Balm in Gilead 97
There's a Hole in the Bucket 98
Three Ravens, The 99
Tom Dooley 100
Trav'lin' Man 101
Uncle Reuben 102
Utah Iron Horse, The 103
Vive La Canadienne 104
We're Coming, Arkansas 105
Willie the Weeper 106
APPENDIX 107

Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

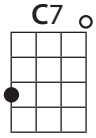
Getting started

Welcome to **Ukulele Chord Melody Songs.** This unique collection of 100 folksongs represents a wide variety of cultures: African, African American, American, Argentinian, Australian, Brazilian, Canadian, English, Flemish, French, German, Indonesian, Irish, Jamaican, Mexican, Scottish, Tobagonian, and Welsh. The tunes were chosen because they have memorable melodies and are well suited to the ukulele.

These instrumental arrangements of easy songs feature common chords strummed at intervals to enrich the sound of the melody. Everything is played with a downward strum of your thumb.

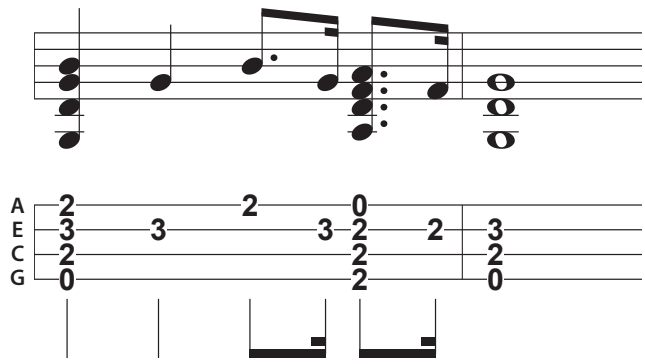
Level

This book was written for the beginner in chord melody playing, but not the absolute beginner on the ukulele. It will be helpful to be familiar with most of the chords used in this book. The standard chord tabs for each song are displayed at the top of the page. Occasionally an alternate way of playing a chord is also shown. An O indicates the string is played open. (See the Appendix for a complete list of the chords.)



The melodies in this book rarely extend beyond a C (3rd fret of A string), so your hand can stay in first position. No melody goes beyond a D (5th fret).

The ability to read music is helpful but not necessary. You may wish to begin with the easier songs, indicated in bold type in the table of contents. As shown in the following example, tabs are used below the melody line to show you where to place your fingers on the strings.



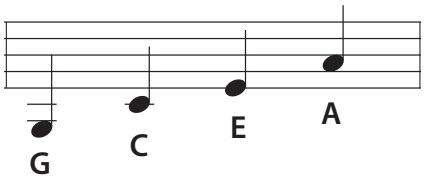
The four lines represent the four ukulele strings. The numbers indicate which frets to place your fingers on, not which fingers to use. A zero means the string is played open. The marks below the numbers indicate how long the notes are held. You can check your rhythm by listening to YouTube videos, which are available for most of the songs.

Tuning

The songs were written for a low G string ukulele. Low G string sets are available for soprano, concert,

Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

tenor, and baritone ukuleles. The low G string is ideal for melody playing because the pitch of the open strings ranges from low to high.

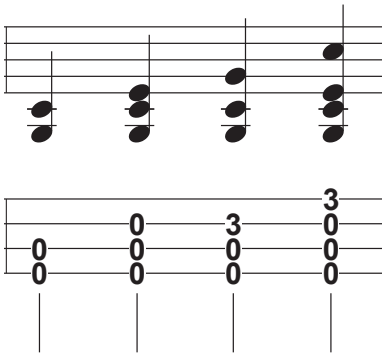


Chord melody arrangements

In chord melody playing, sometimes referred to as solo fingerpicking, you strum chords and pick the melody. The highest note played in a chord is what the ear hears as the melody note. Many well-known players prefer this style, including Jake Shimabukuro and James Hill.

Technique

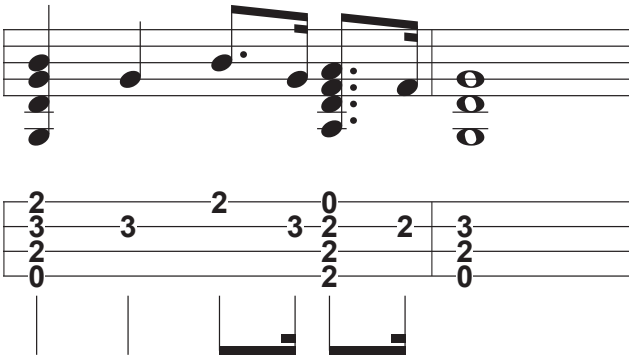
To strum the chords, brush down the strings with your thumb, playing only those notes indicated in the tablature. The tab for a chord may show 2, 3, or 4 vertical numbers. For example, a C chord may be strummed any of the following ways, depending on the melody note.



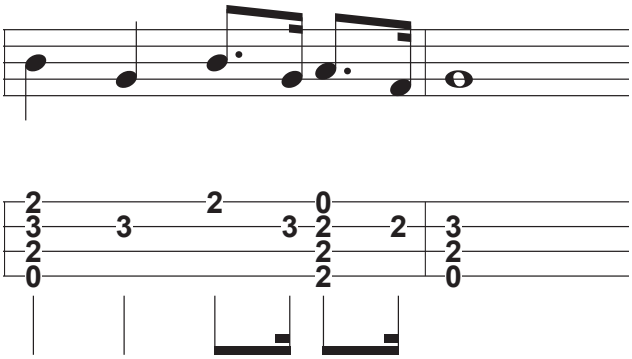
Alternate between strumming the chords and picking the individual melody notes, all done with the thumb. This technique gives you a lighter and smoother sound than strumming a chord on every melody note.

For ease of reading, only the melody note is displayed in the top part of the score, even though chords are sometimes being played.

Standard music notation



Simplified music notation in this book



The rewards

Learning the chord melody technique, which is not difficult, is a satisfying addition to whatever kind of ukulele playing you're already doing. You'll be demonstrating that the ukulele is indeed a real musical instrument with a lot more potential than often recognized. Have fun on your adventure!

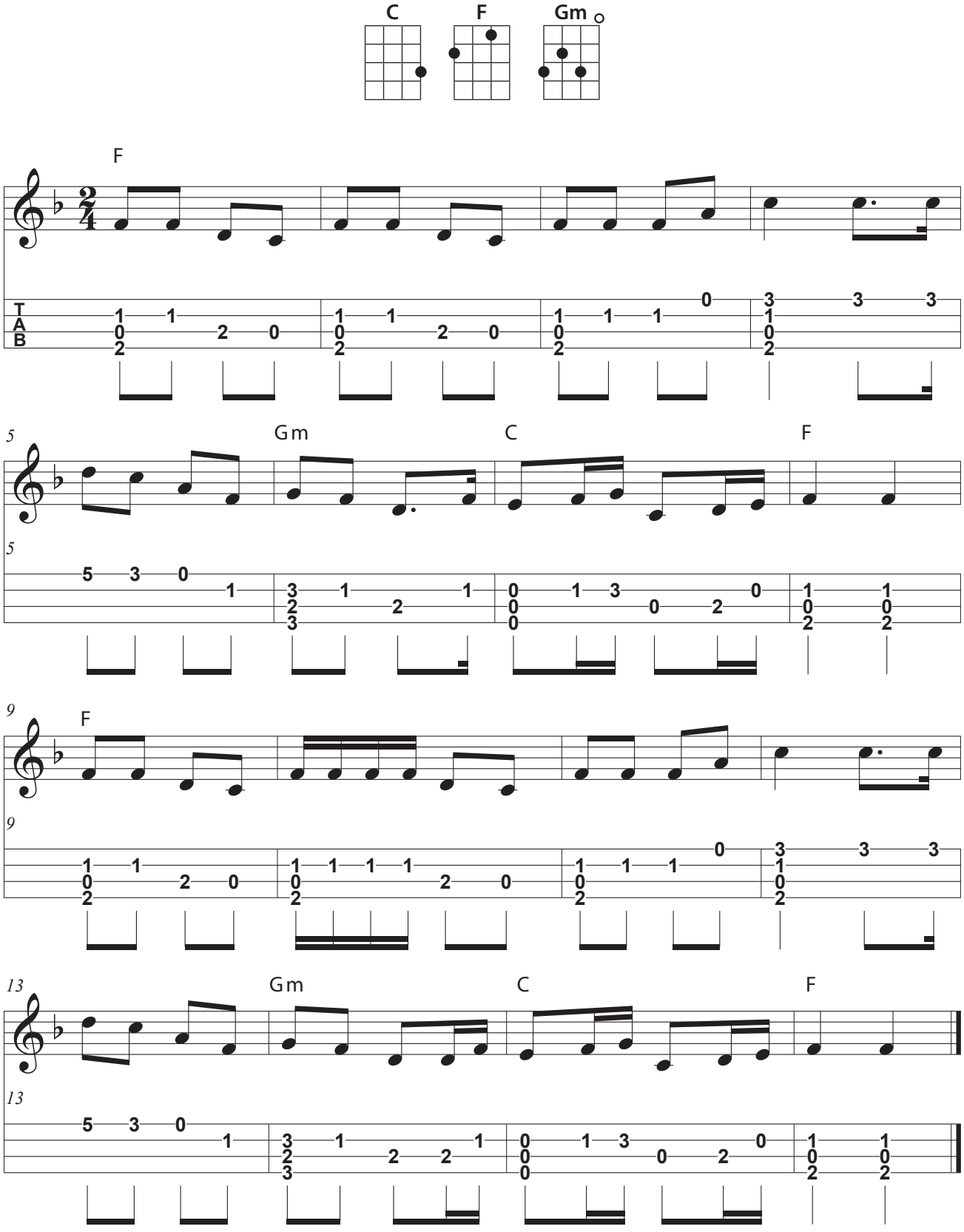
▶ Tip

You may find it easier to finger an entire chord, as indicated at the top of each page, even though you may not be strumming all the strings. Likewise, you can often keep your fingers in a set position as you play a whole segment of the melody, with the goal of shifting your hand as little as possible.

Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Across the Hall

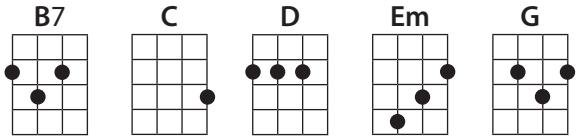
American
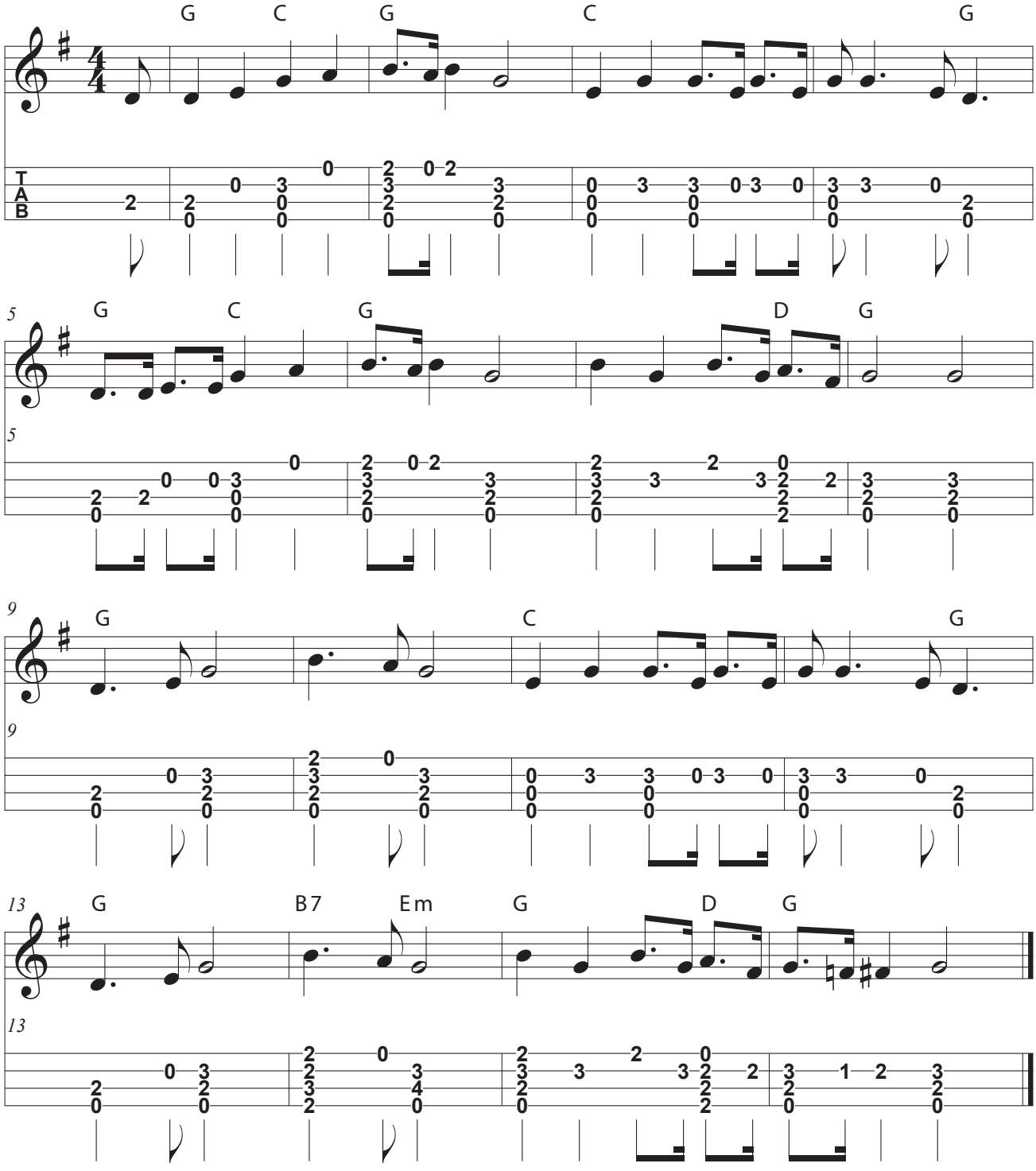


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

All Night, All Day

African American
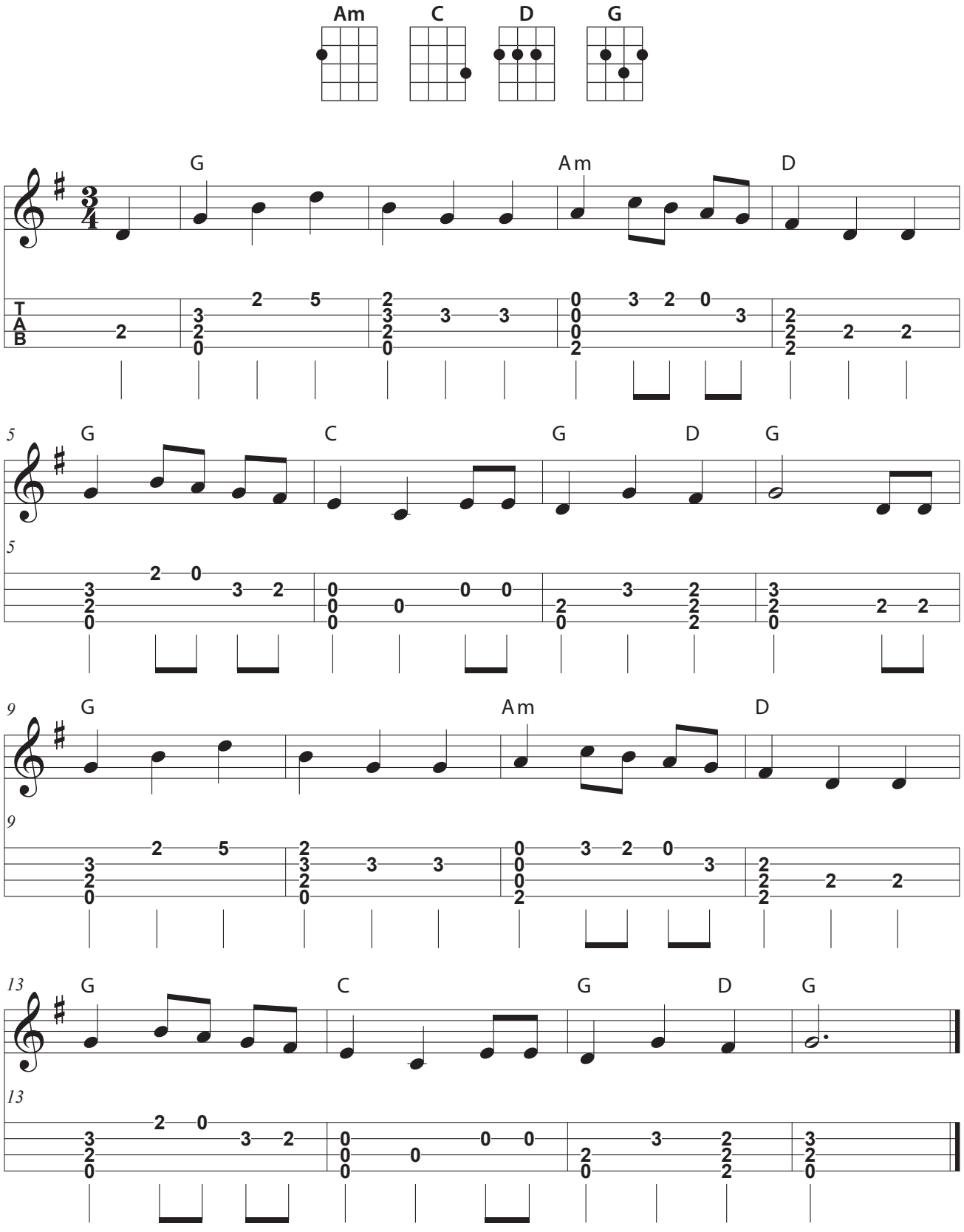




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Ash Grove
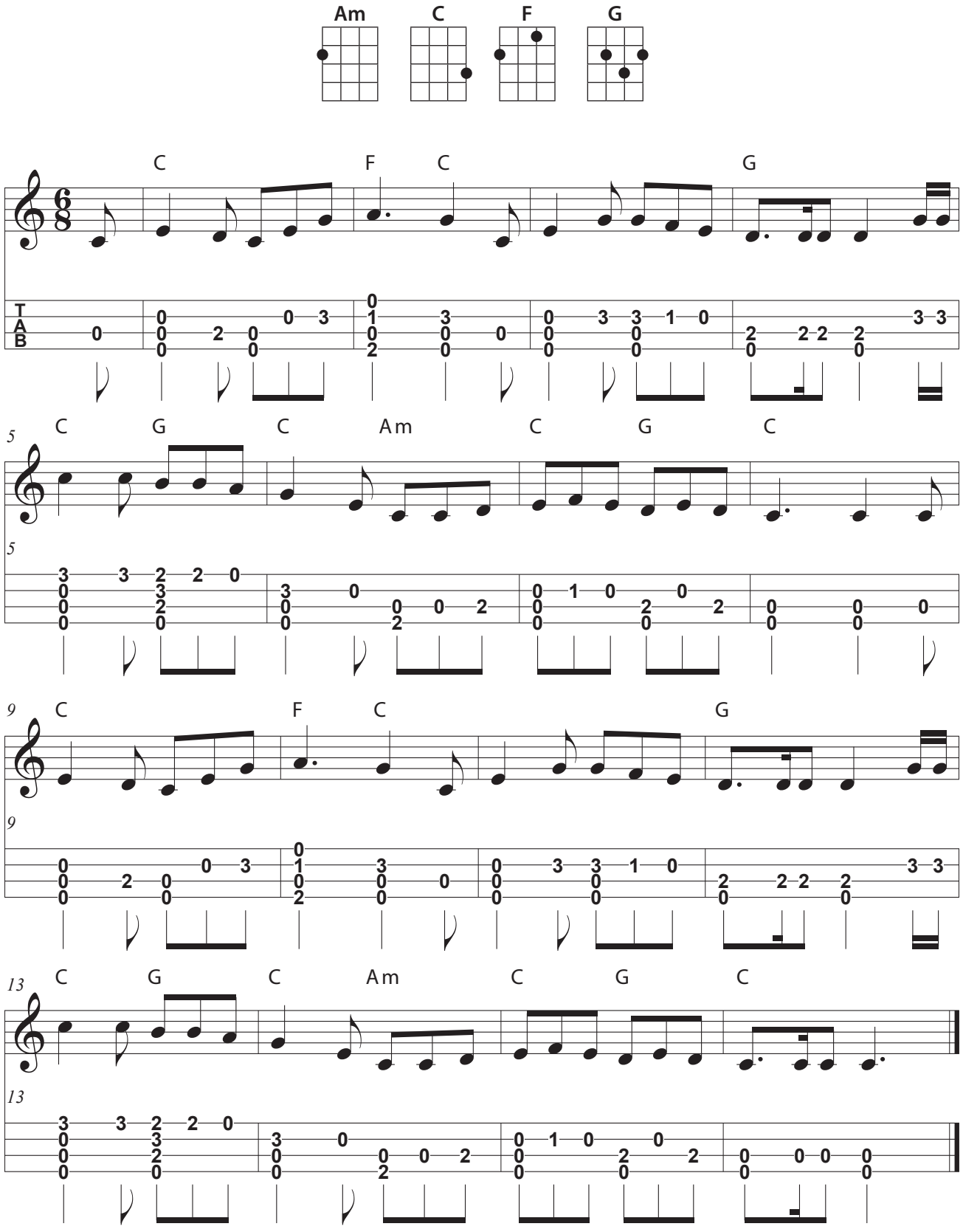
Welsh



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Ballad of Mary Hamilton
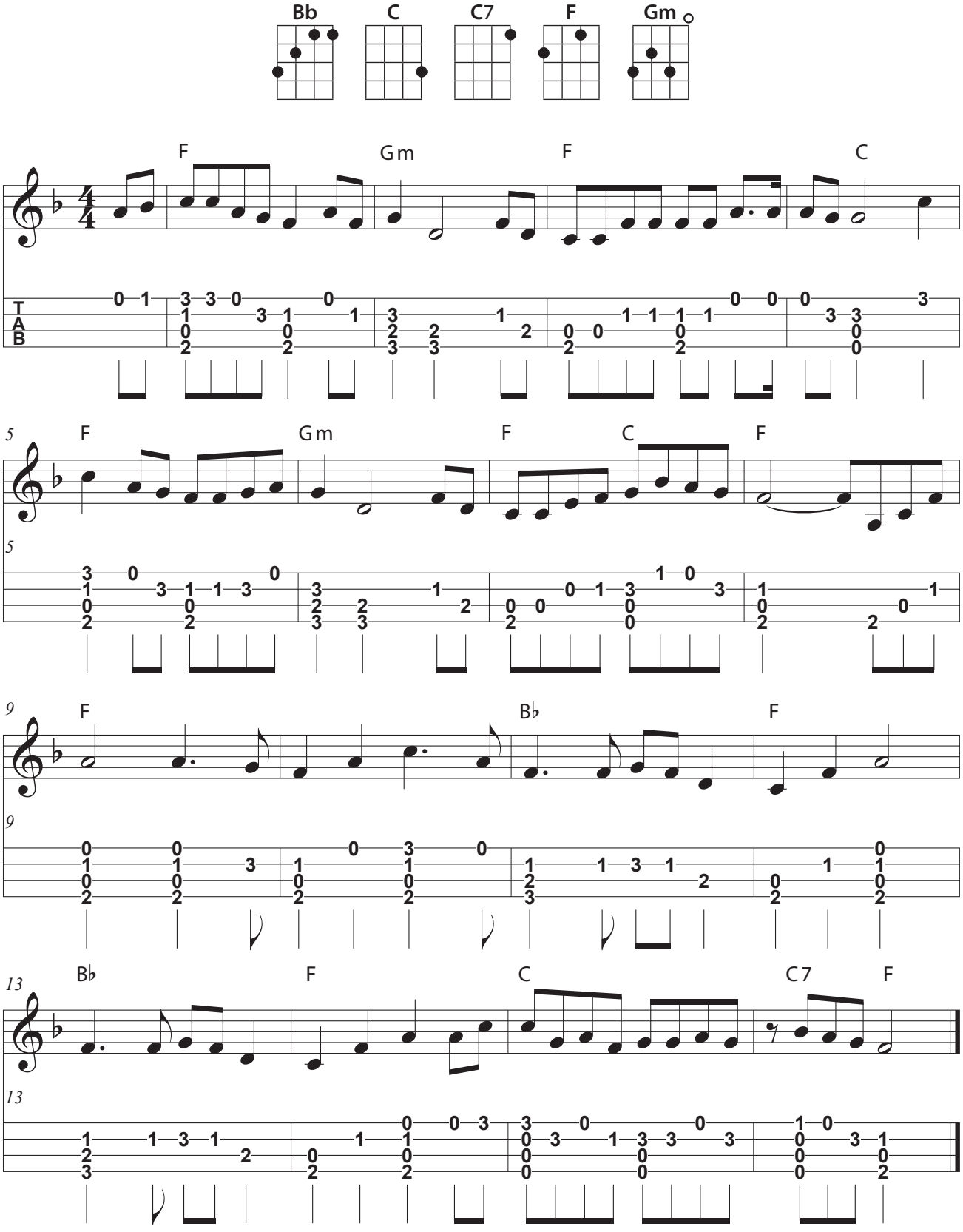
Scottish



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Baltimore Fire
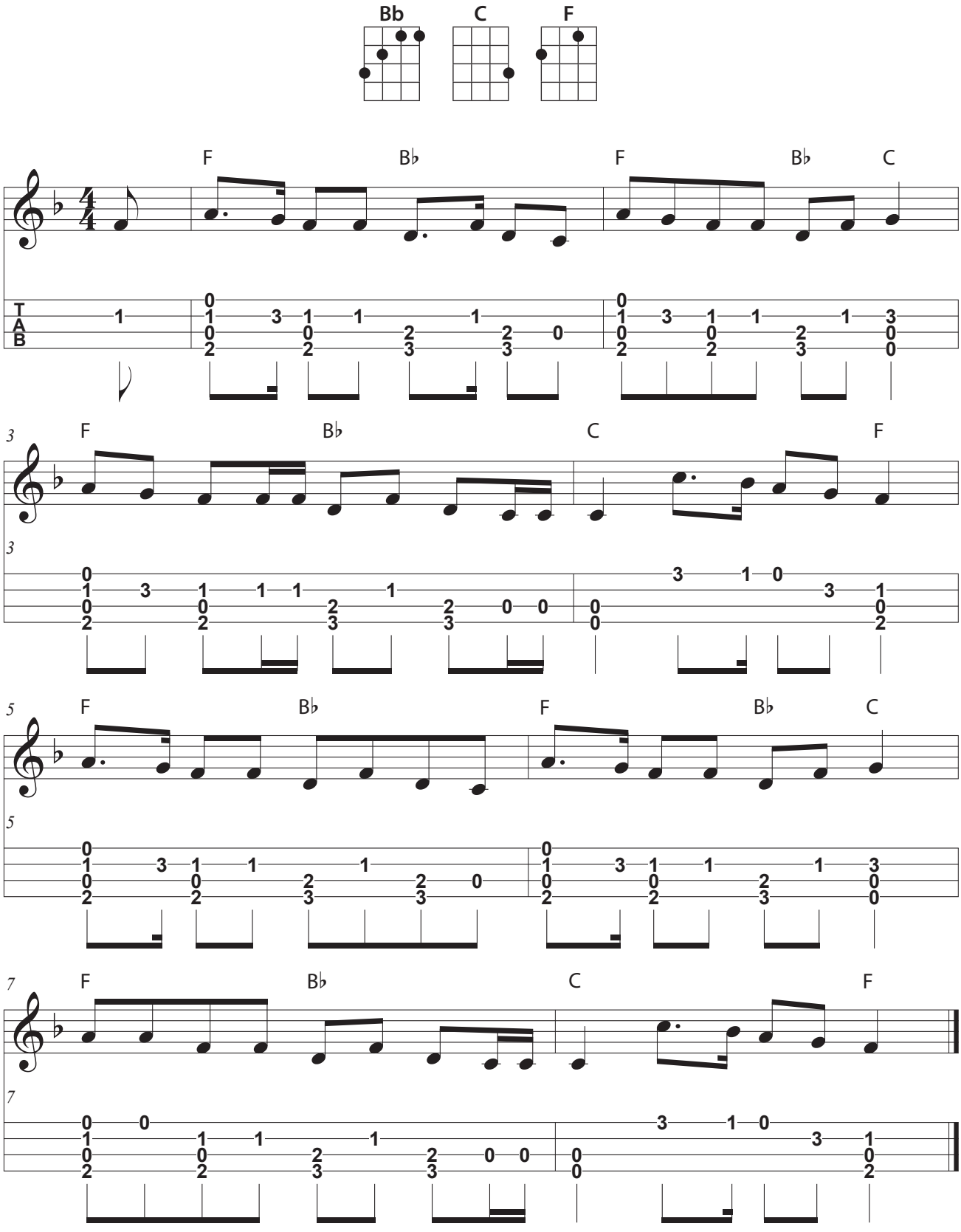
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Barnyards of Delgaty
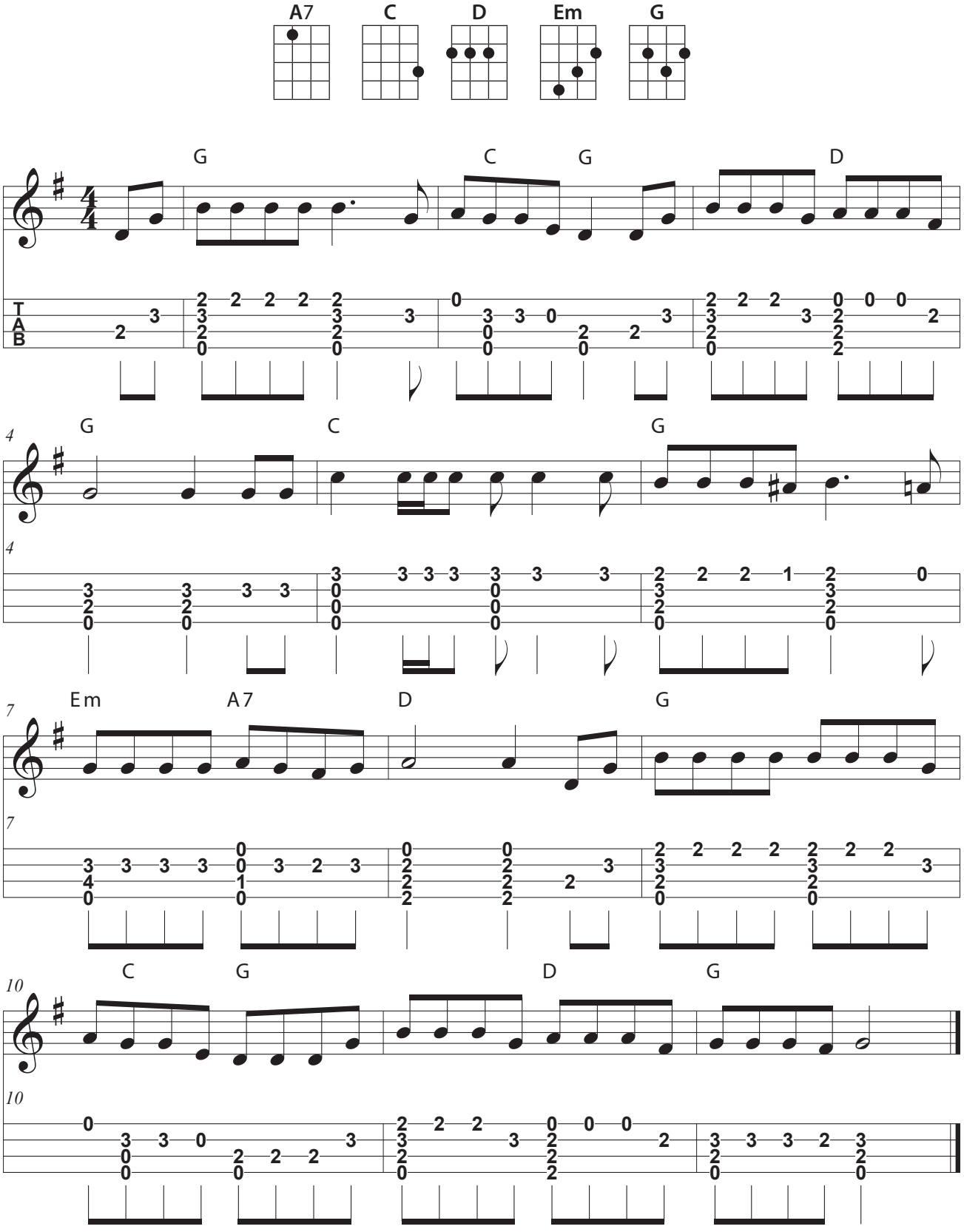
Scottish



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Beans, Bacon and Gravy

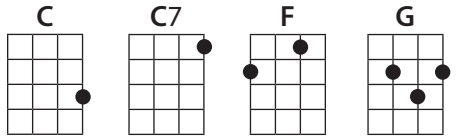
American
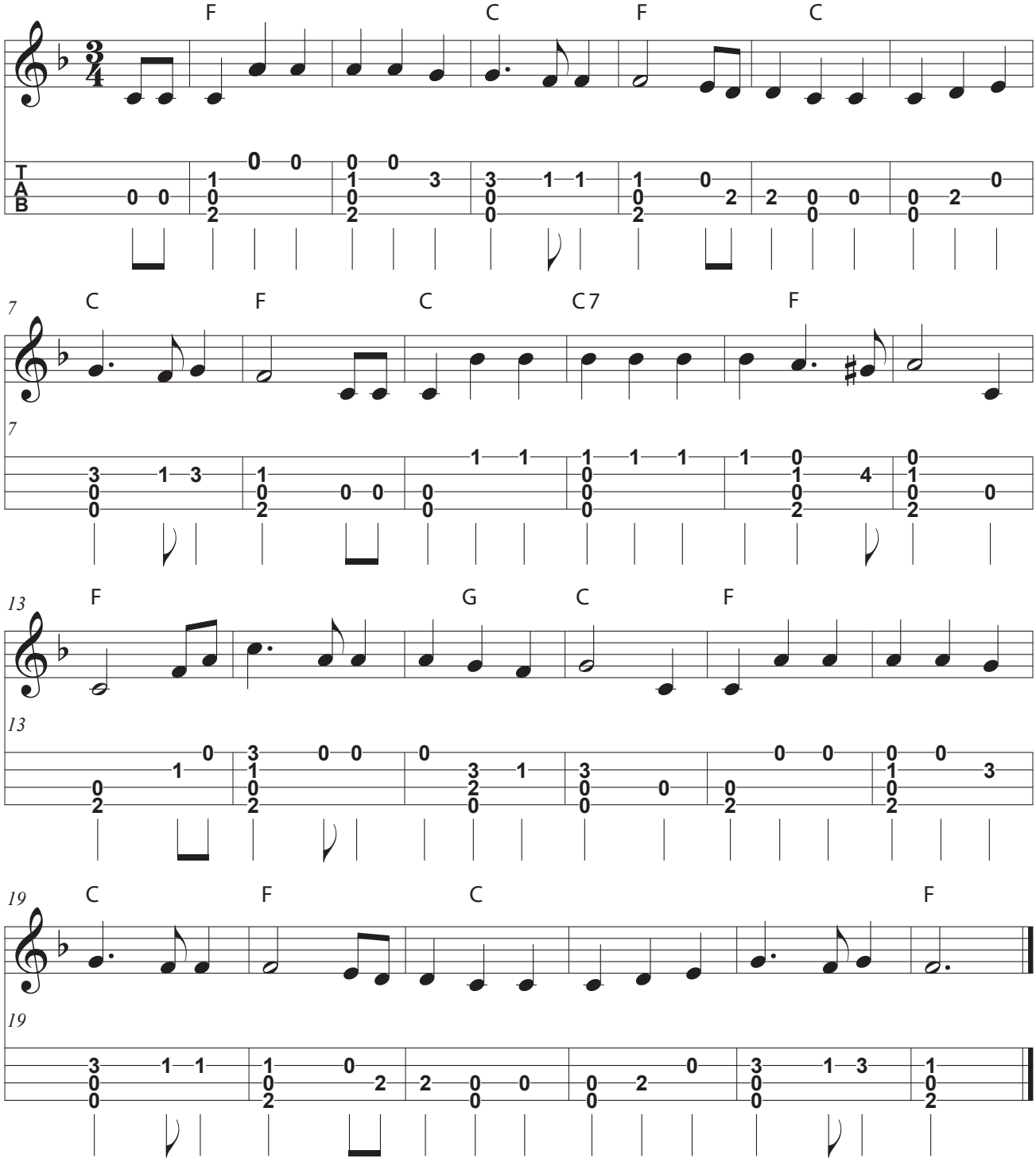


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Bendemeer's Stream

Irish
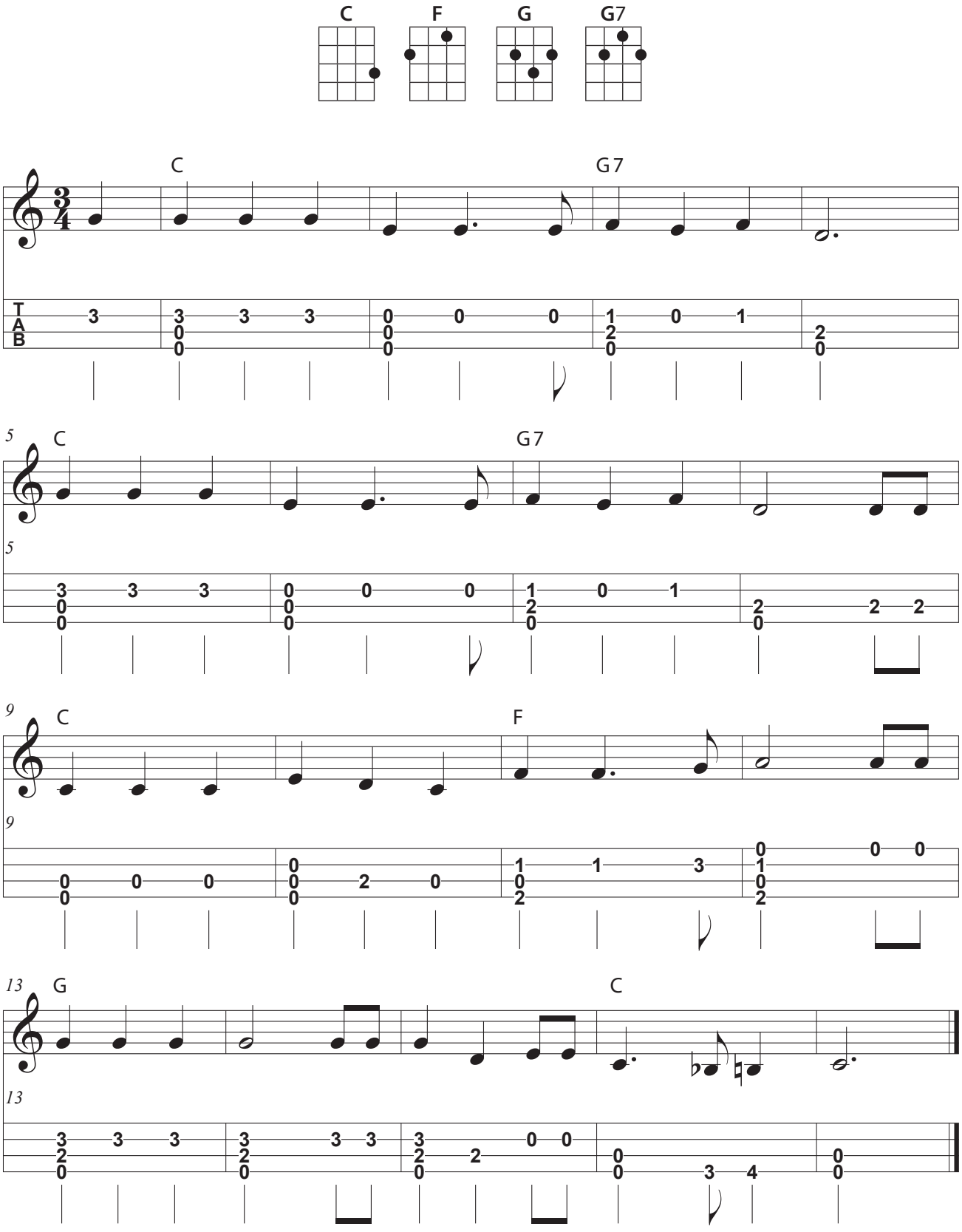




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Billy the Kid
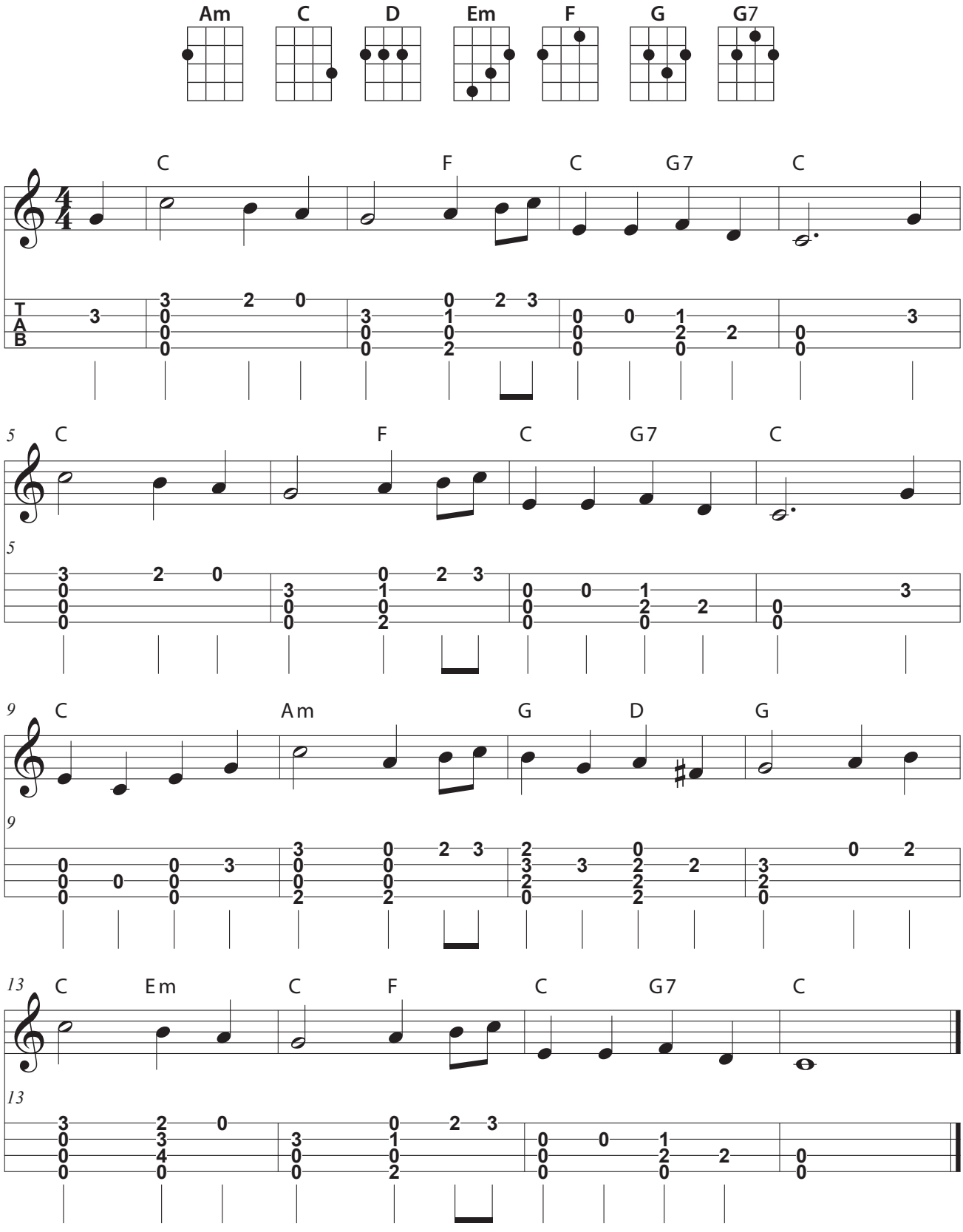
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Bluebells of Scotland
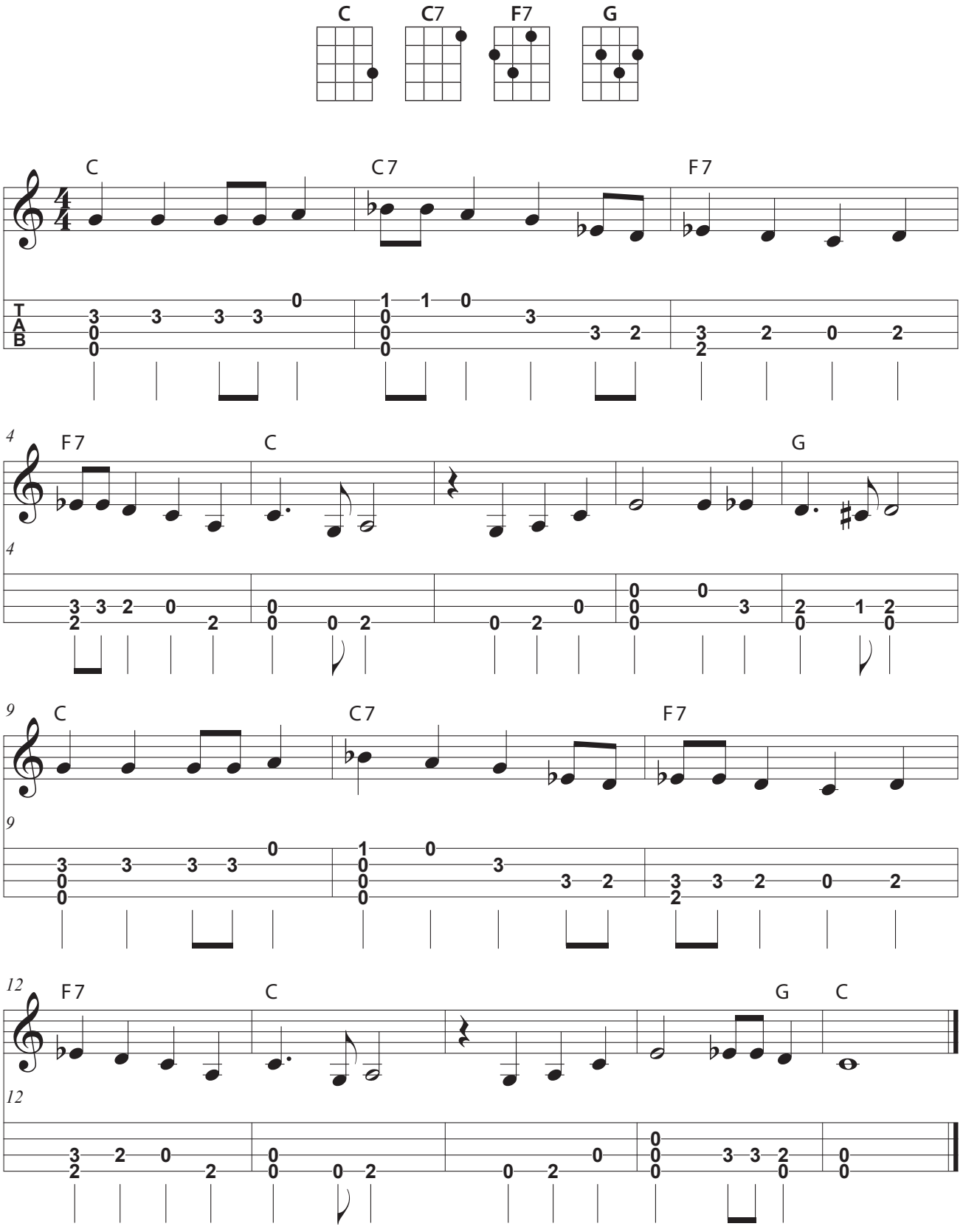
Scottish



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Brown's Ferry Blues
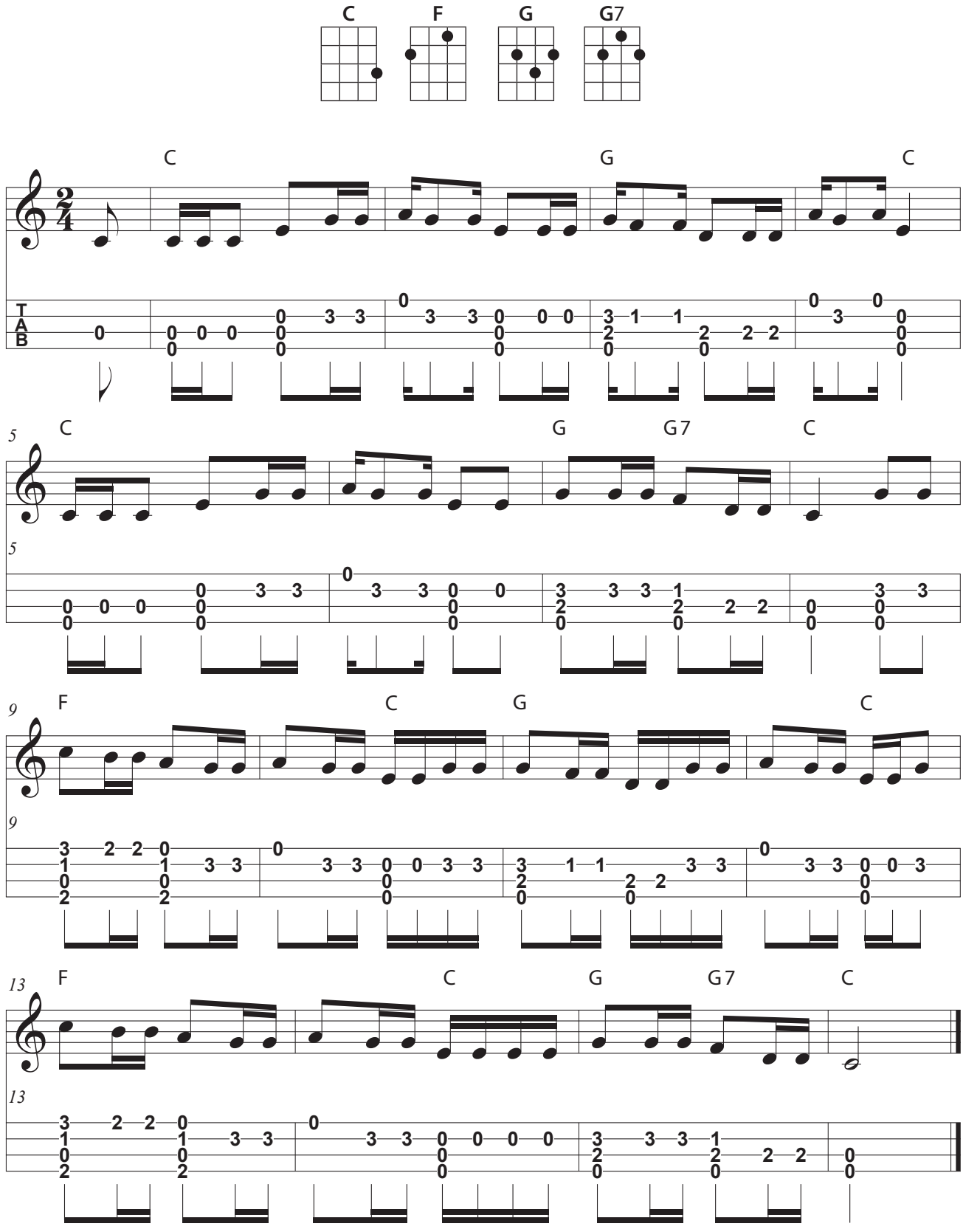
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Buffalo Gals
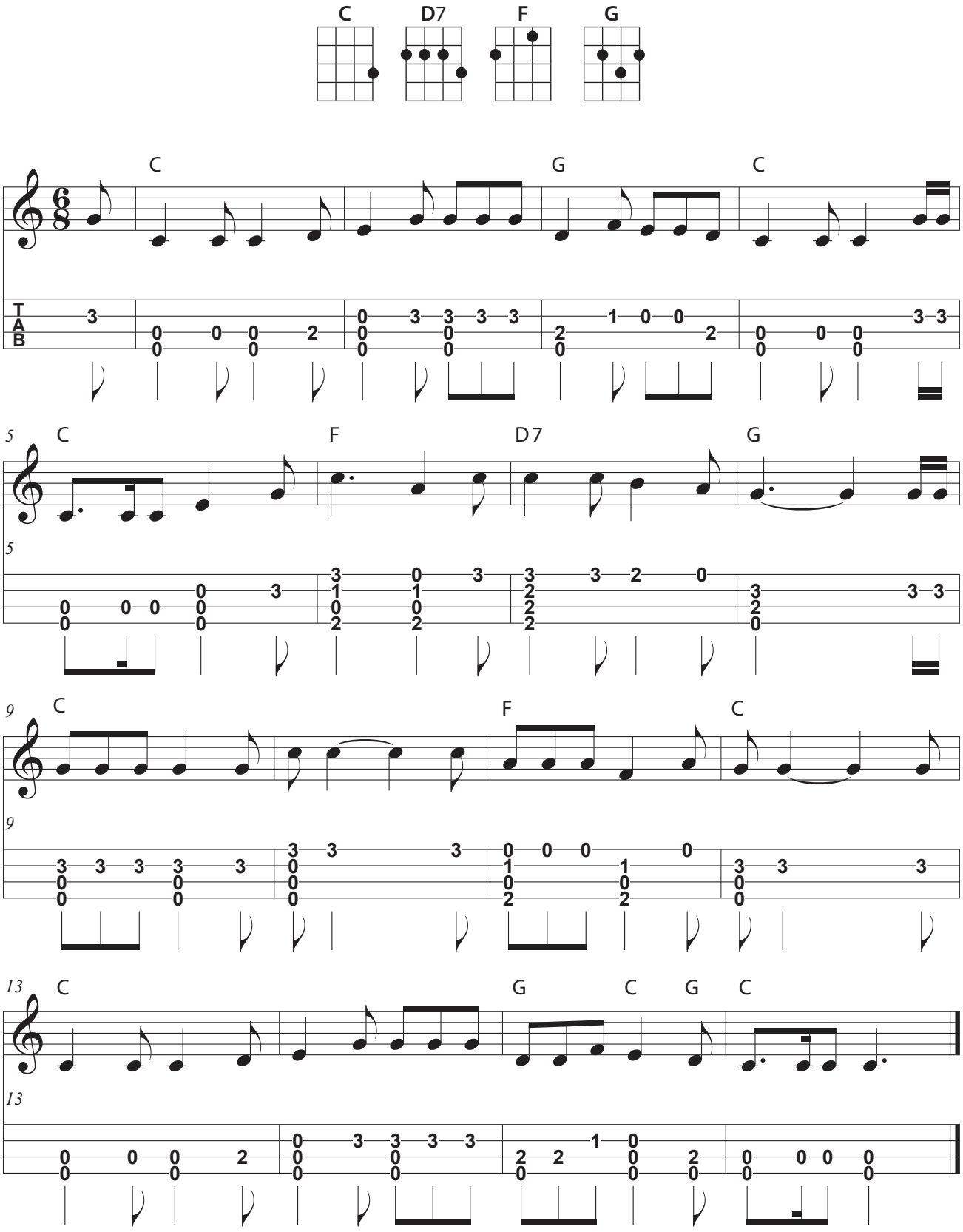
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Buffalo Skinners

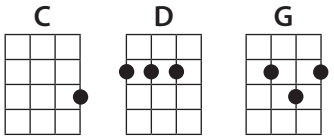
American
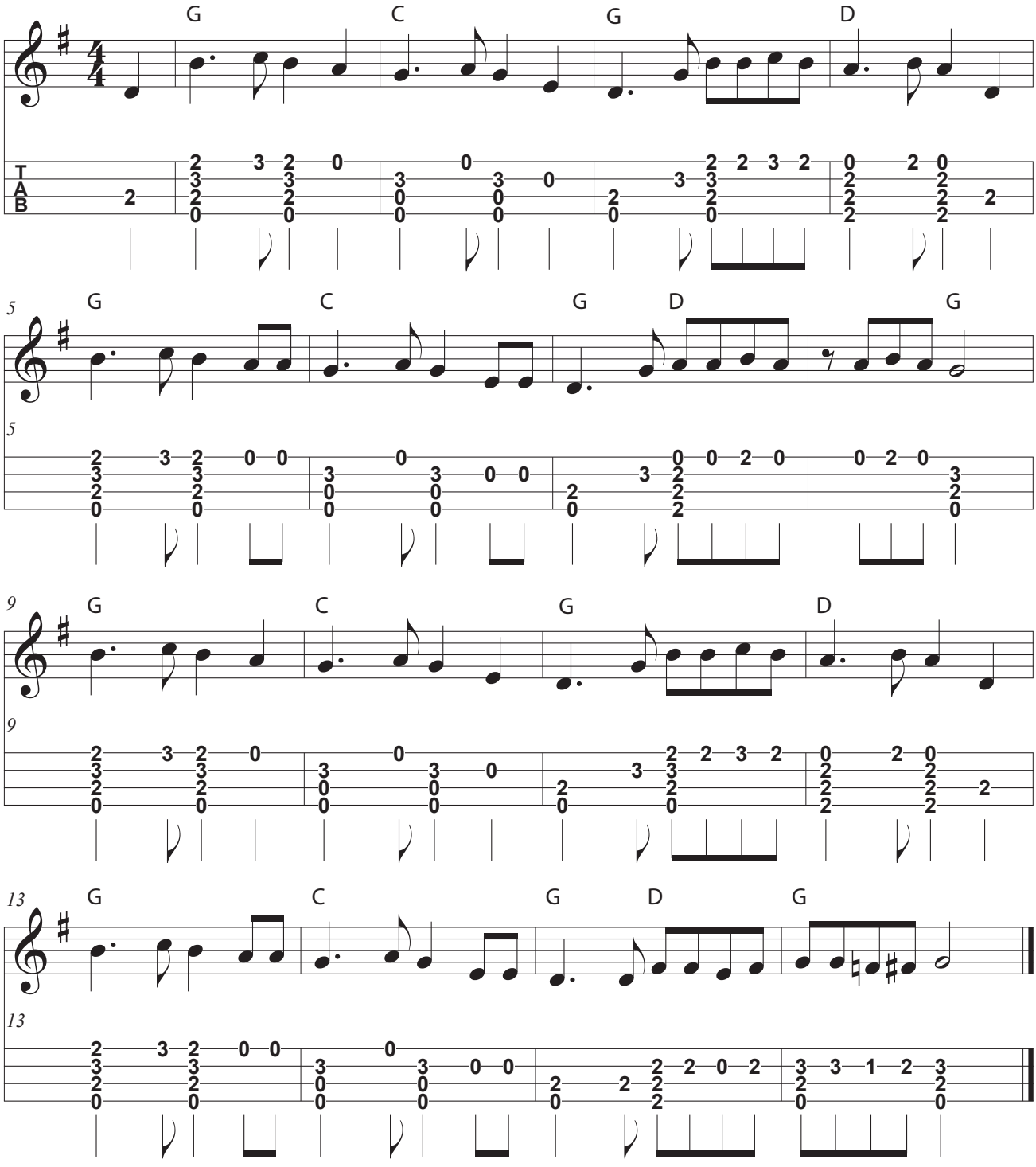


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Bury Me Beneath the Willow

American
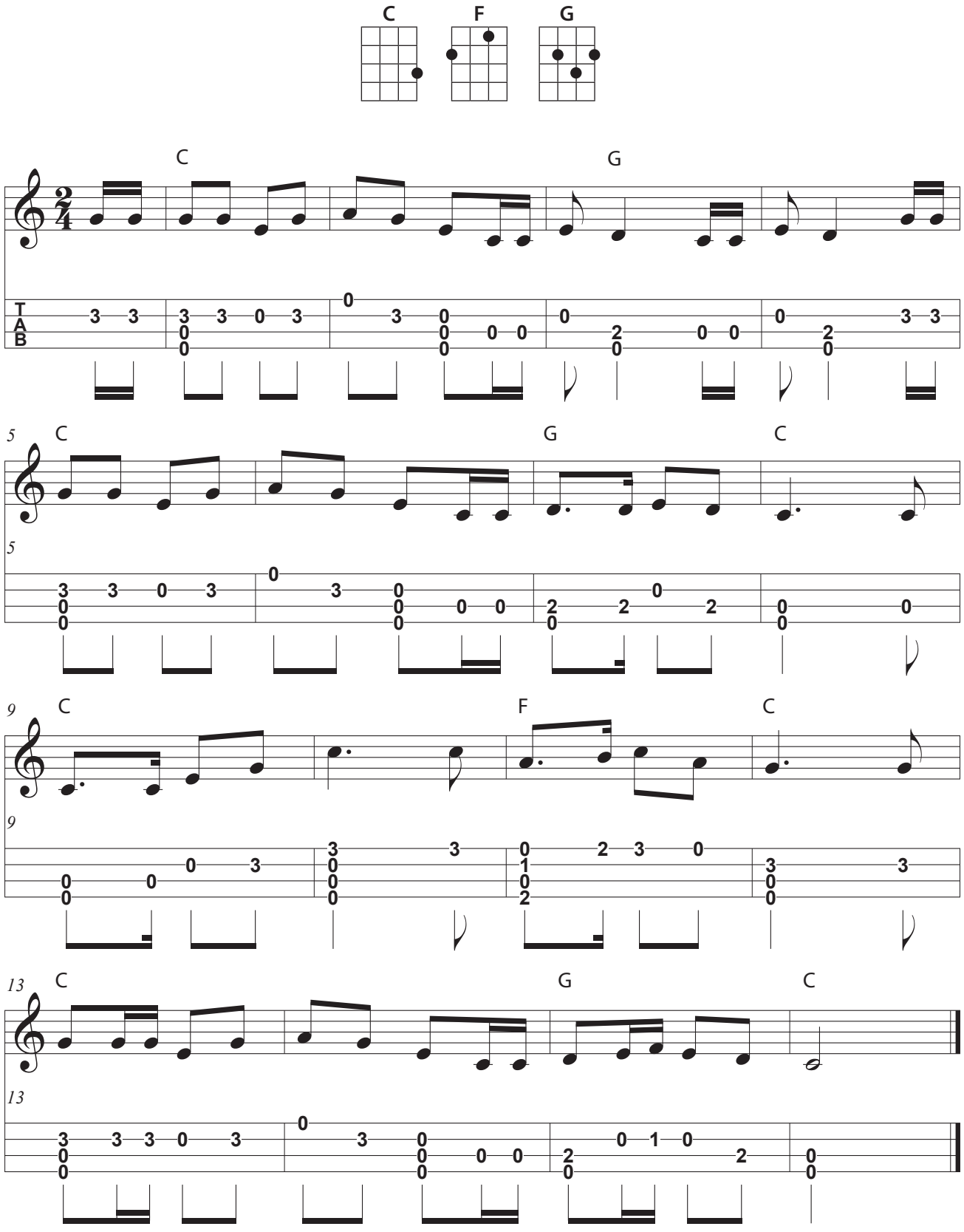




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Camptown Races

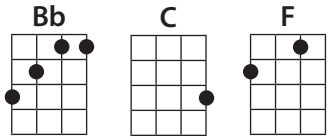
American
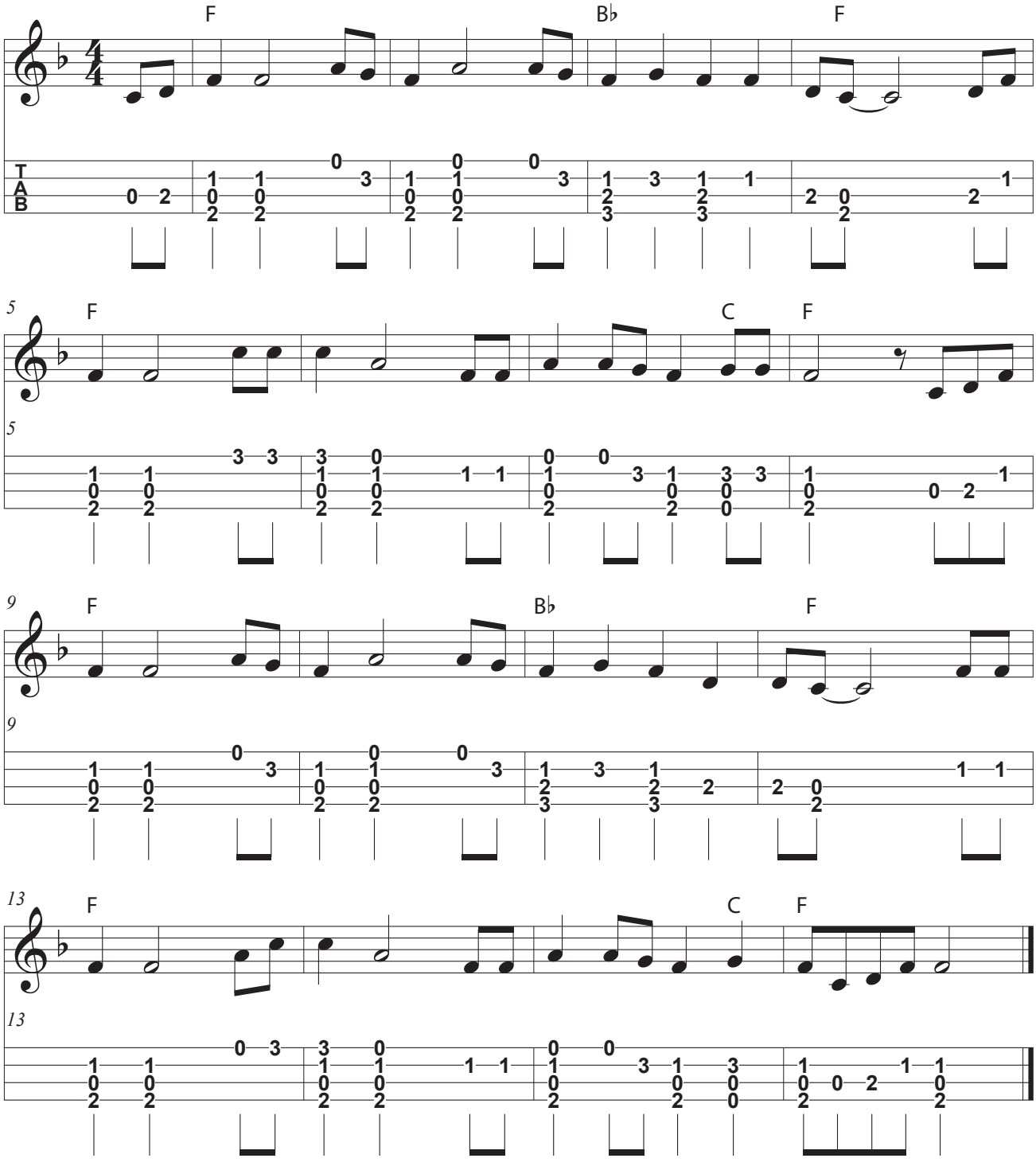


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Can the Circle Be Unbroken

American
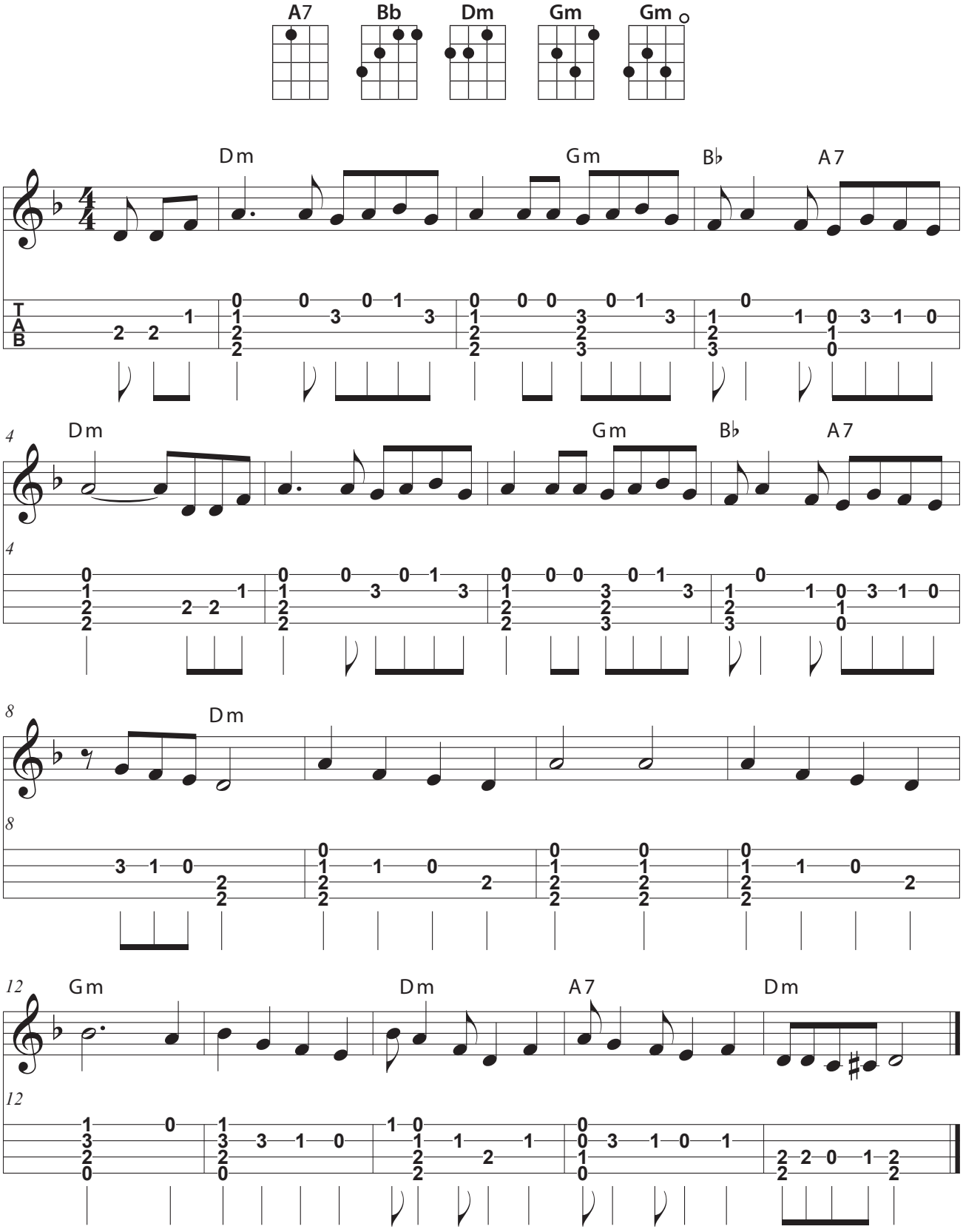




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Cirandeiro
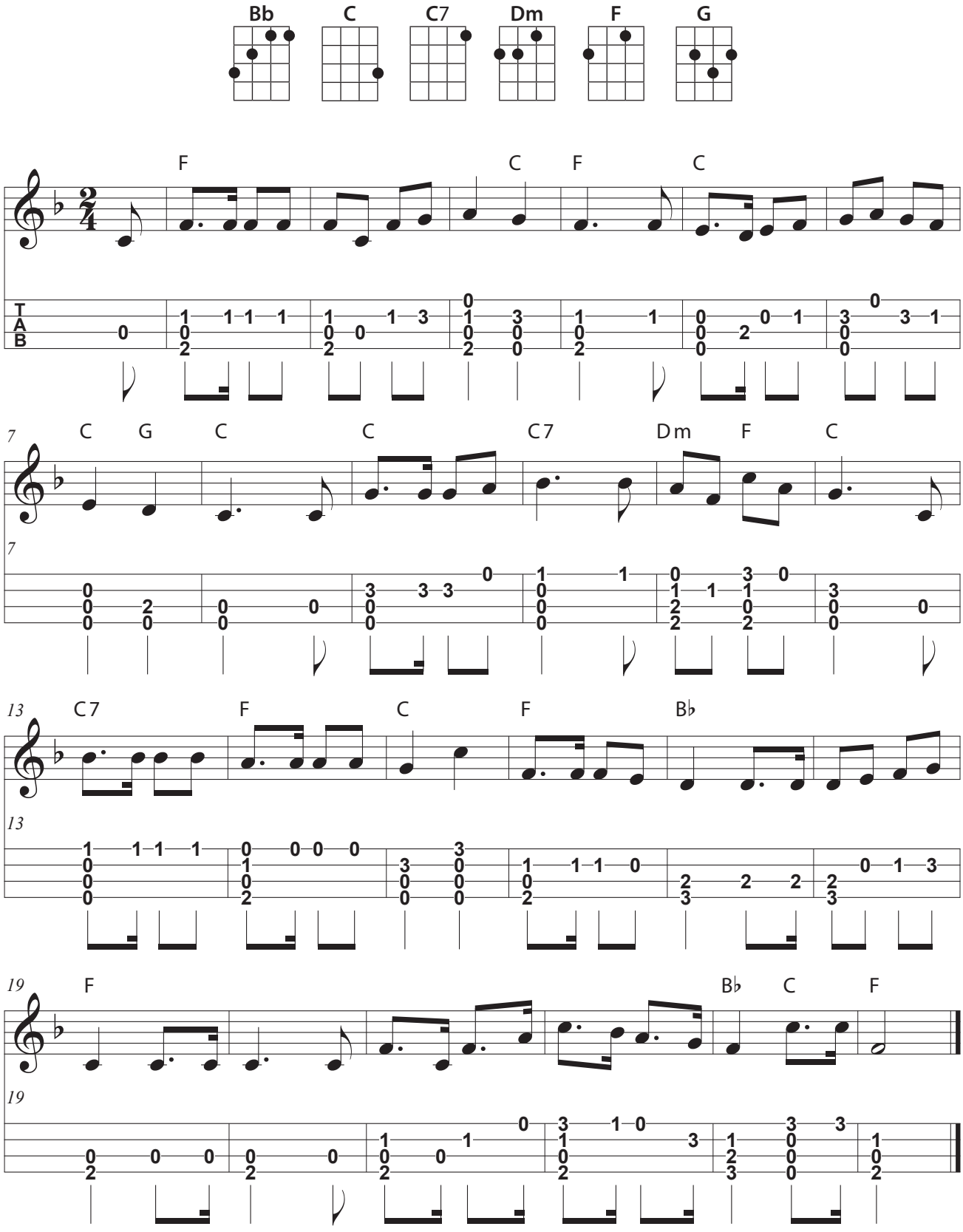
Brazilian



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Crow and the Fox
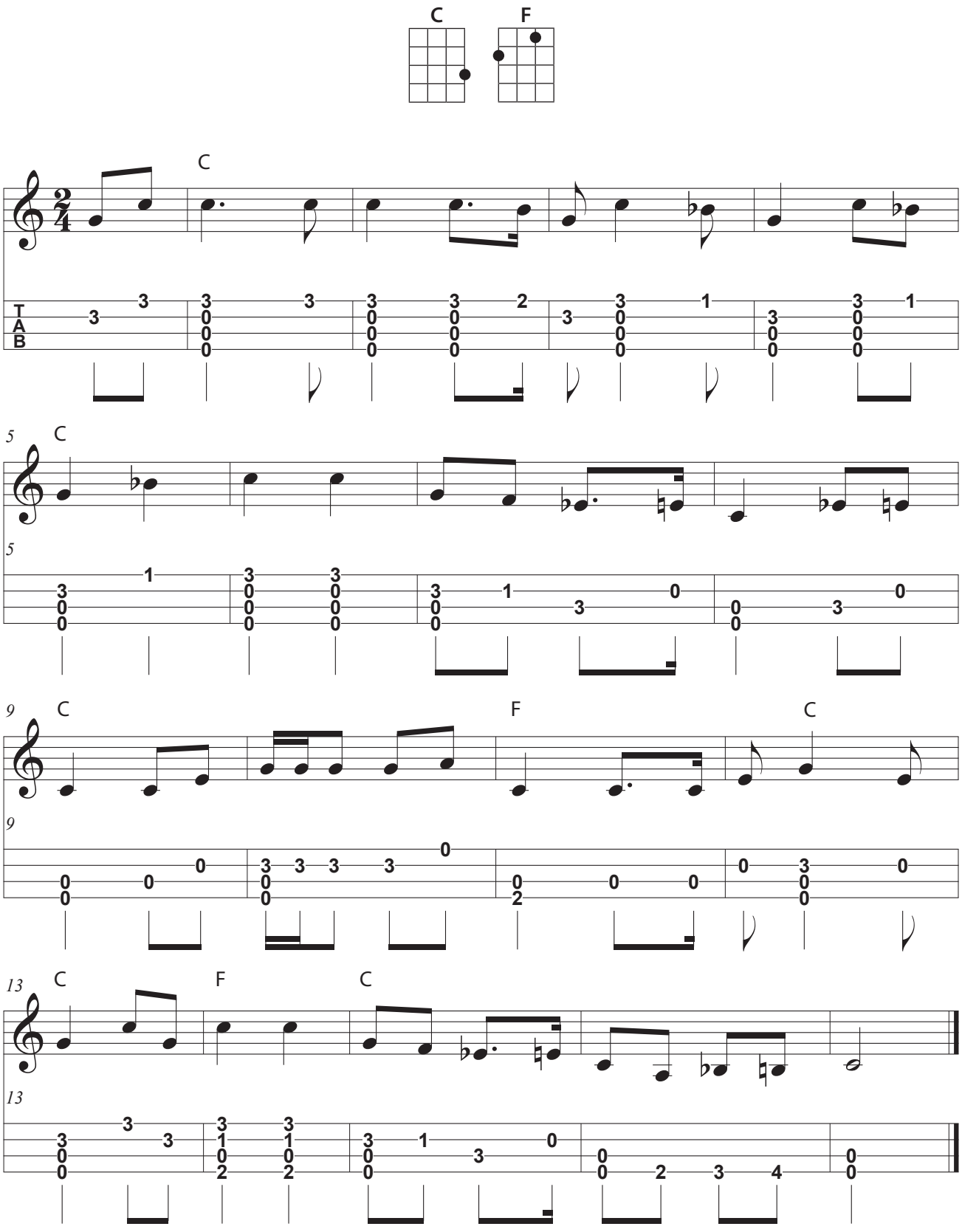
French



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Darling Corey
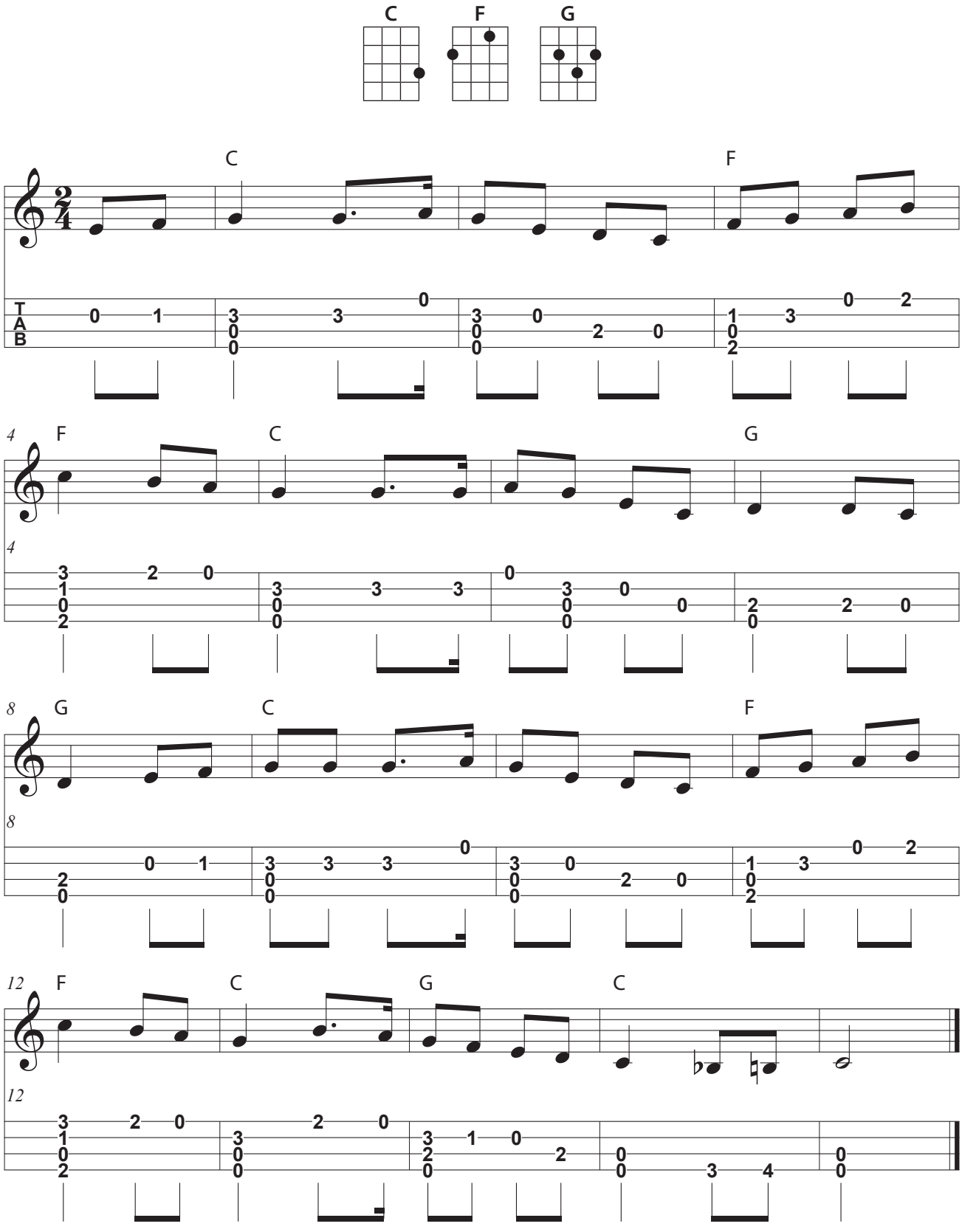
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Darling Nellie Gray

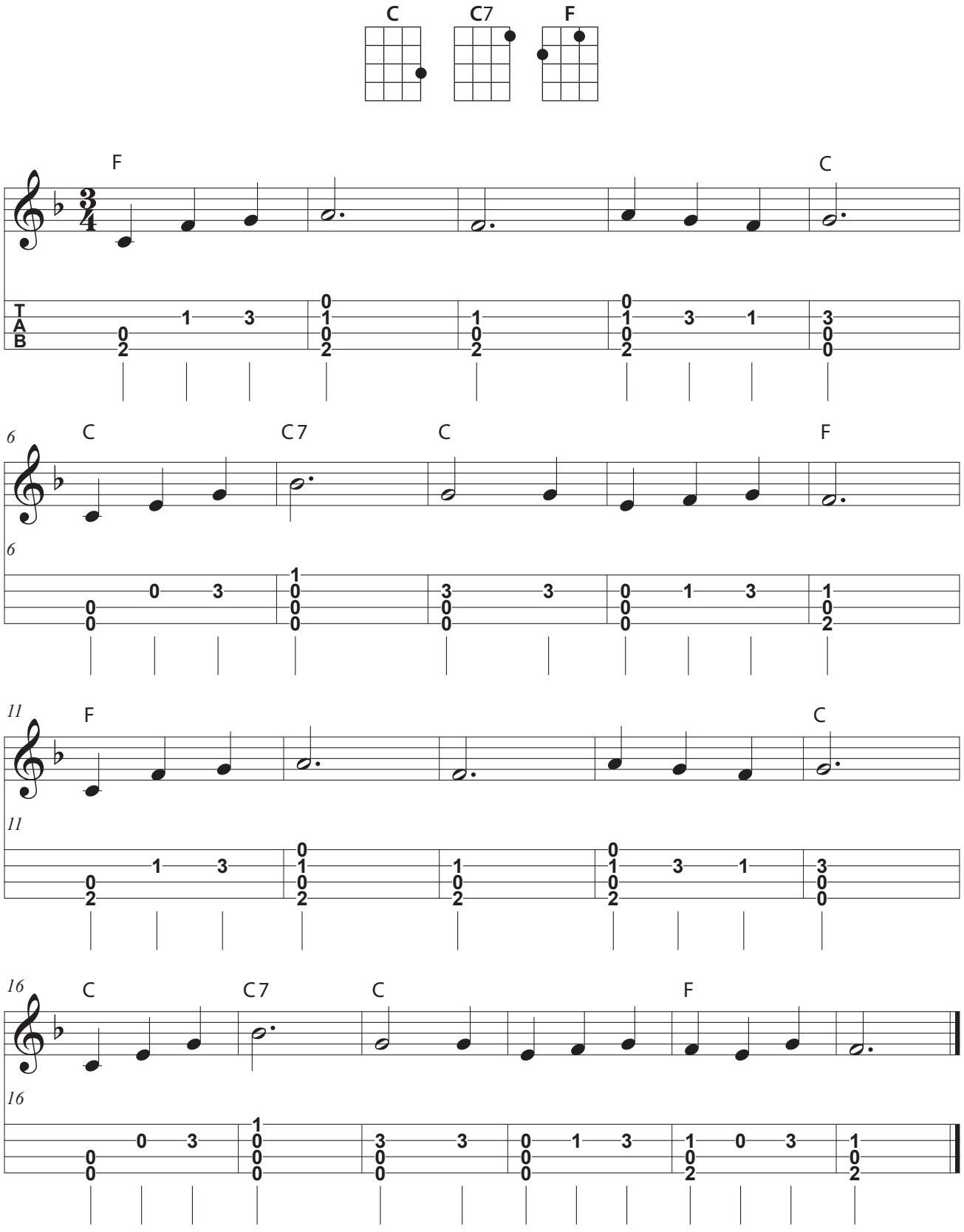
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Down in the Valley
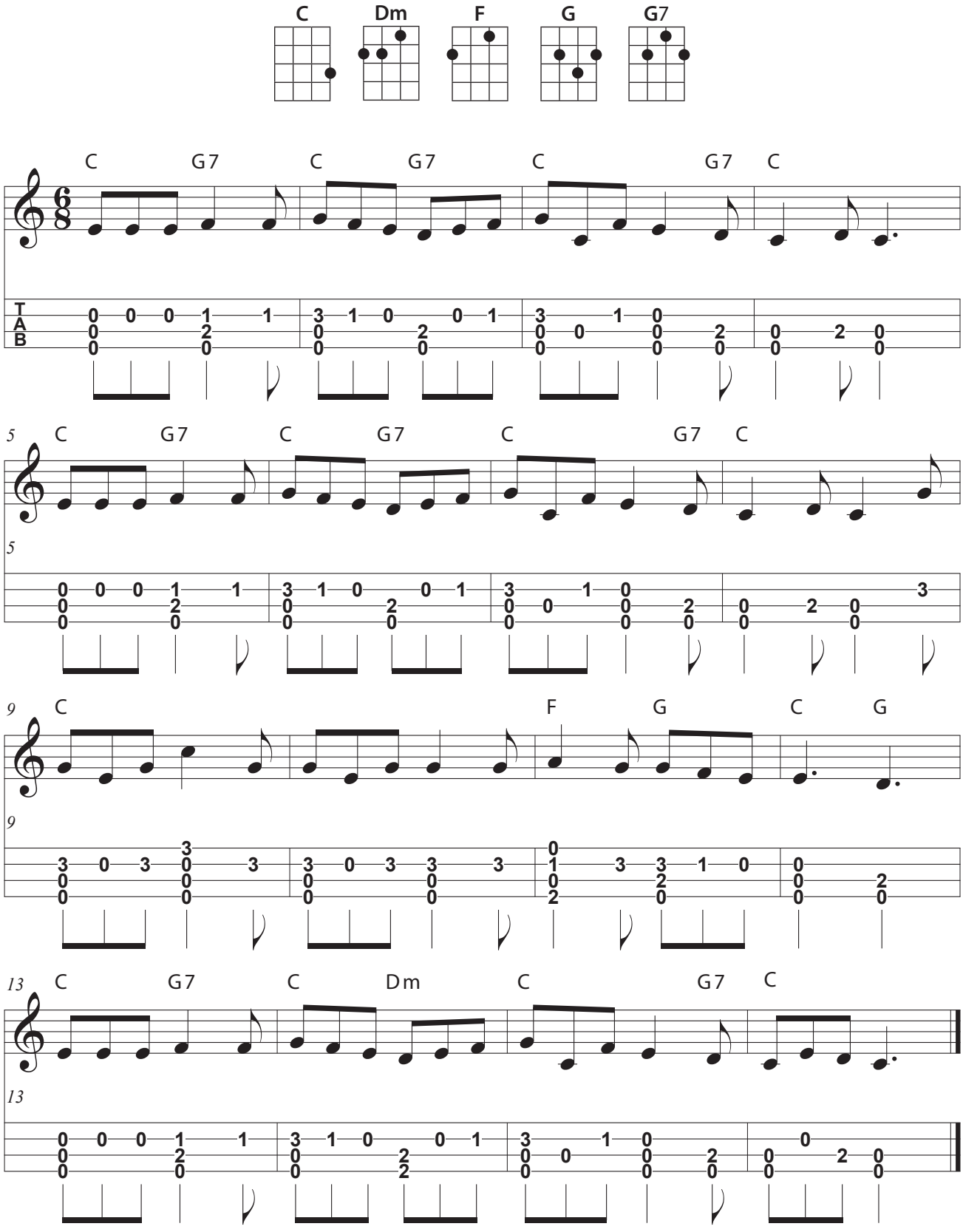
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Drink to Me Only with Thine Eyes
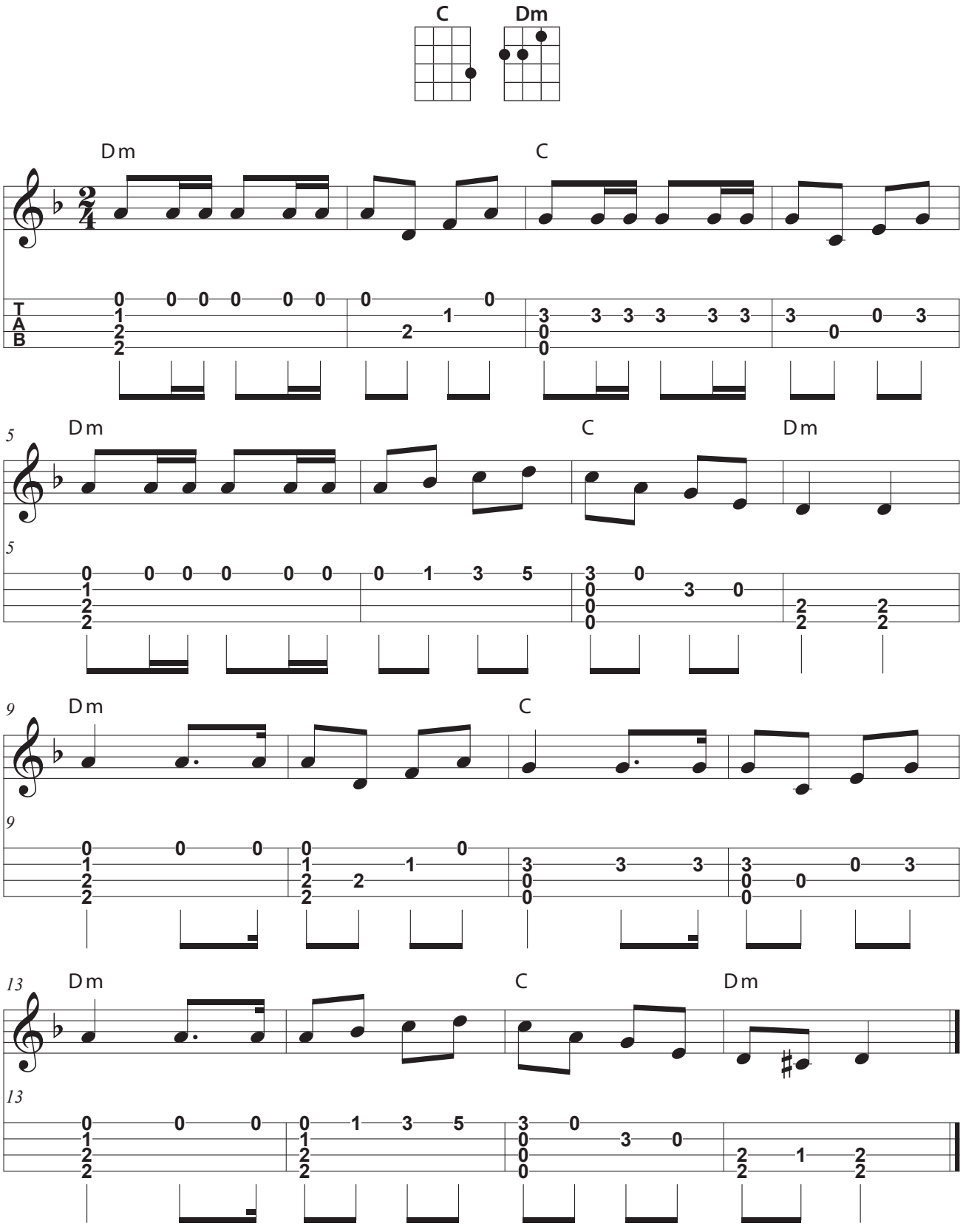
English



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Drunken Sailor
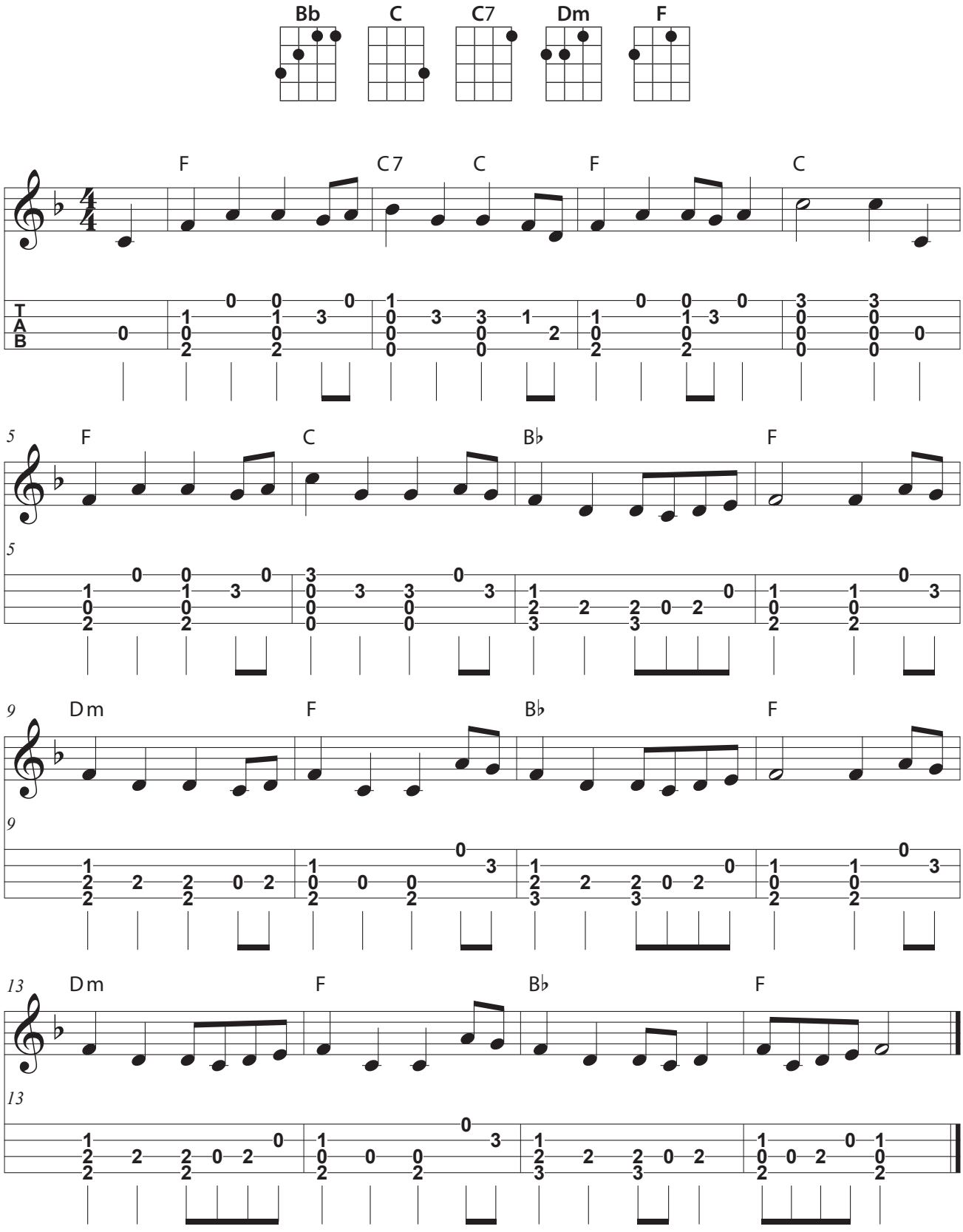
Irish



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Earl of Errol
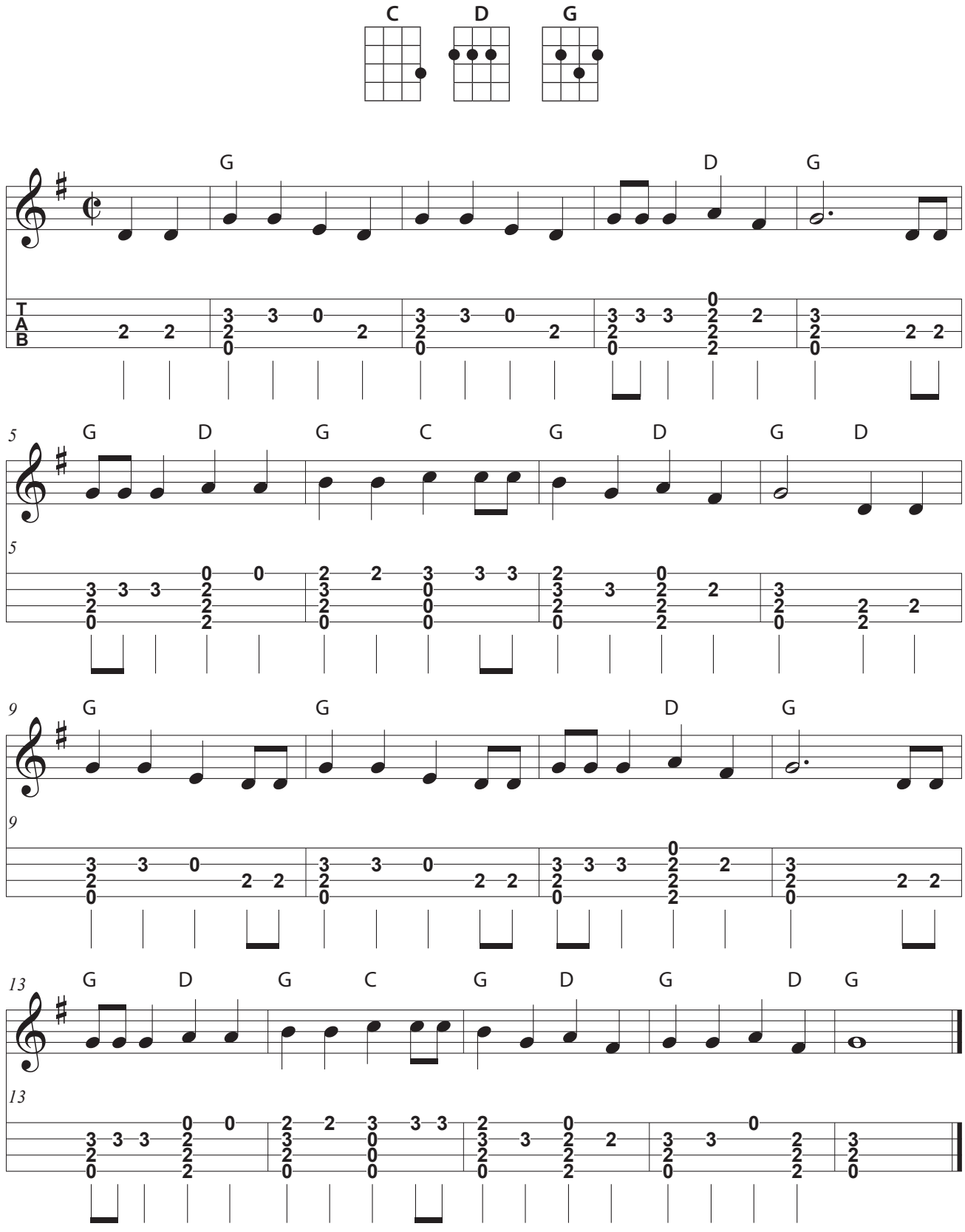
Scottish



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Erie Canal
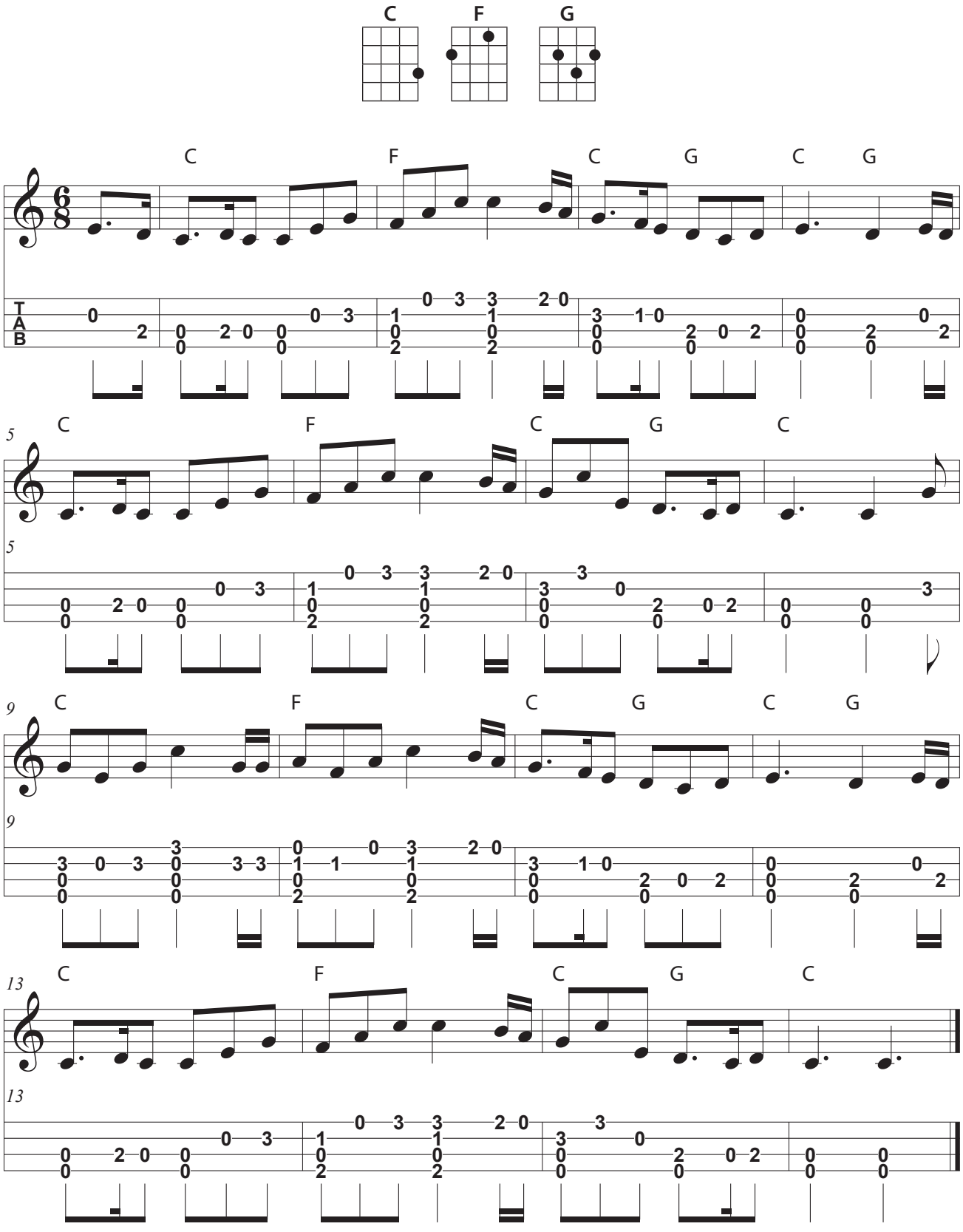
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Fair Harvard
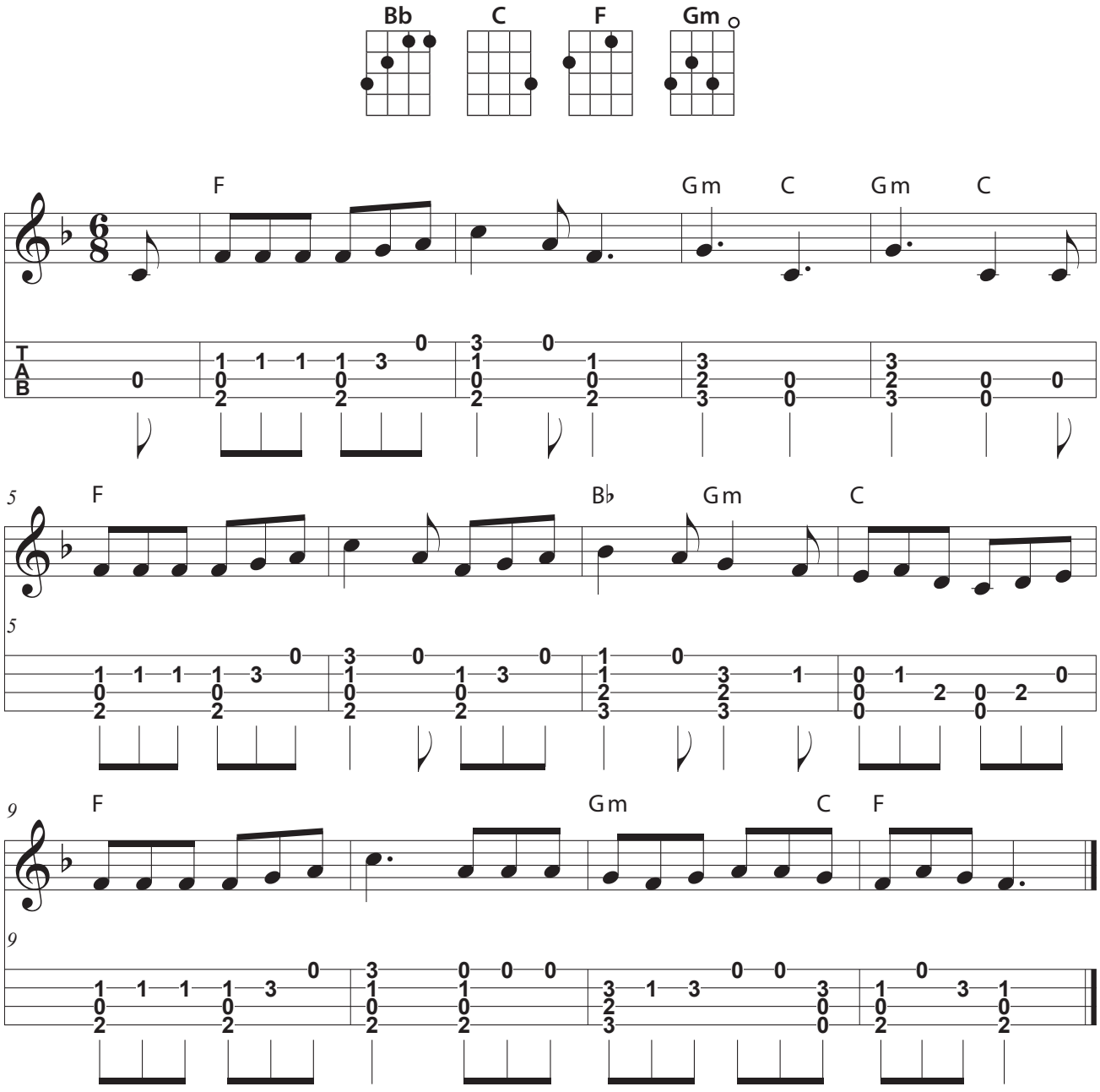
Irish



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Farmer's Daughter
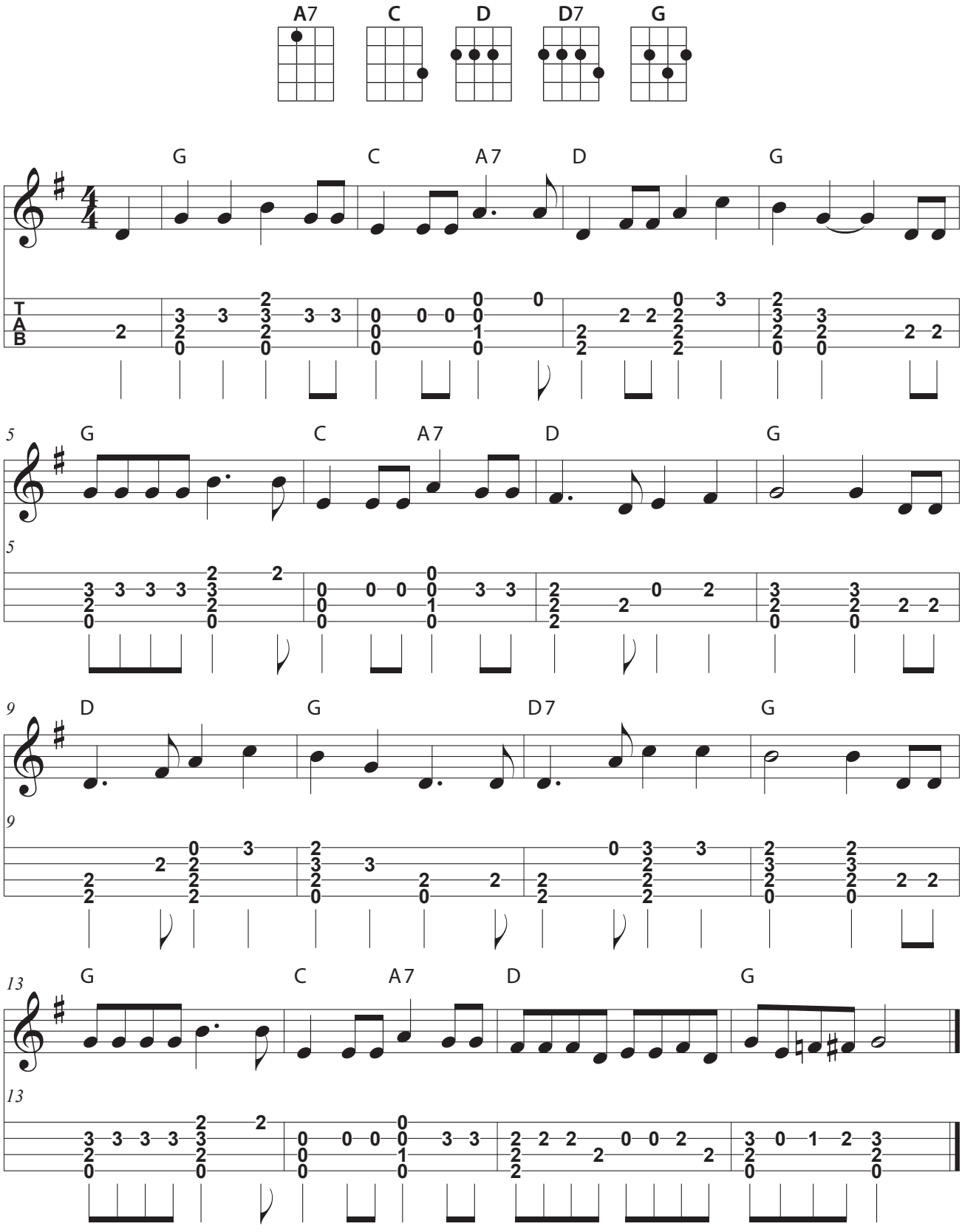
English



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Foggy, Foggy Dew
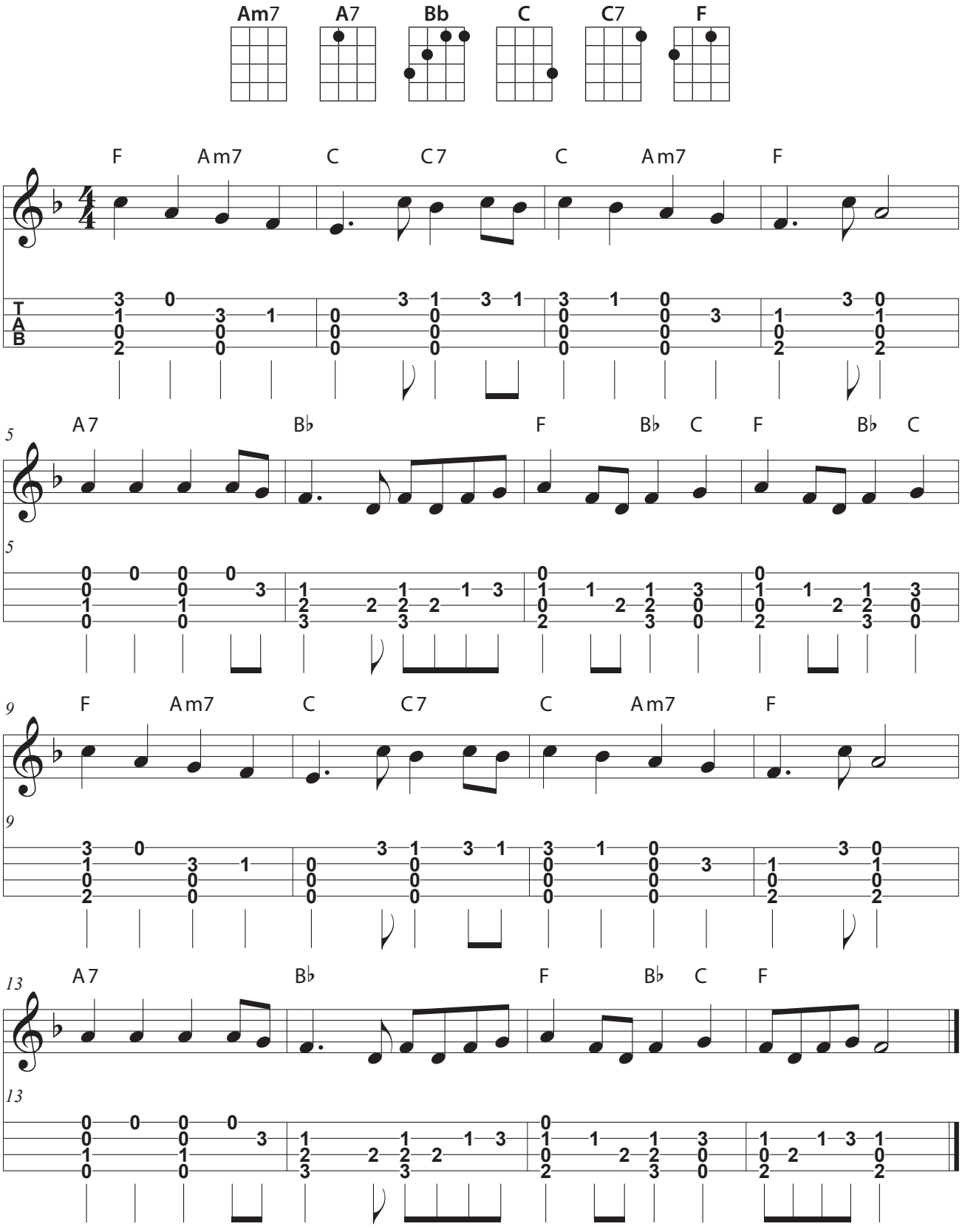
English



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Freight Train

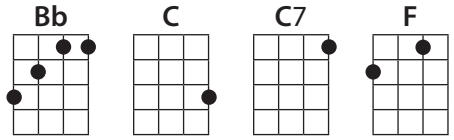
American
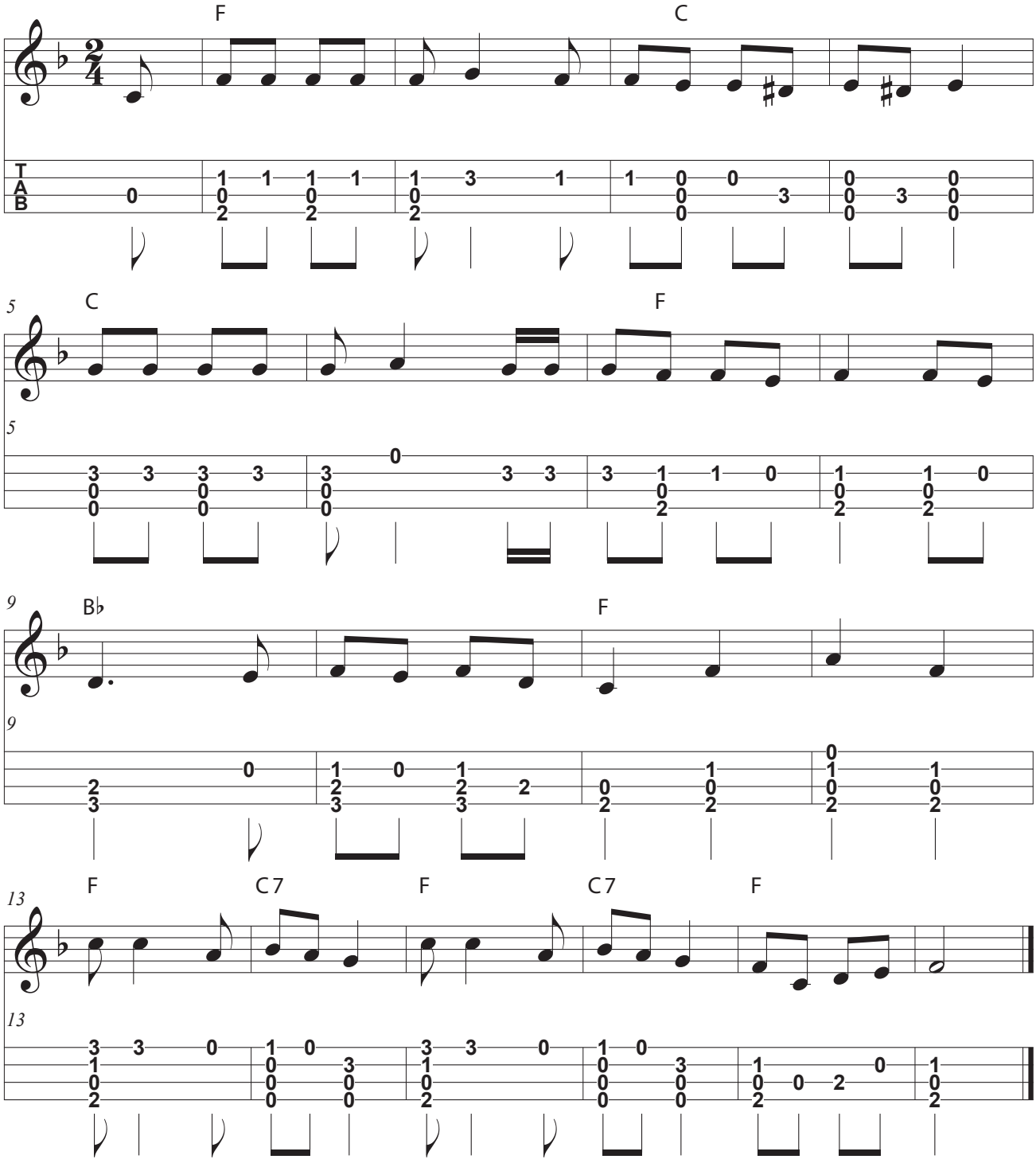


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Gee, but I Want to Go Home

American
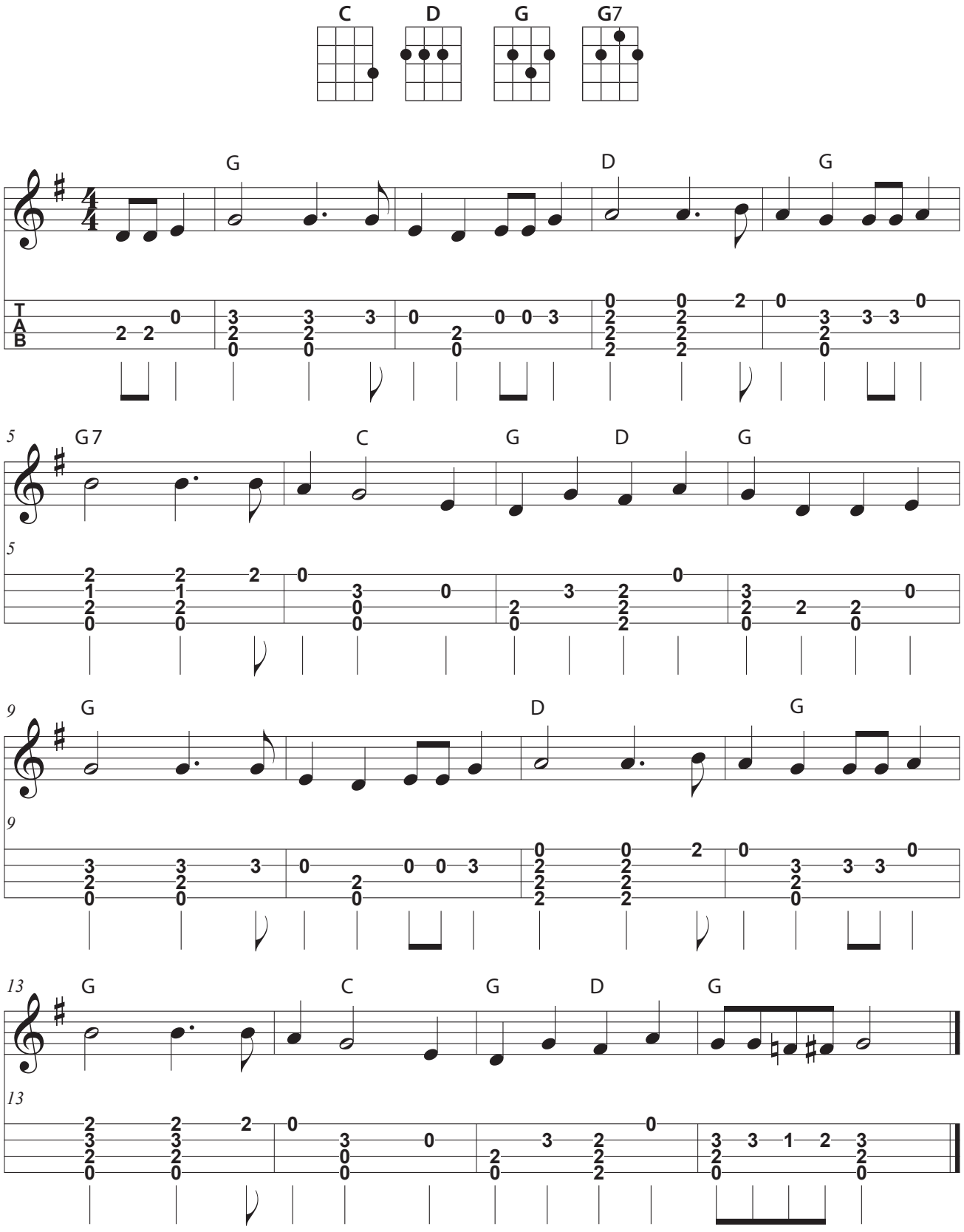




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Give Me That Old Time Religion

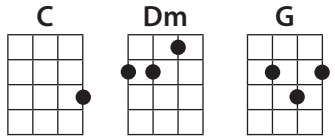
American
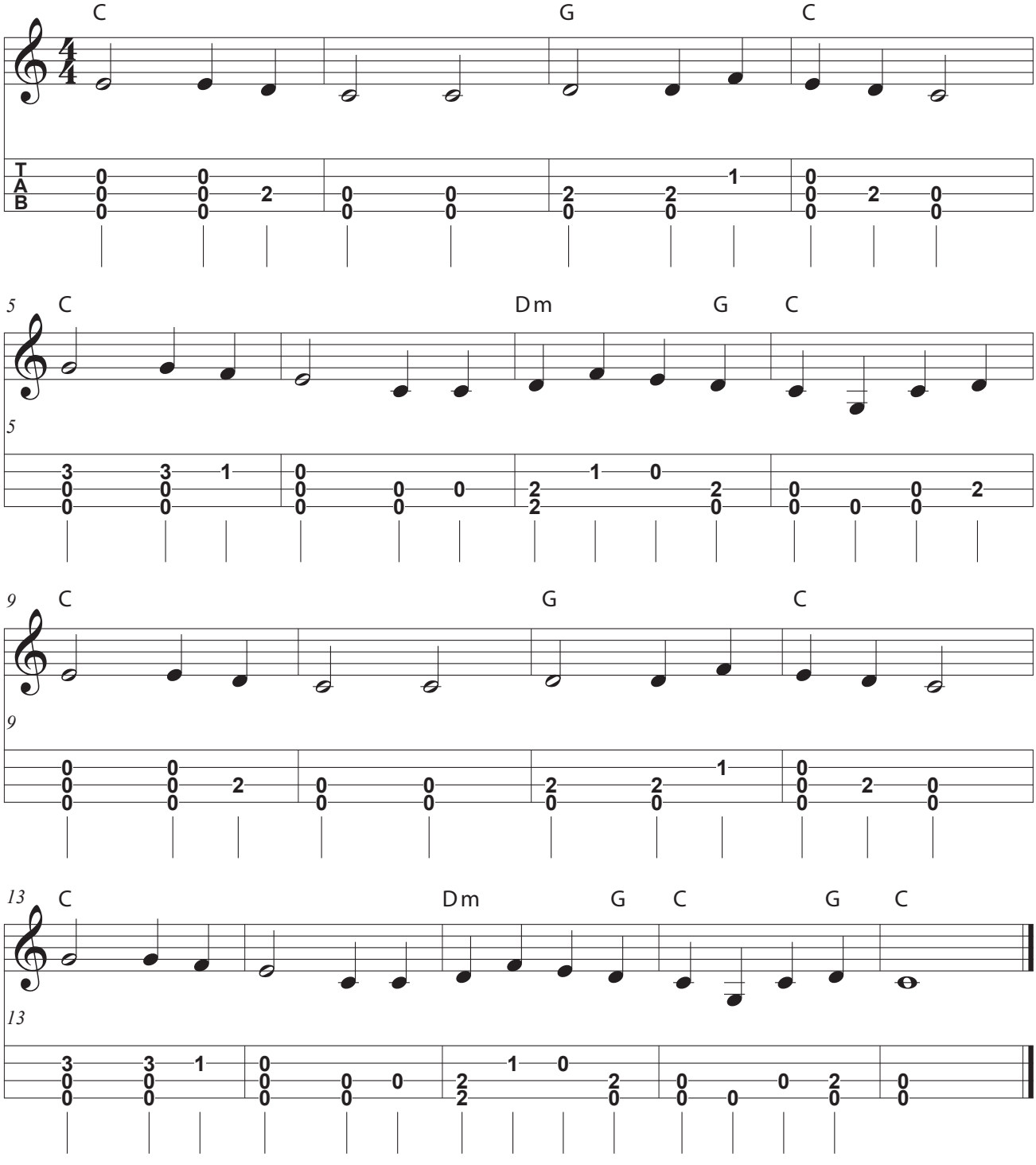


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Go Tell Aunt Rhody

American
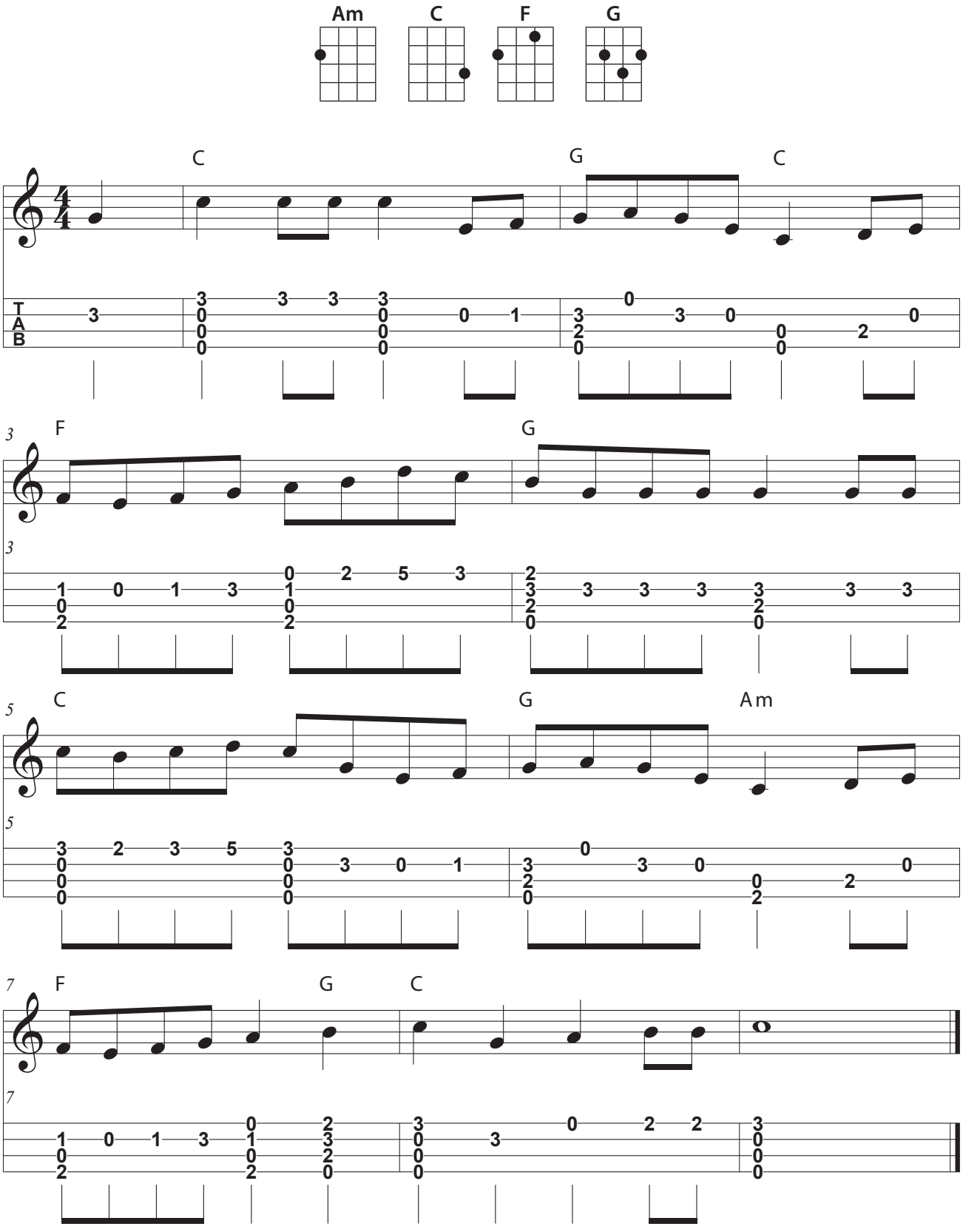




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Golden Vanity

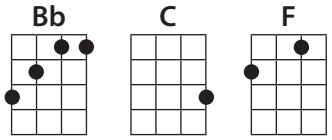
English
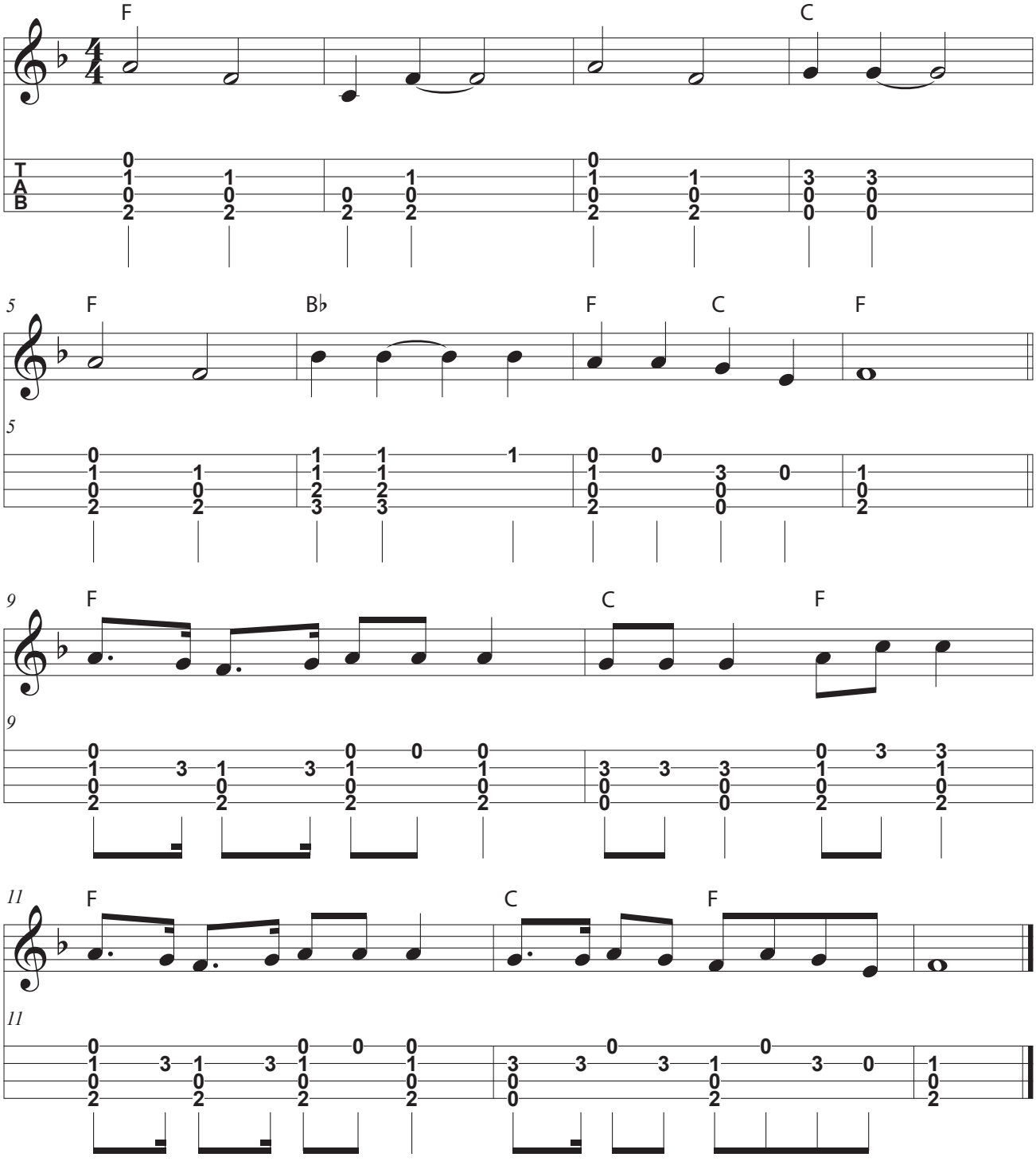


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Goodnight, Ladies

American
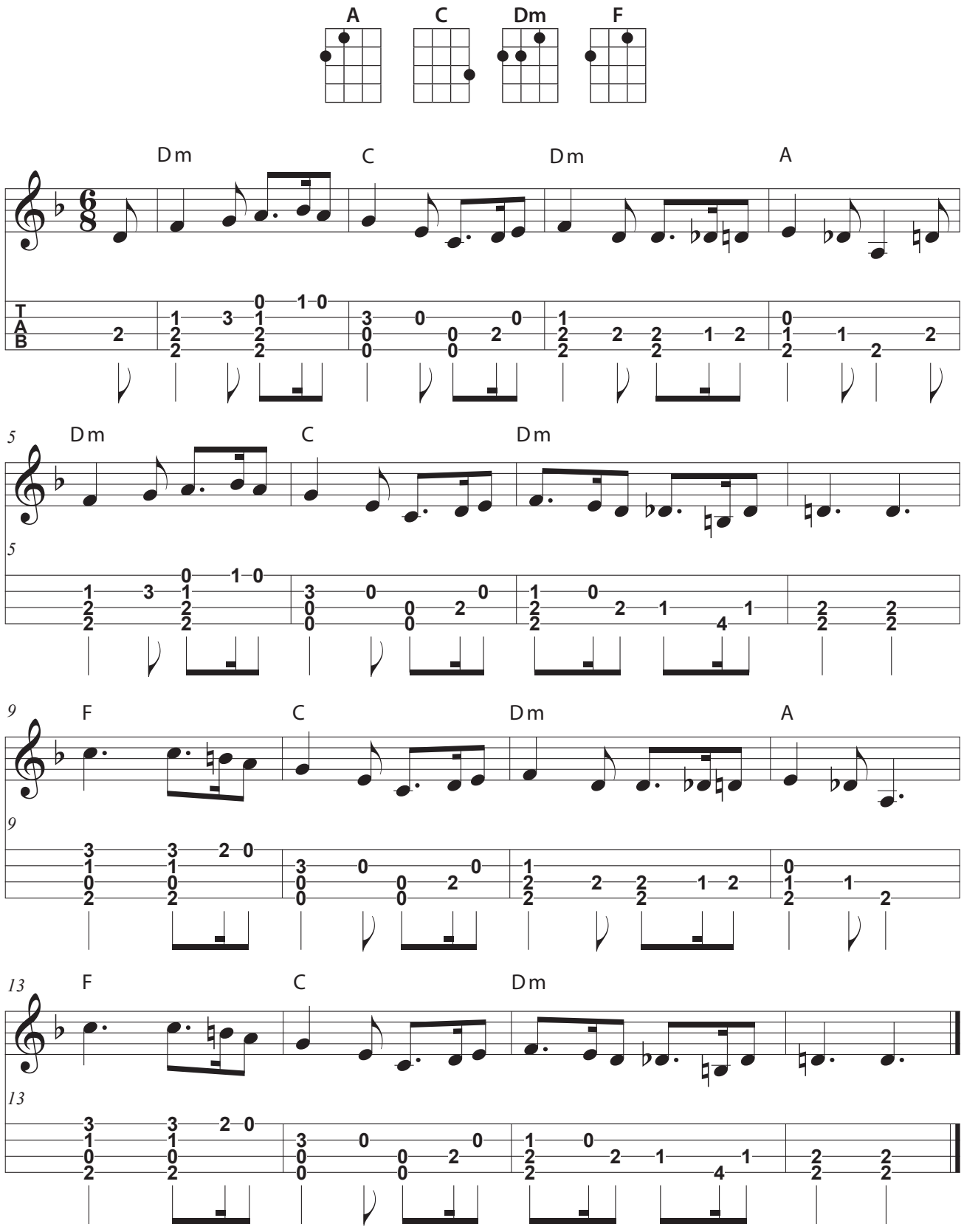




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Greensleeves
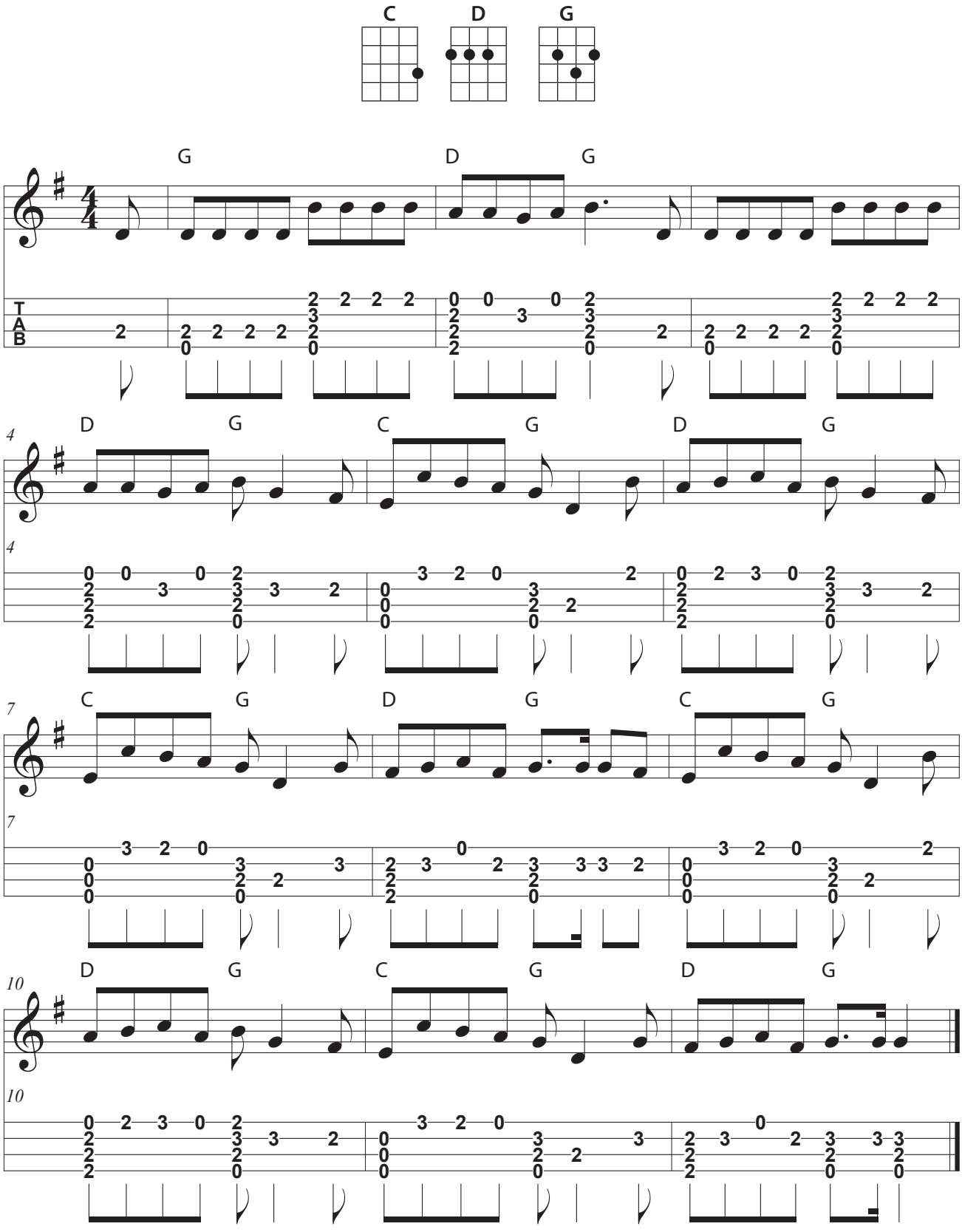
English



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Grind the Meal
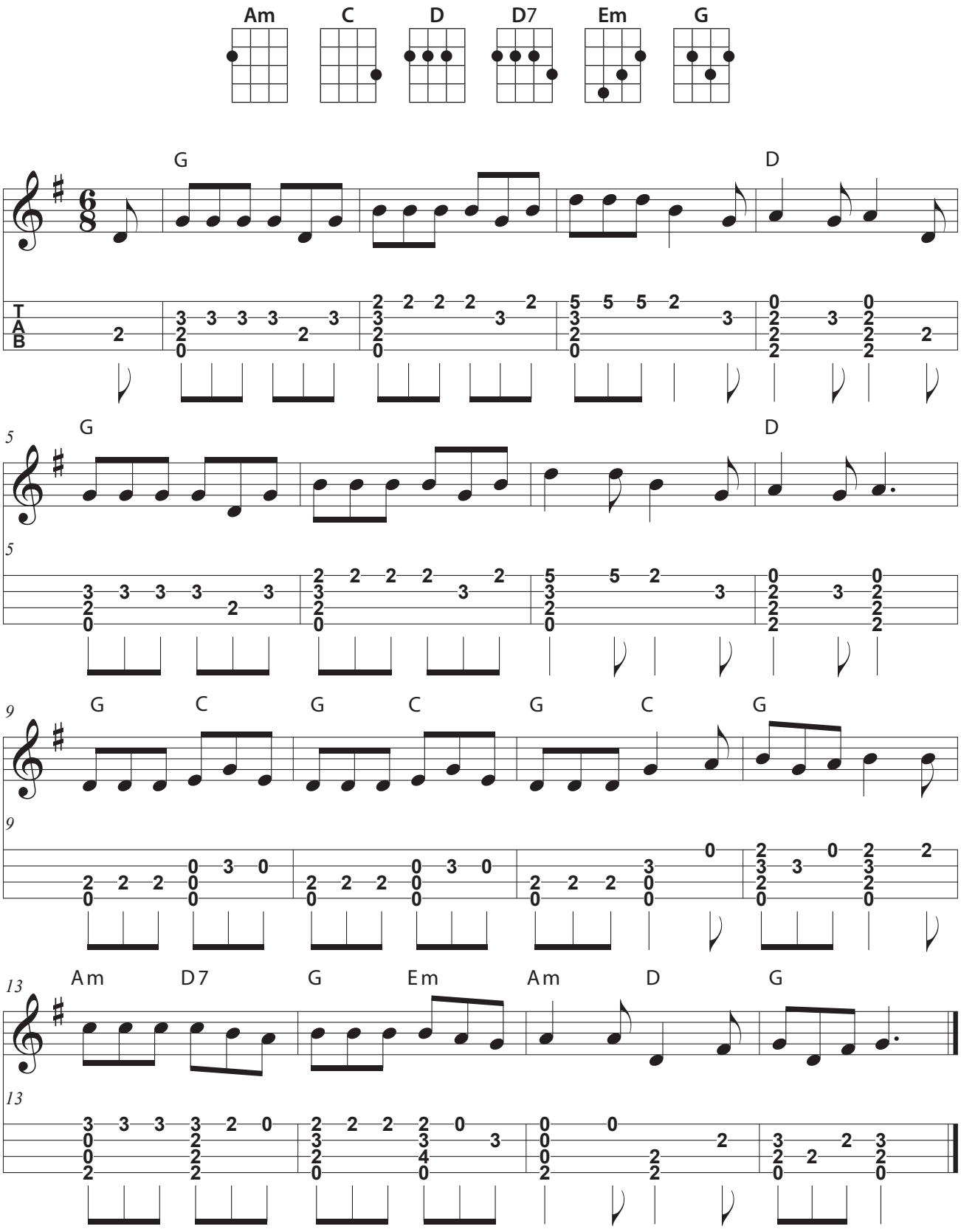
African



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Hard Luck
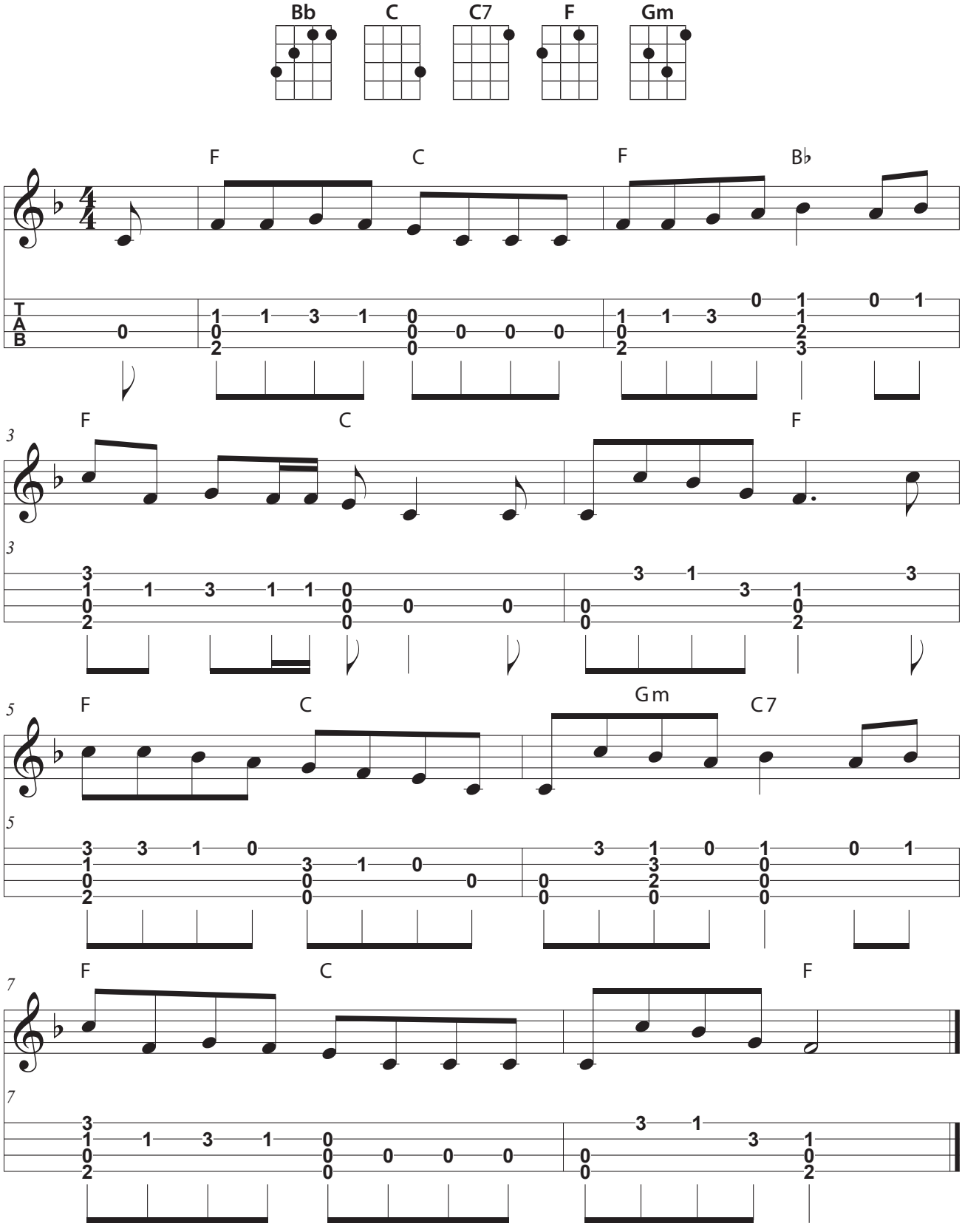
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Honest Ploughman
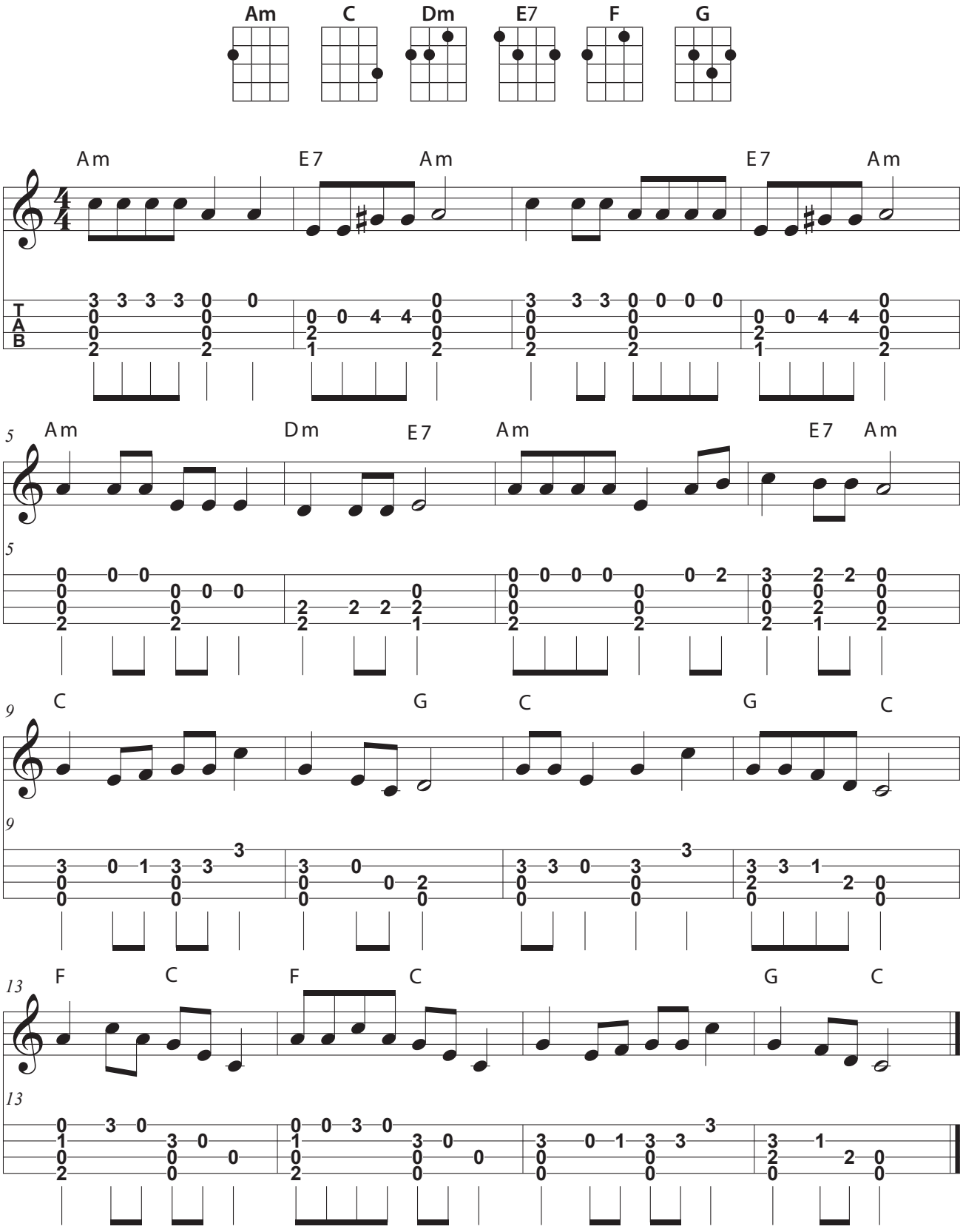
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Hudson River Steamboat
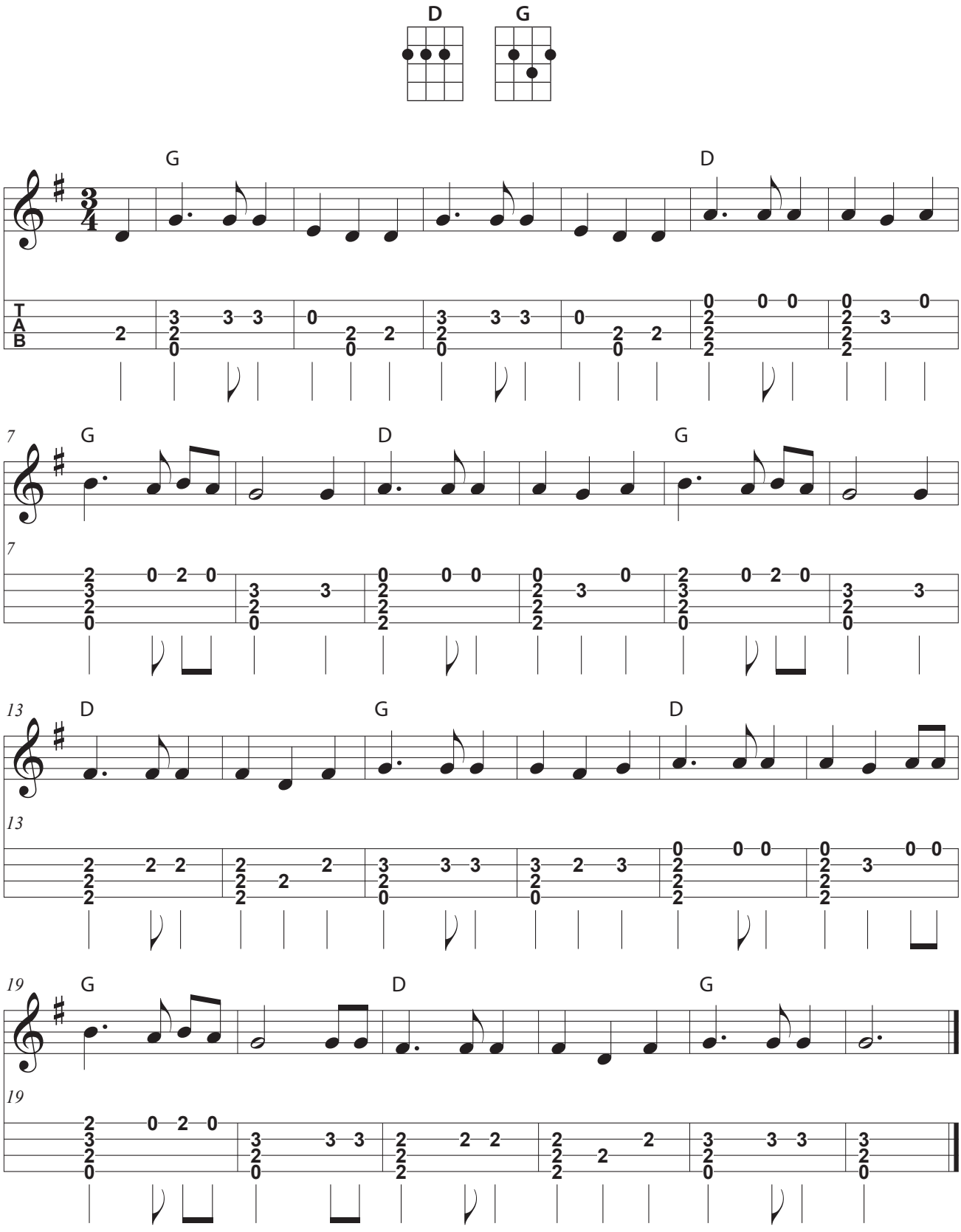
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

I Ride Old Paint

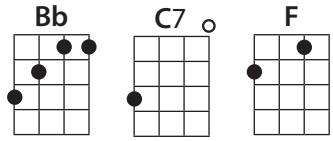
American
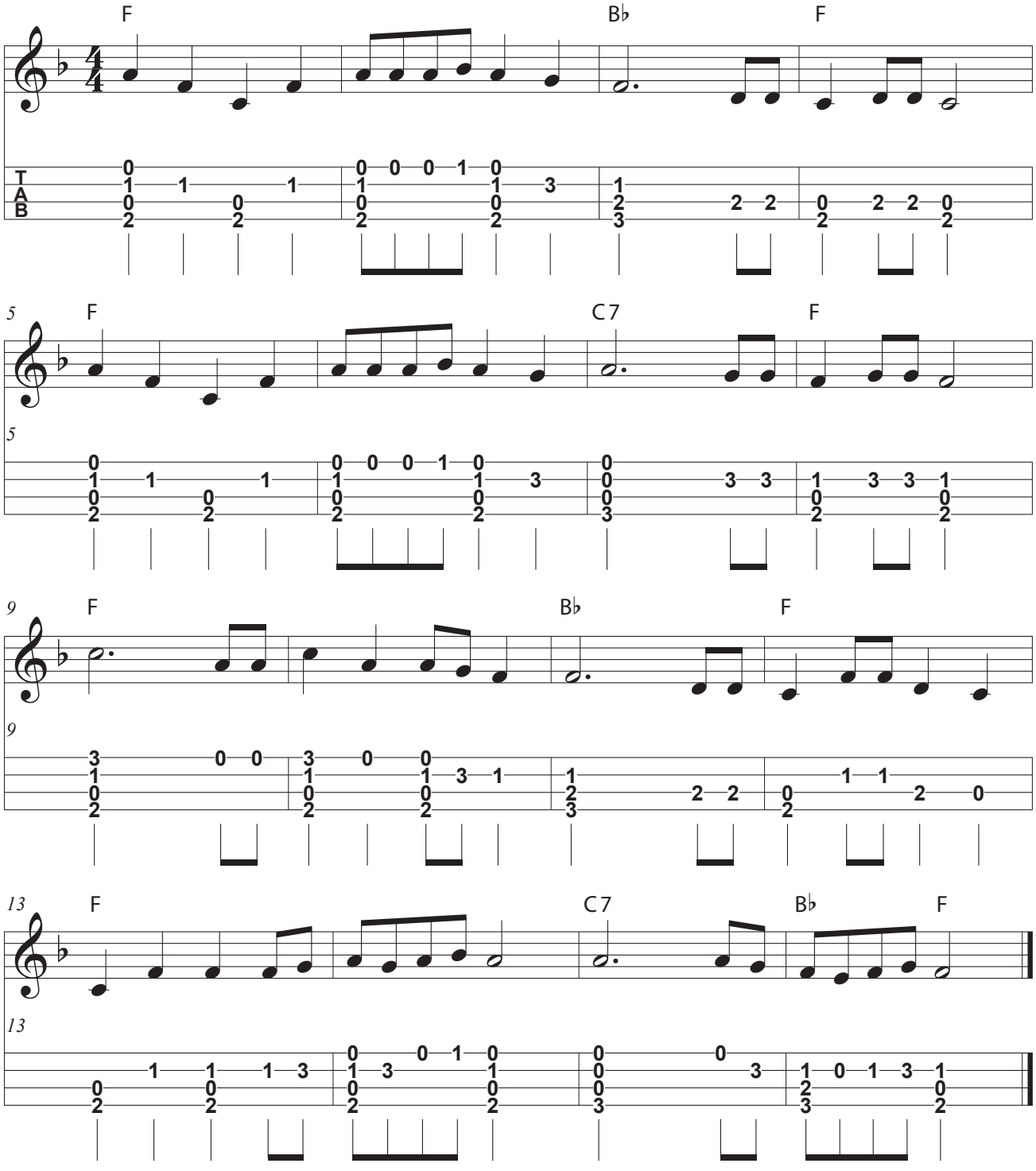


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

I'll Fly Away

American
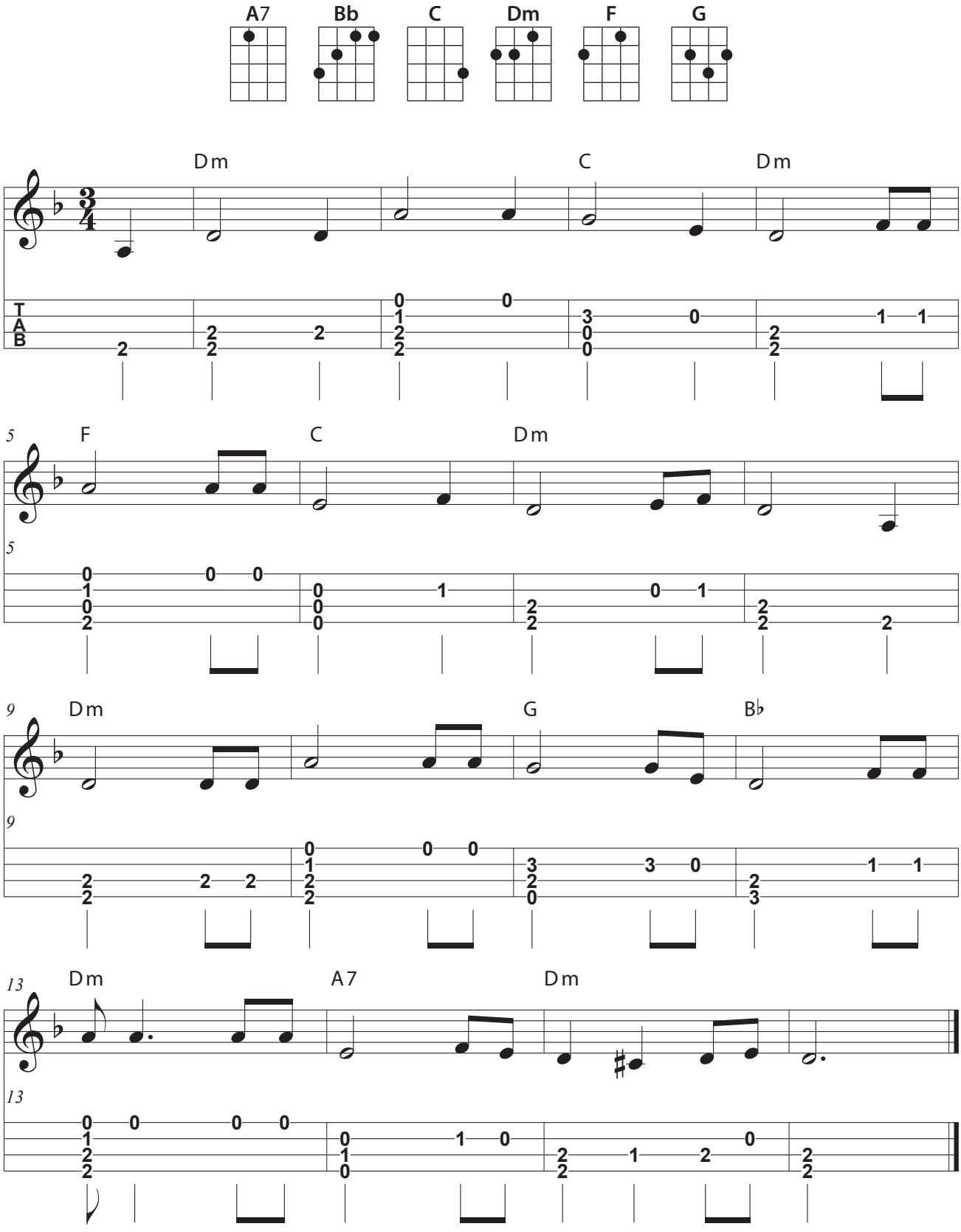




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

In the Pines
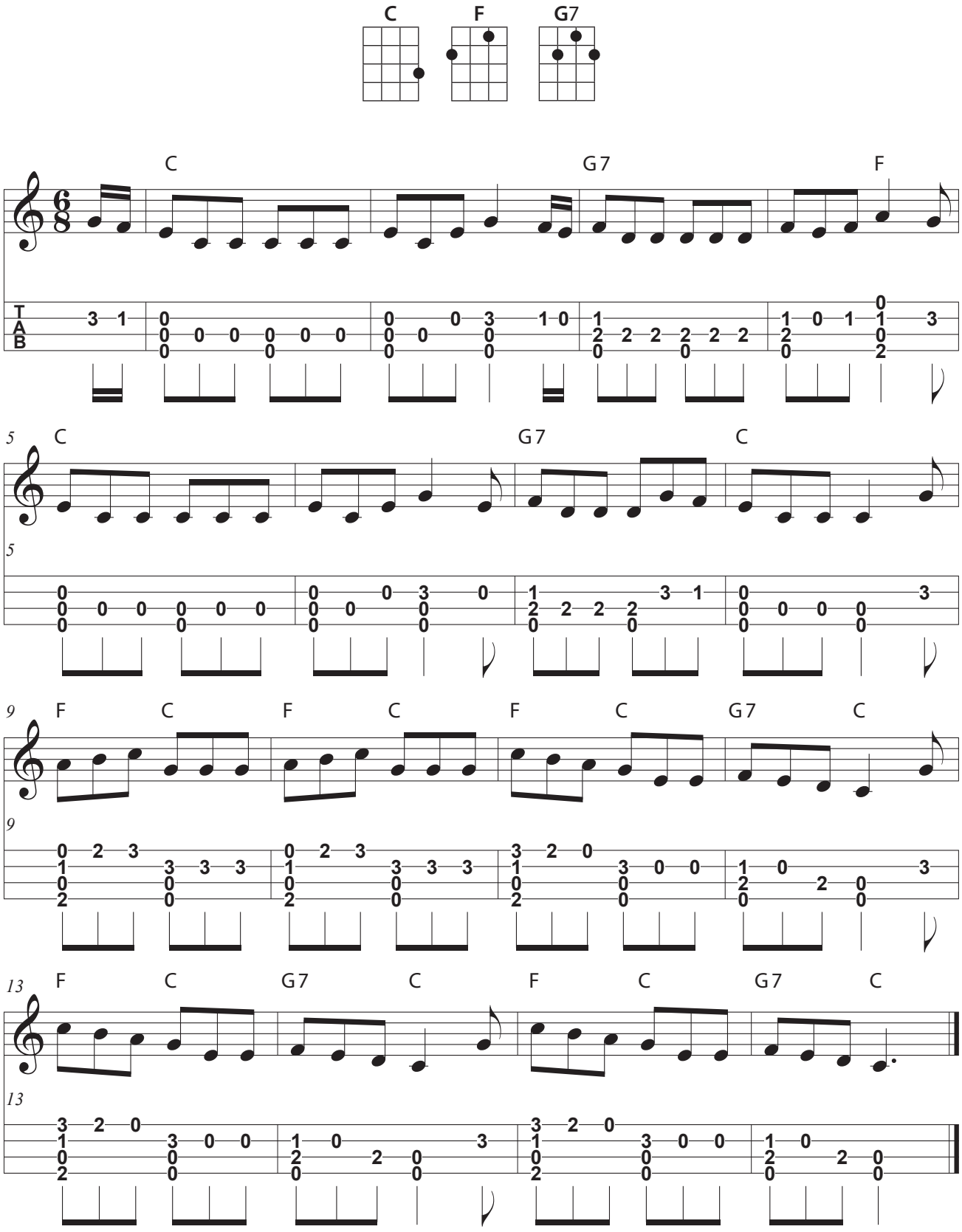
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Irishman's Epistle

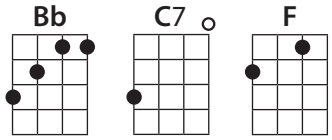
Irish
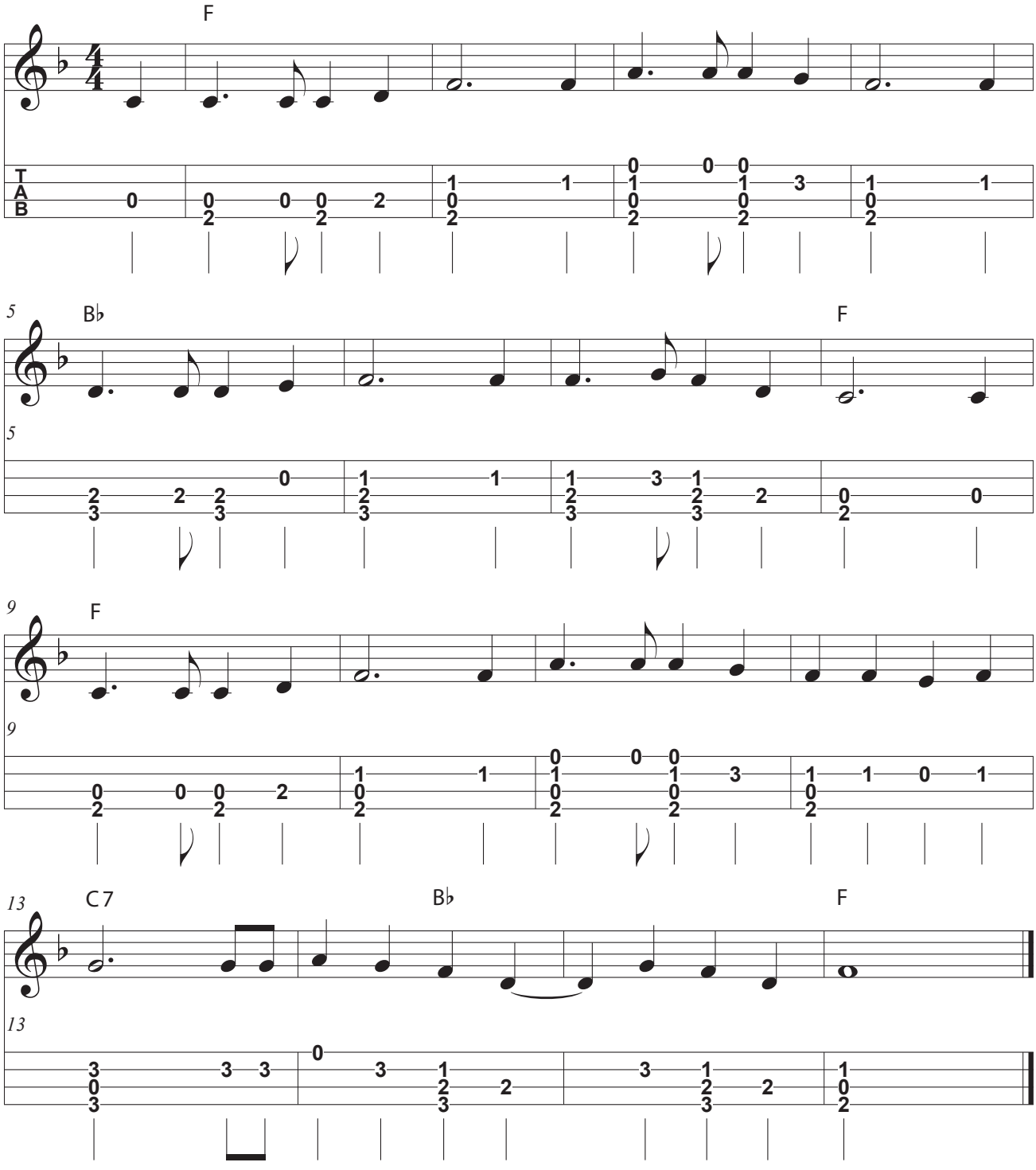


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

It Takes a Worried Man

American
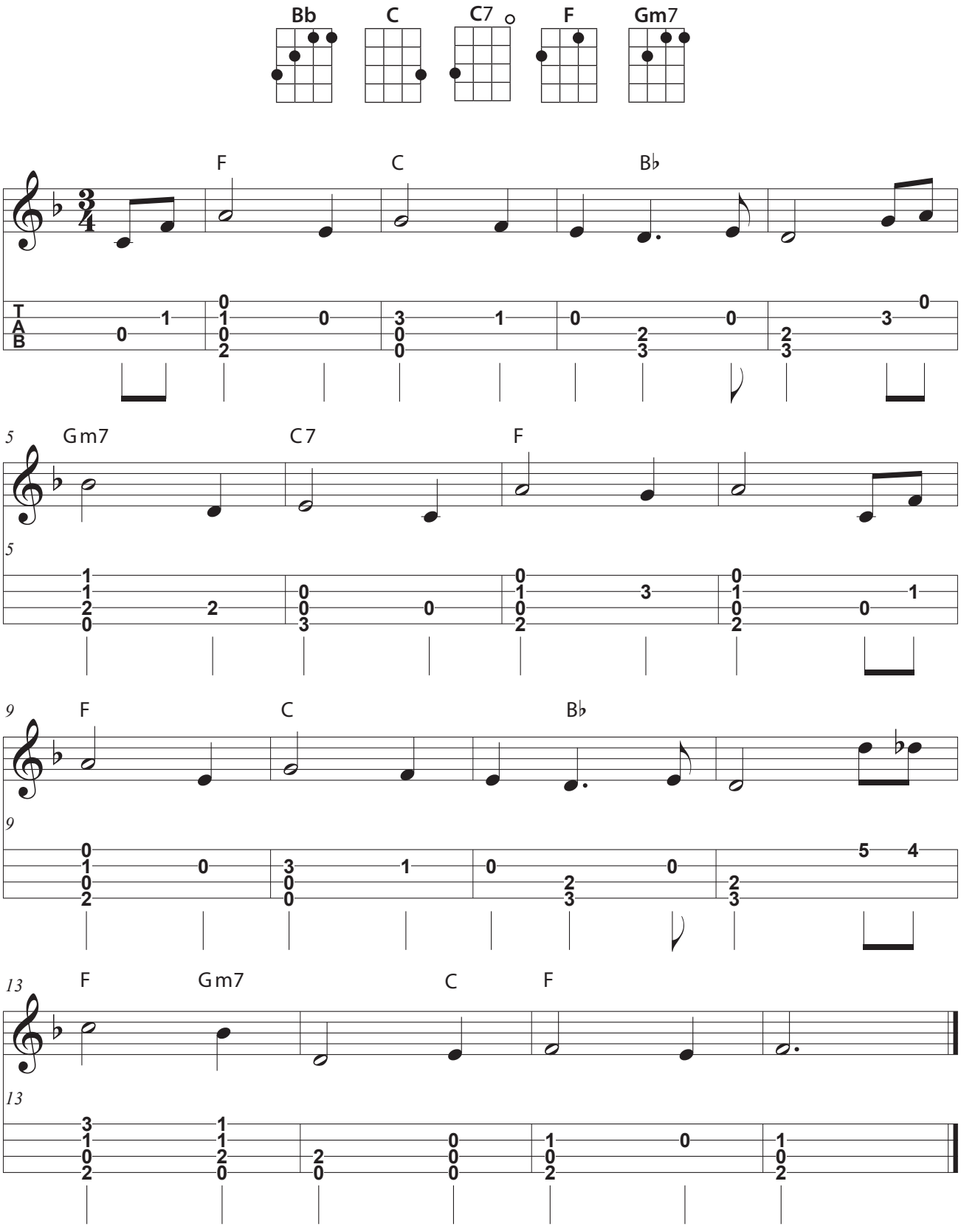




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

It's the Same the World Over
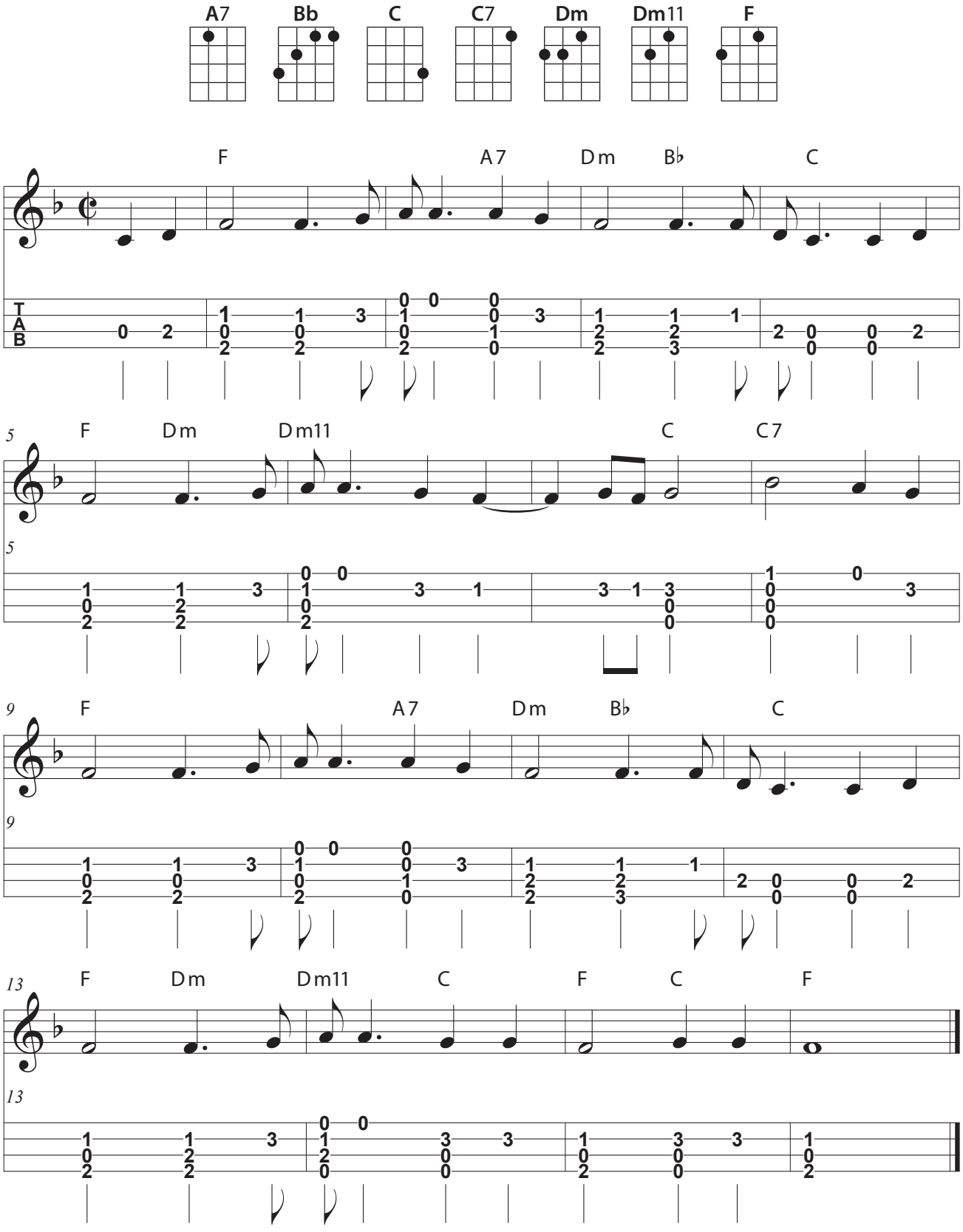
English



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

I've Got Peace Like a River
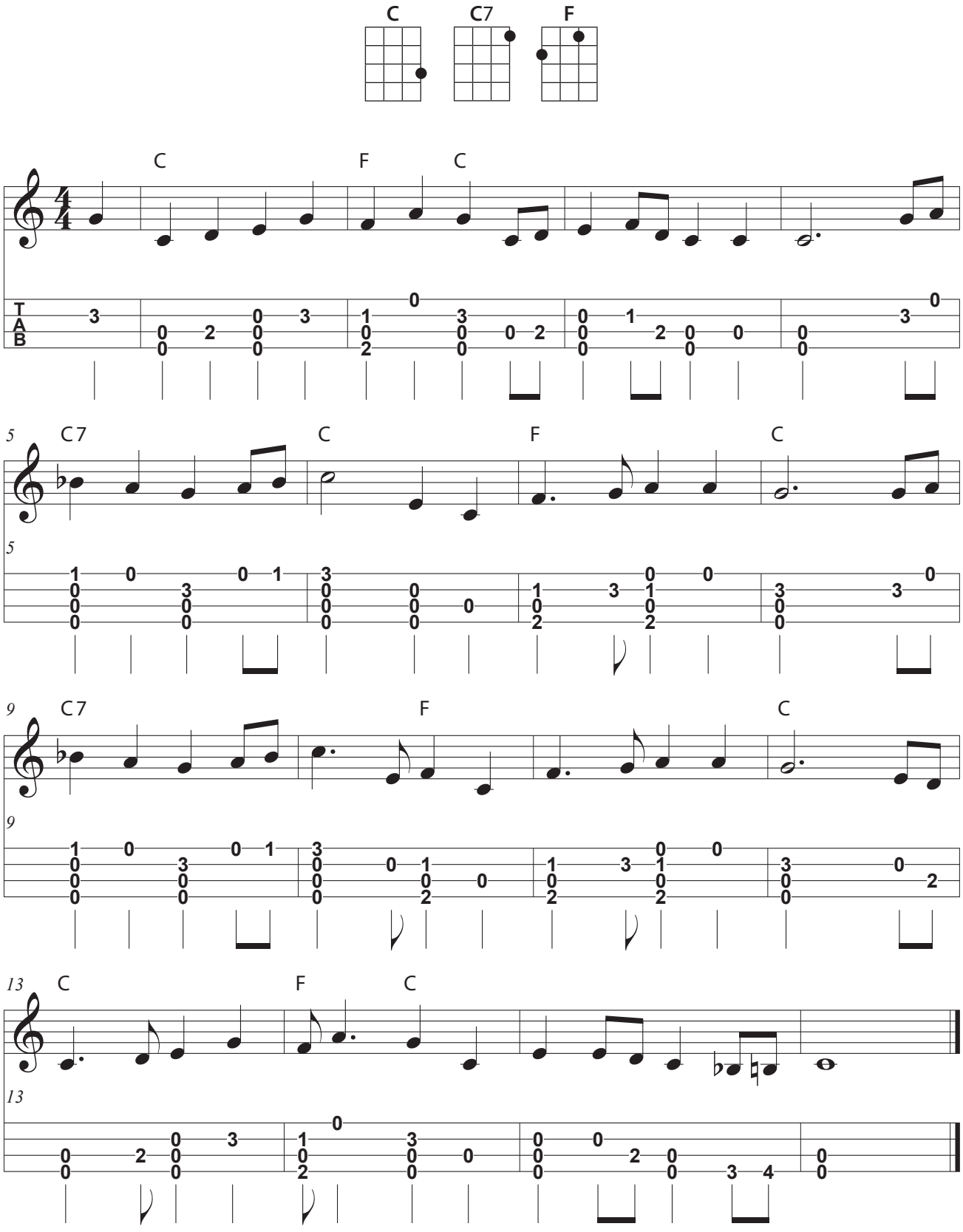
African American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Jam on Gerry's Rocks
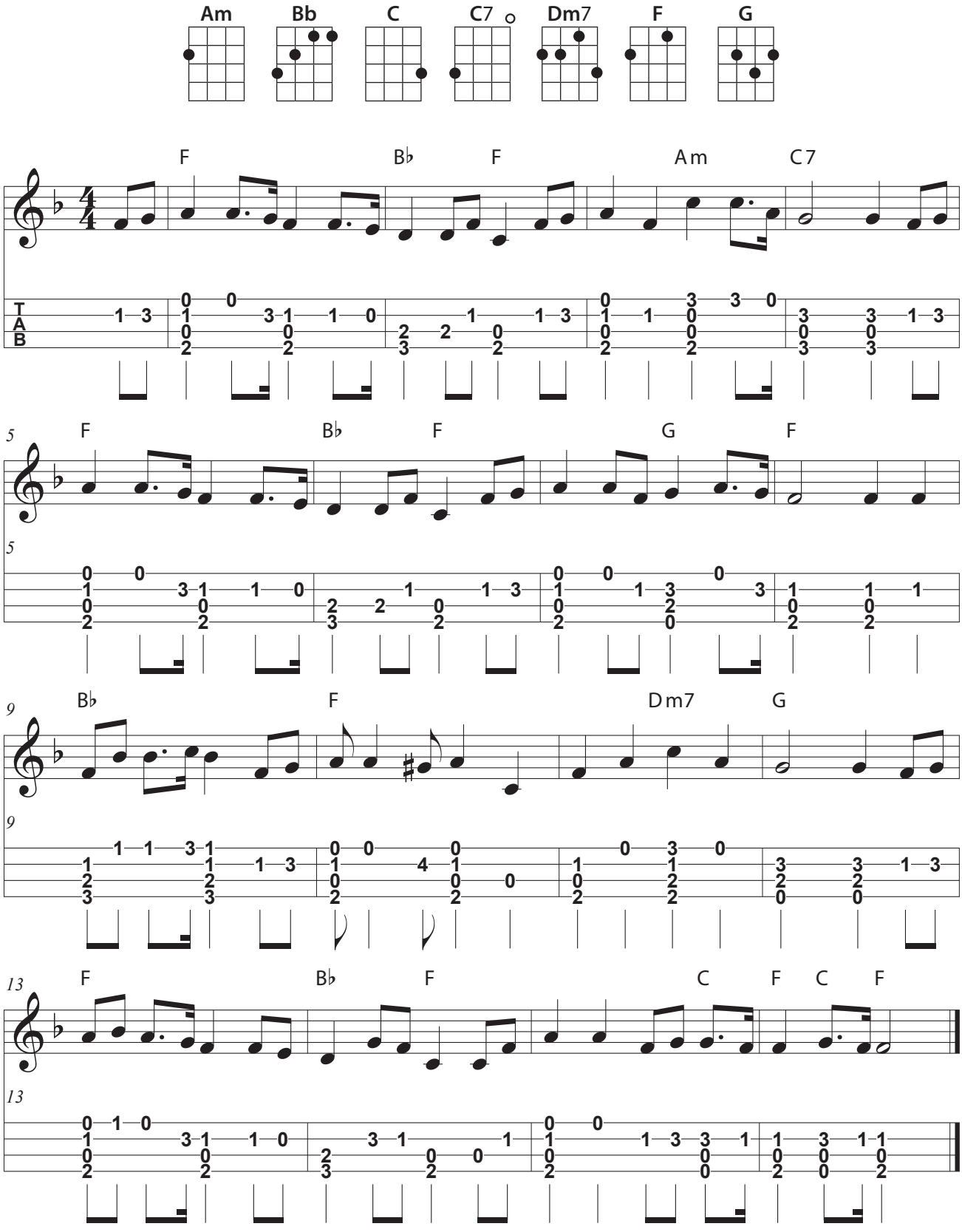
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Jesse James
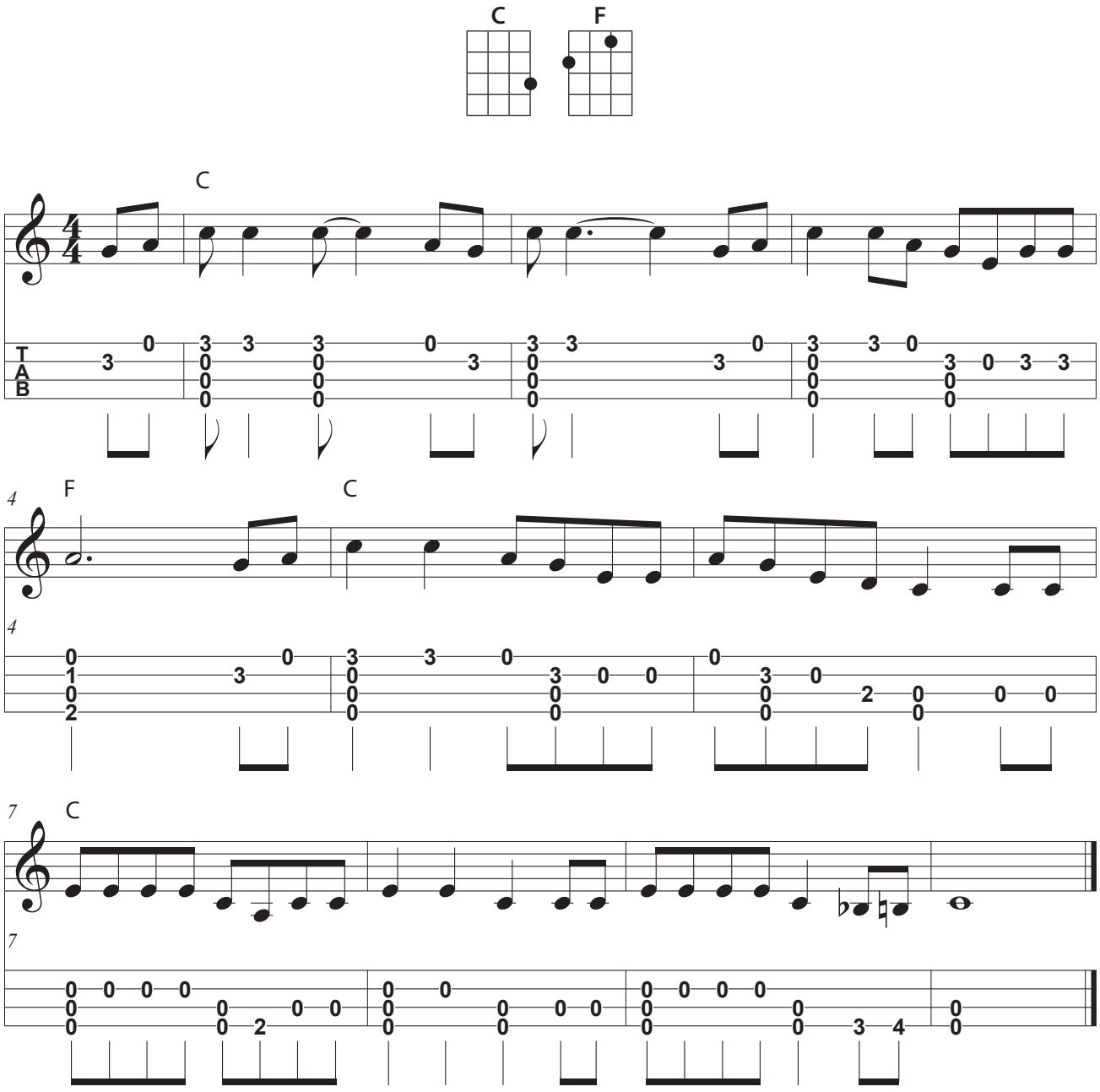
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

John Henry

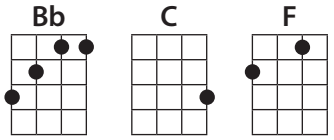
American
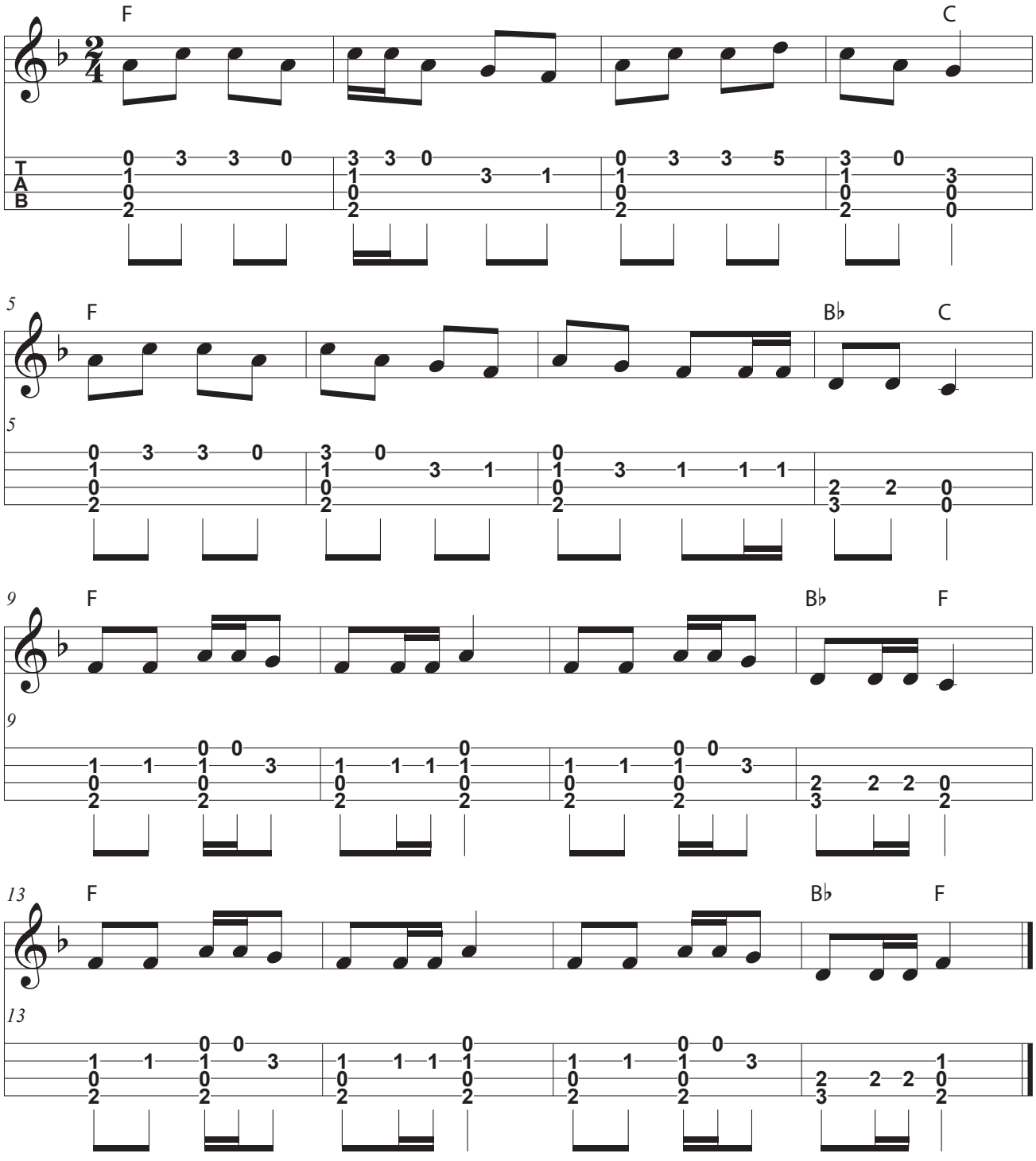


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Johnson Boys

American
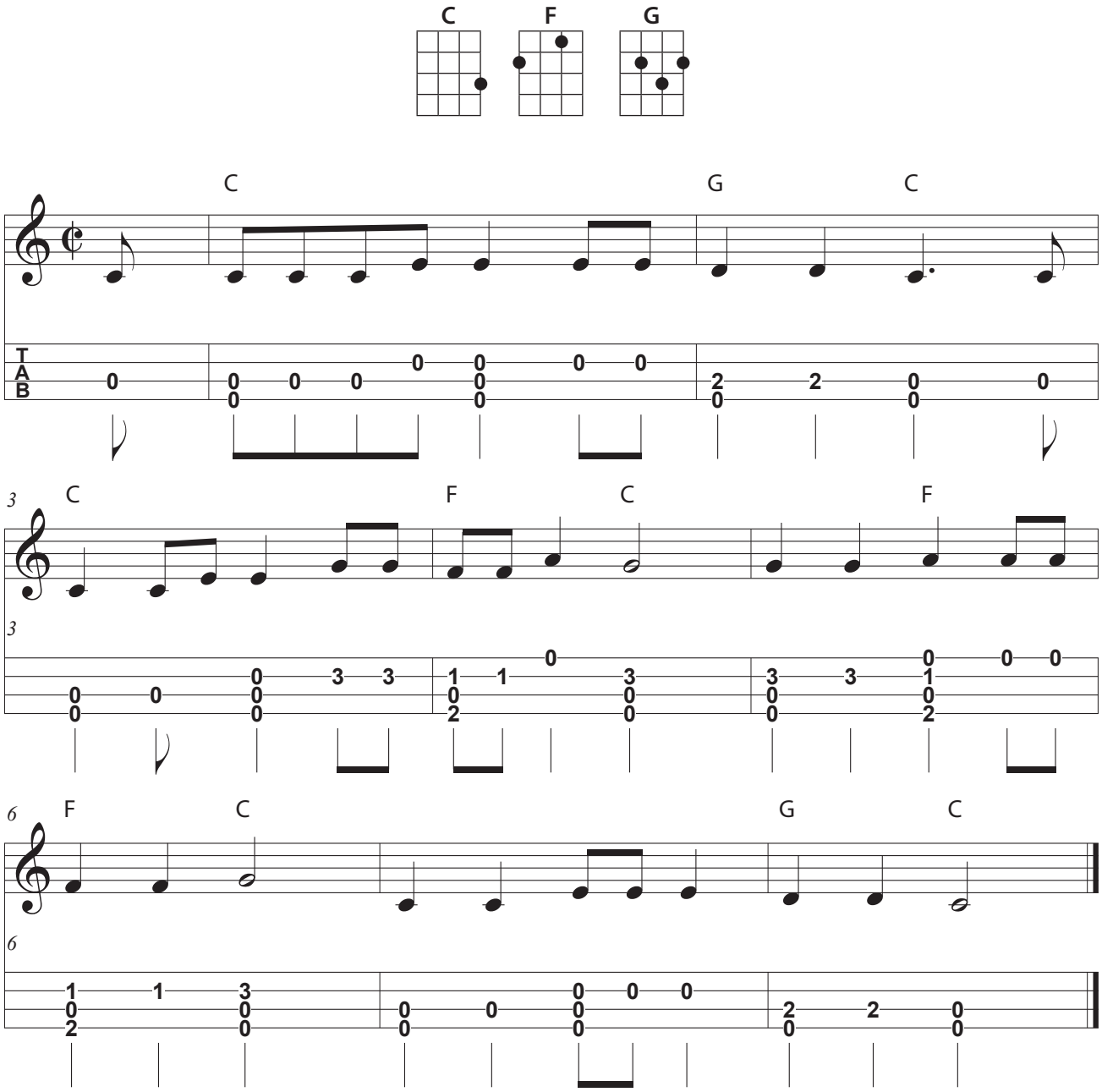




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Kentucky Bootlegger
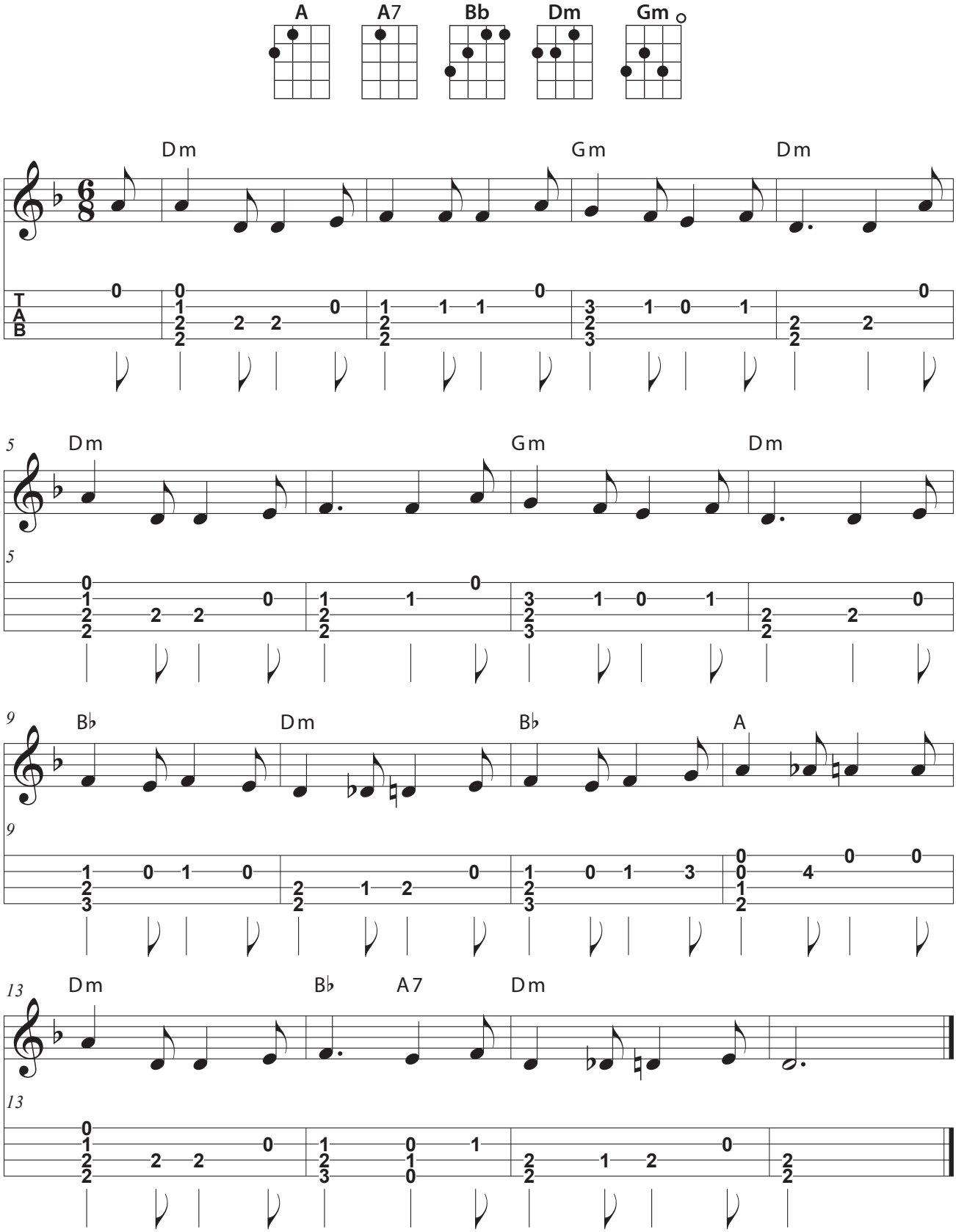
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Keys of Canterbury
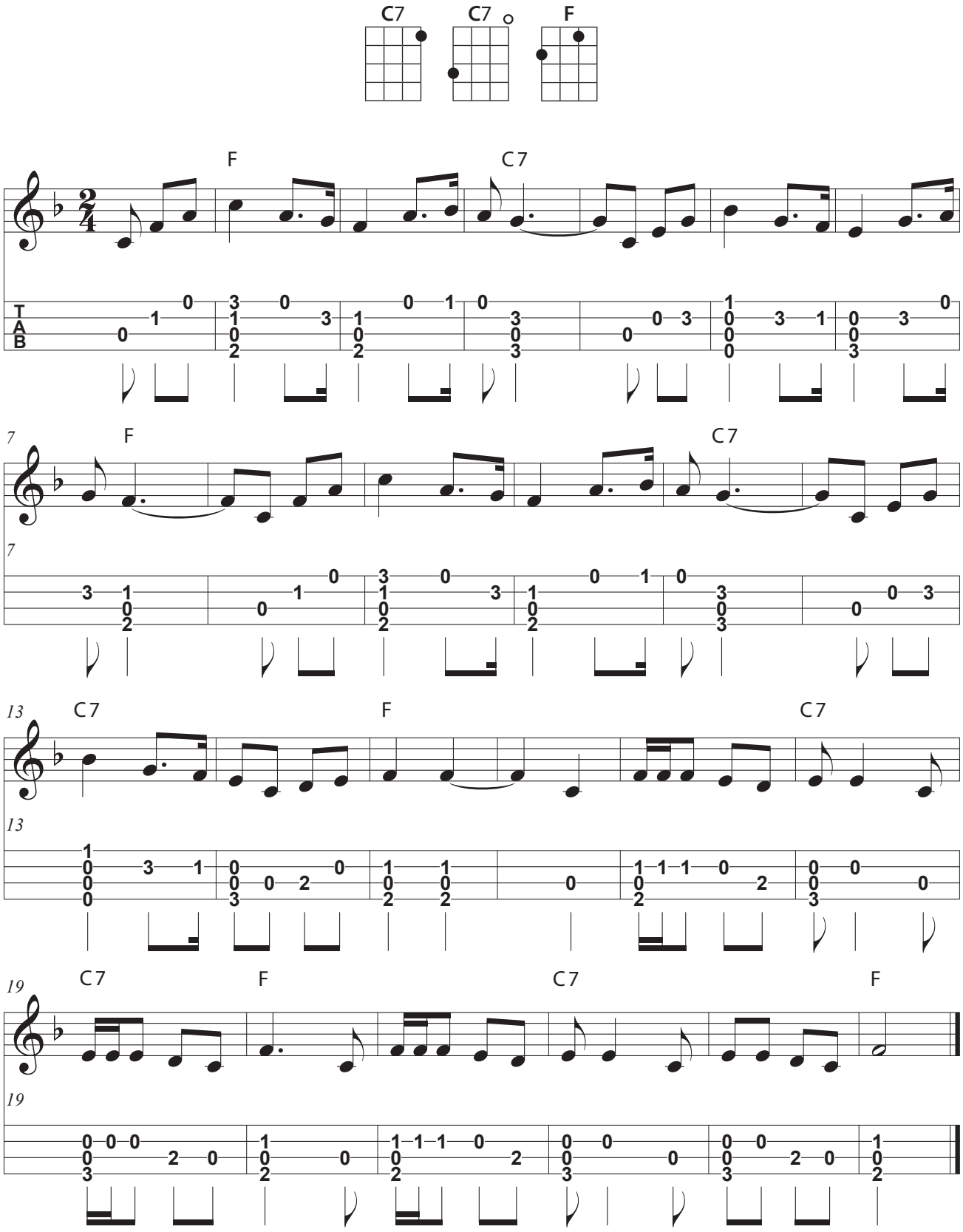
English



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

La Jesucita

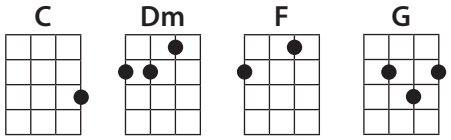
Mexican
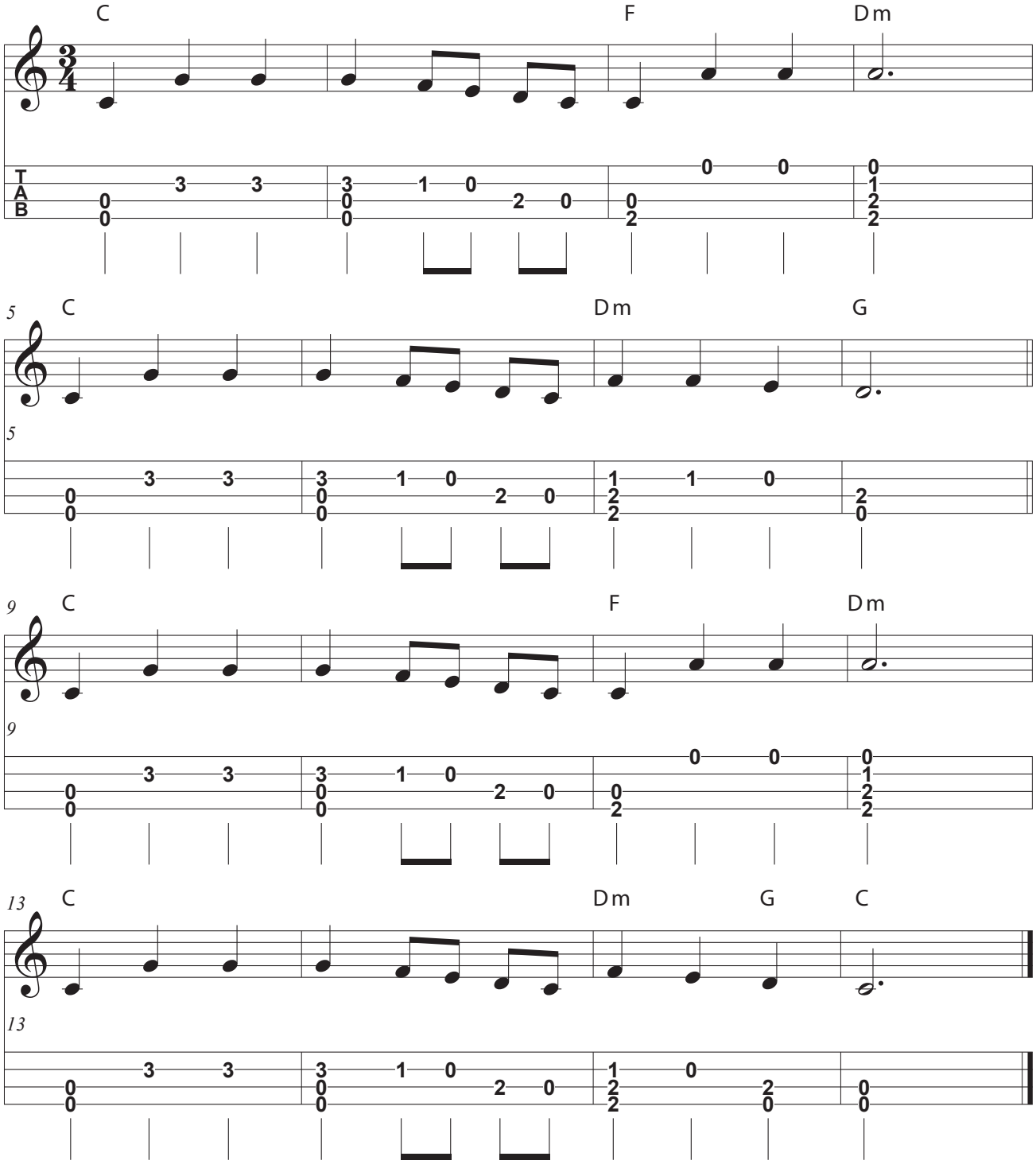


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Lavender's Blue

English
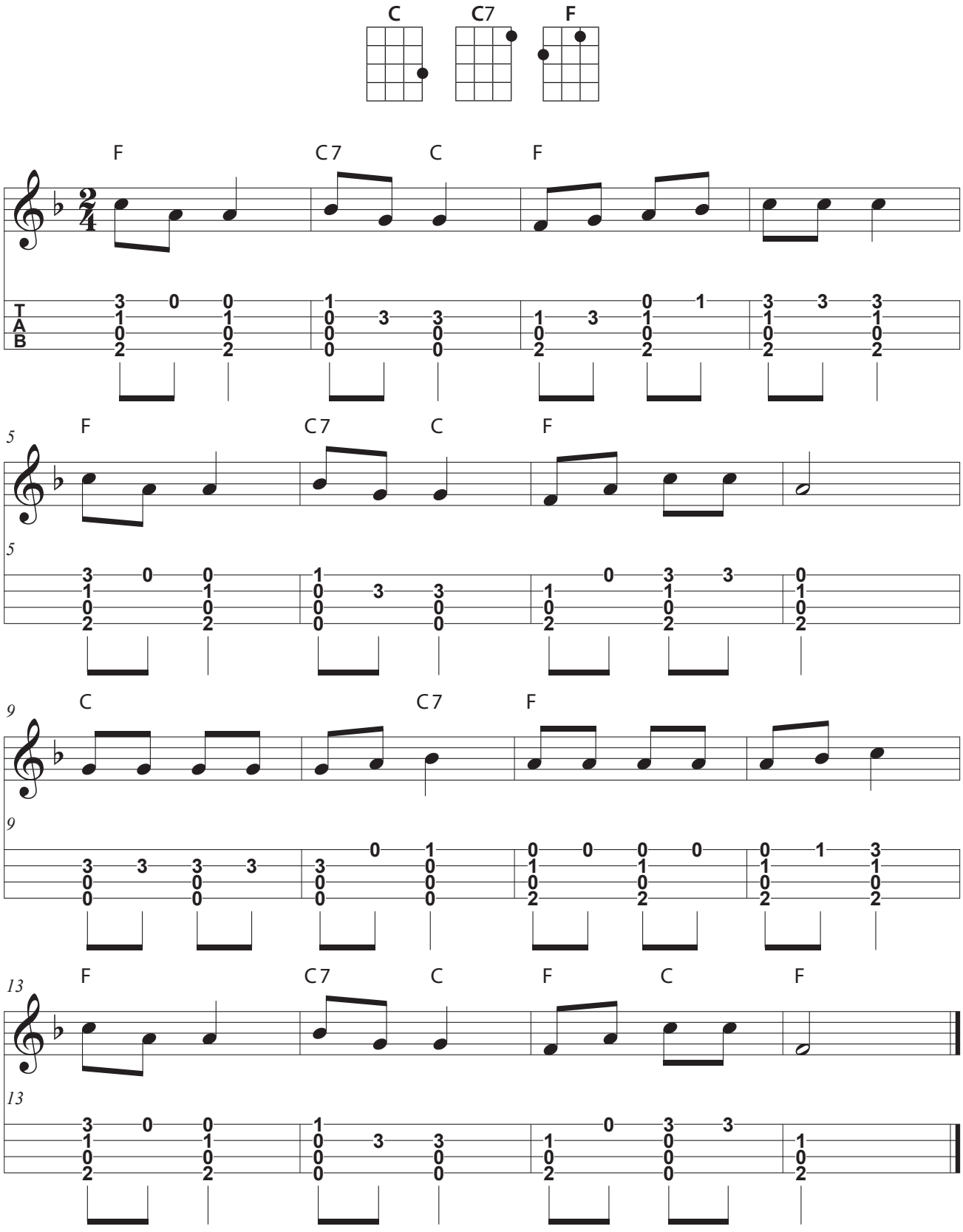




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Lightly Row

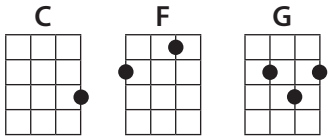
American
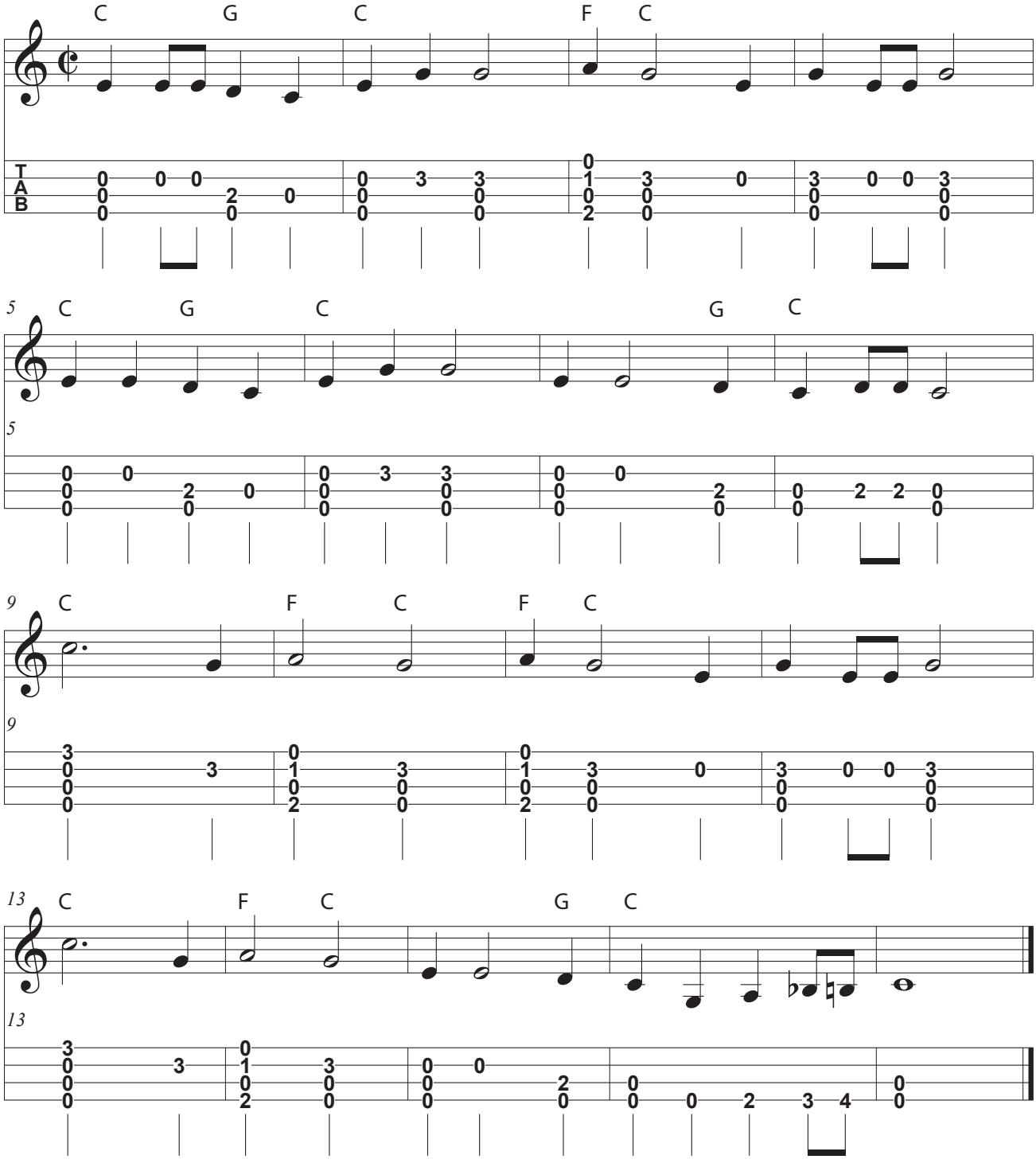


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Li'l Liza Jane

American
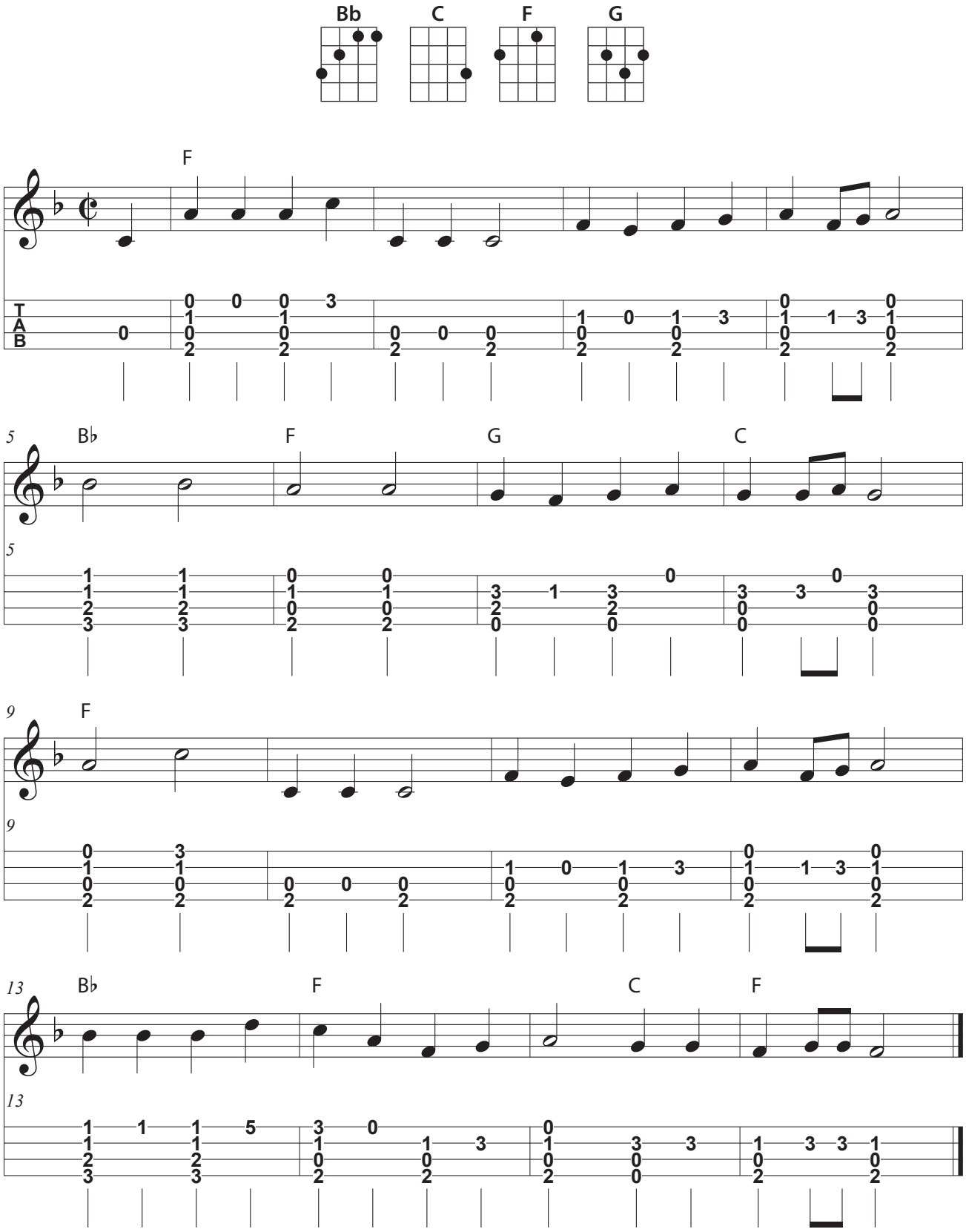




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Little Sandy Girl
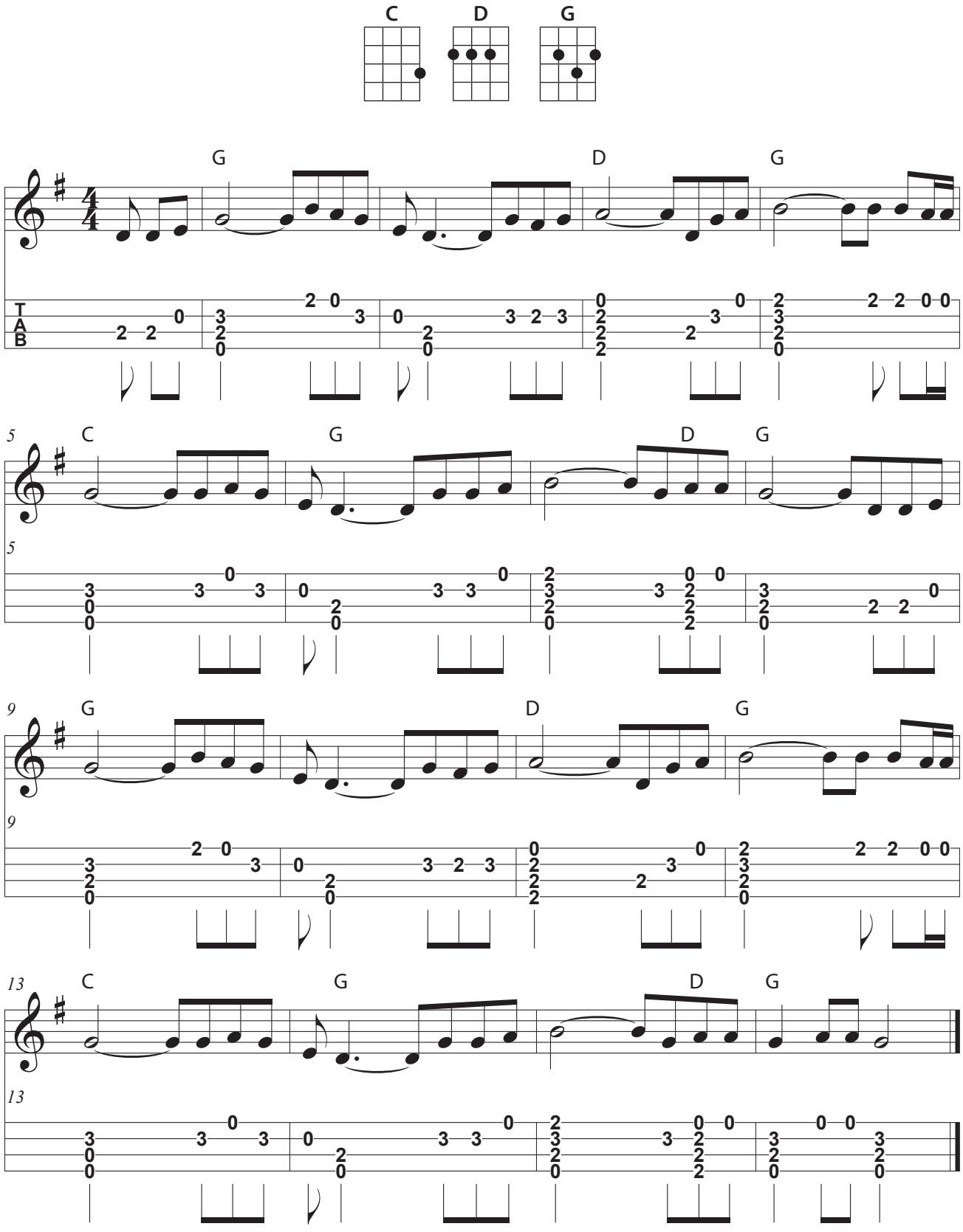
Tobagonian



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Lonesome Valley
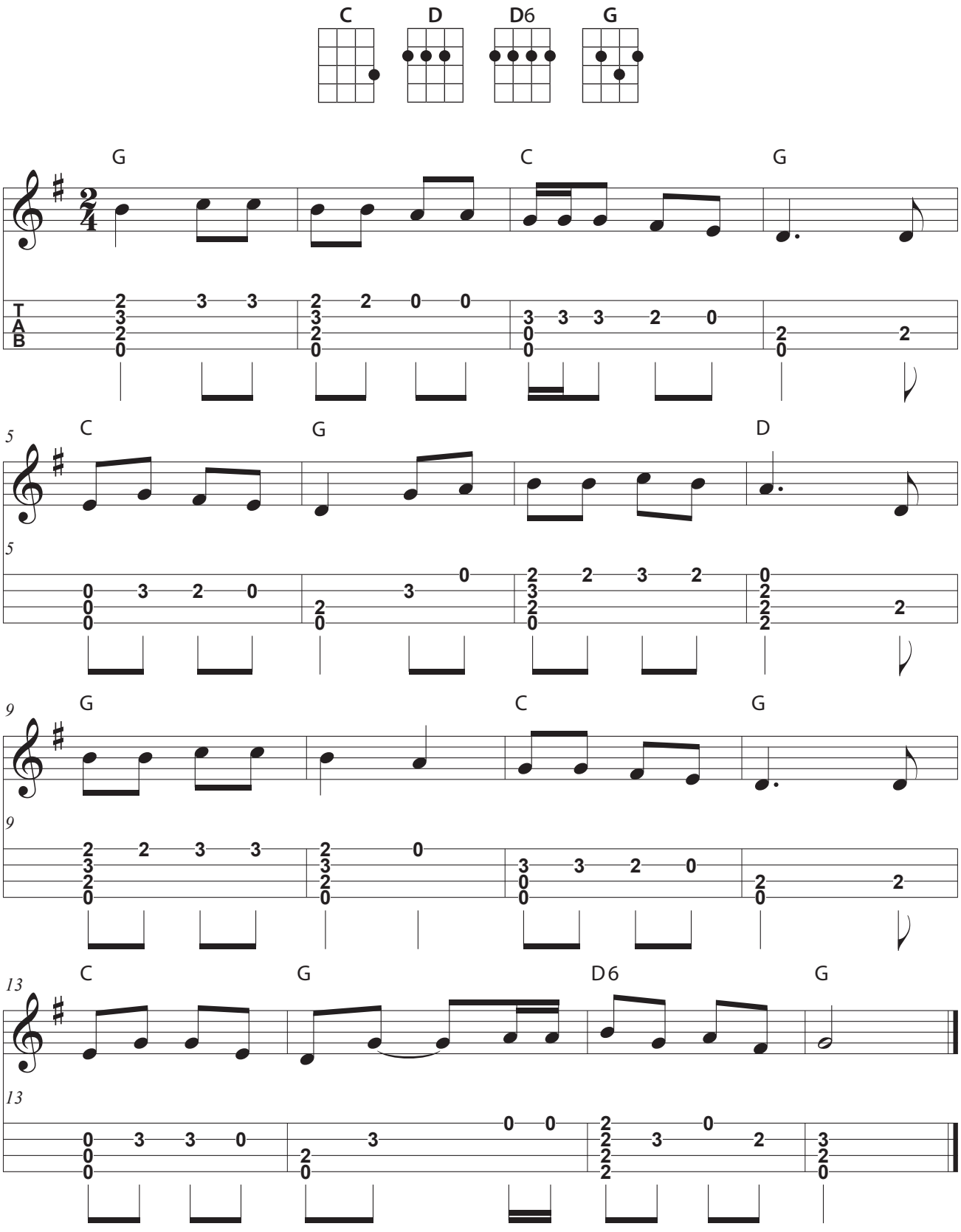
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Louisville Burglar
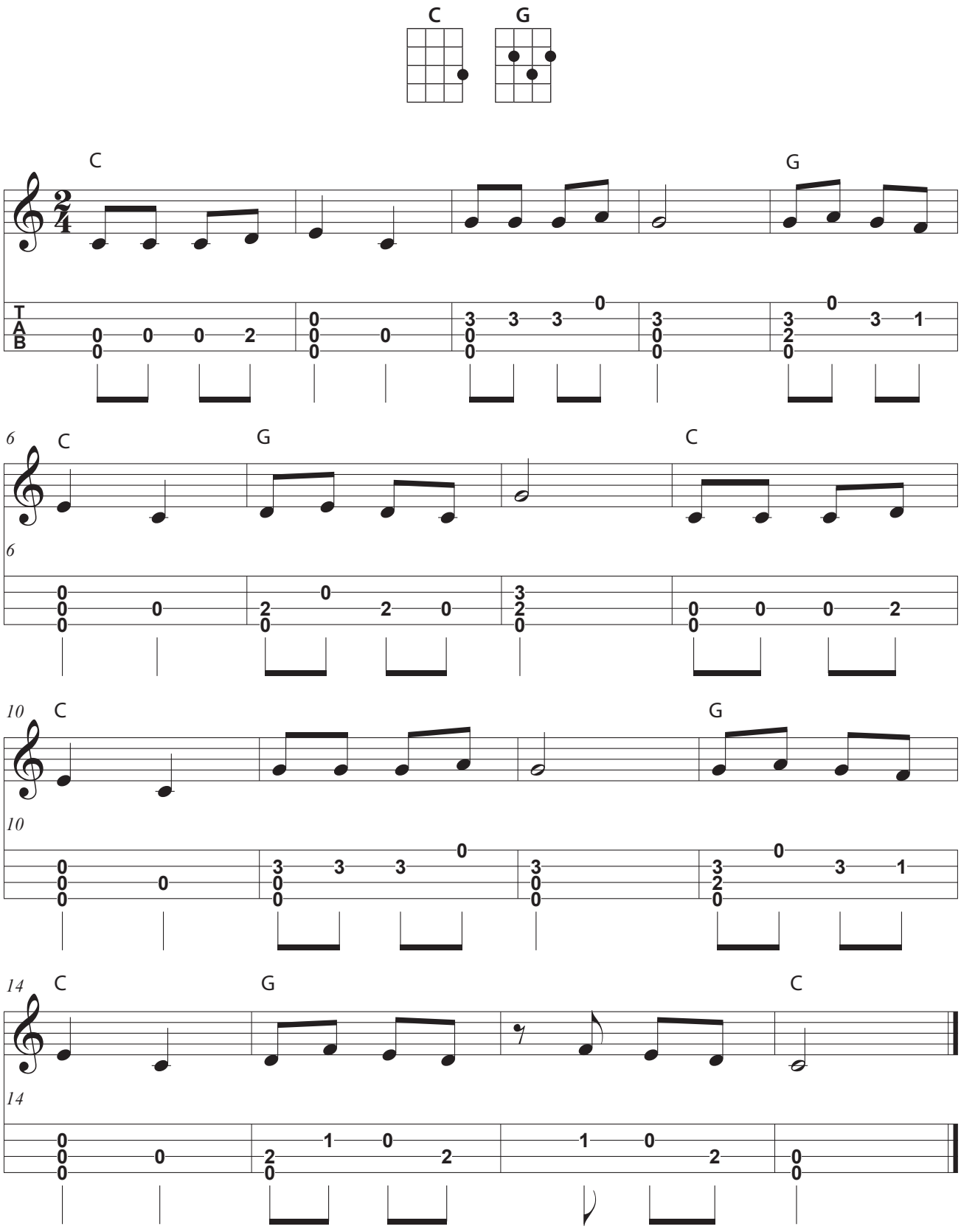
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Lullaby, My Baby
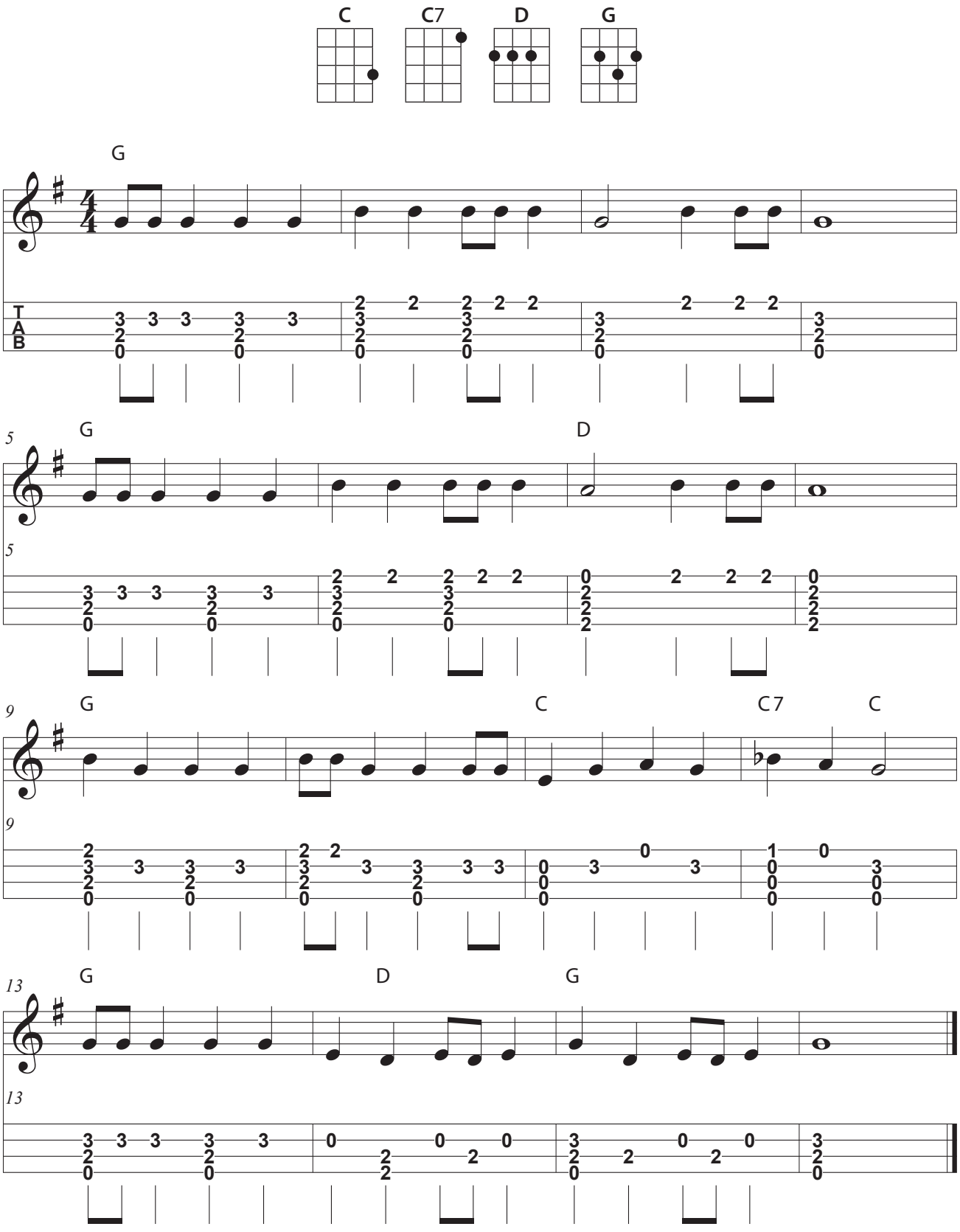
Argentinian



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Mama Don't 'Low
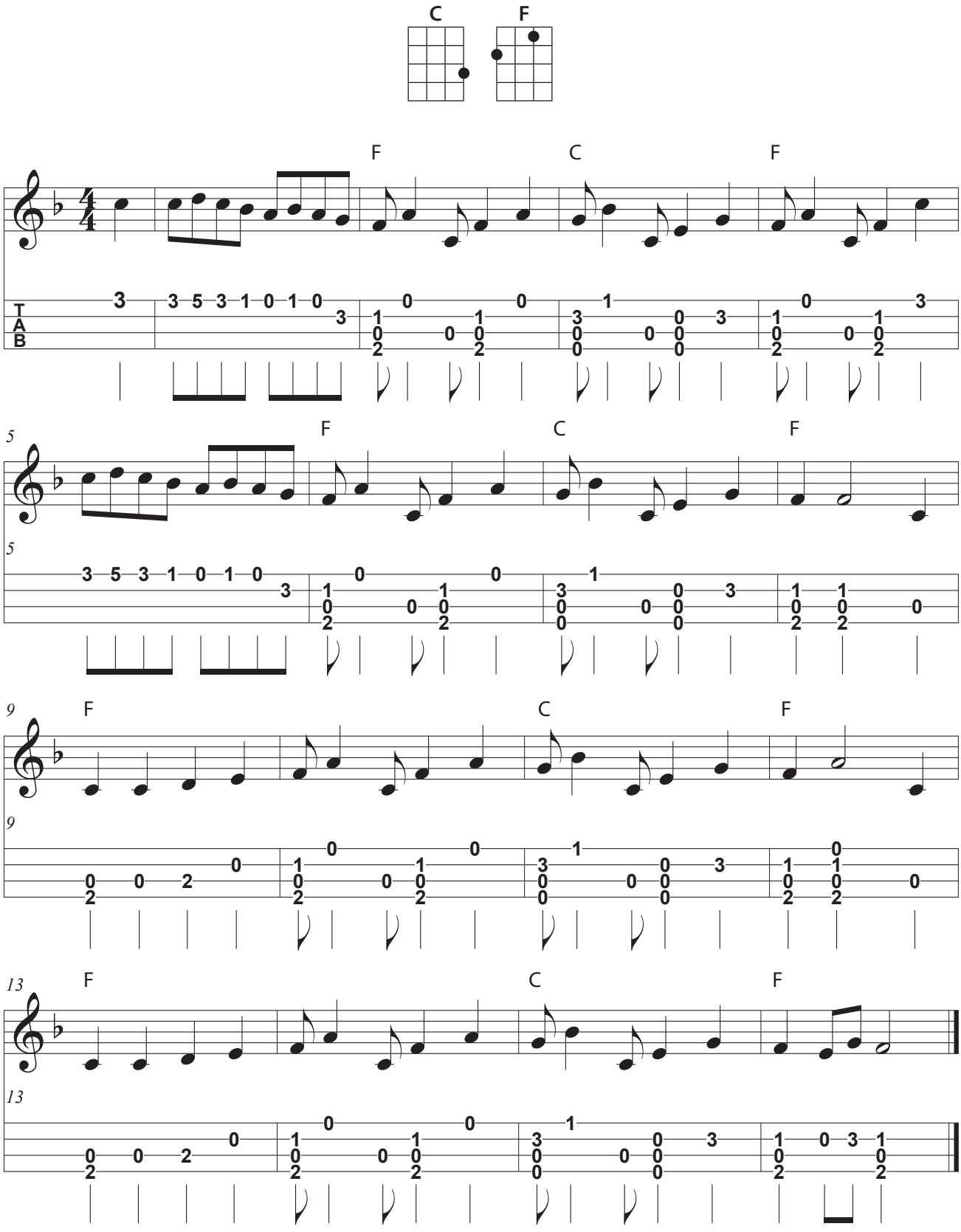
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Mango Walk
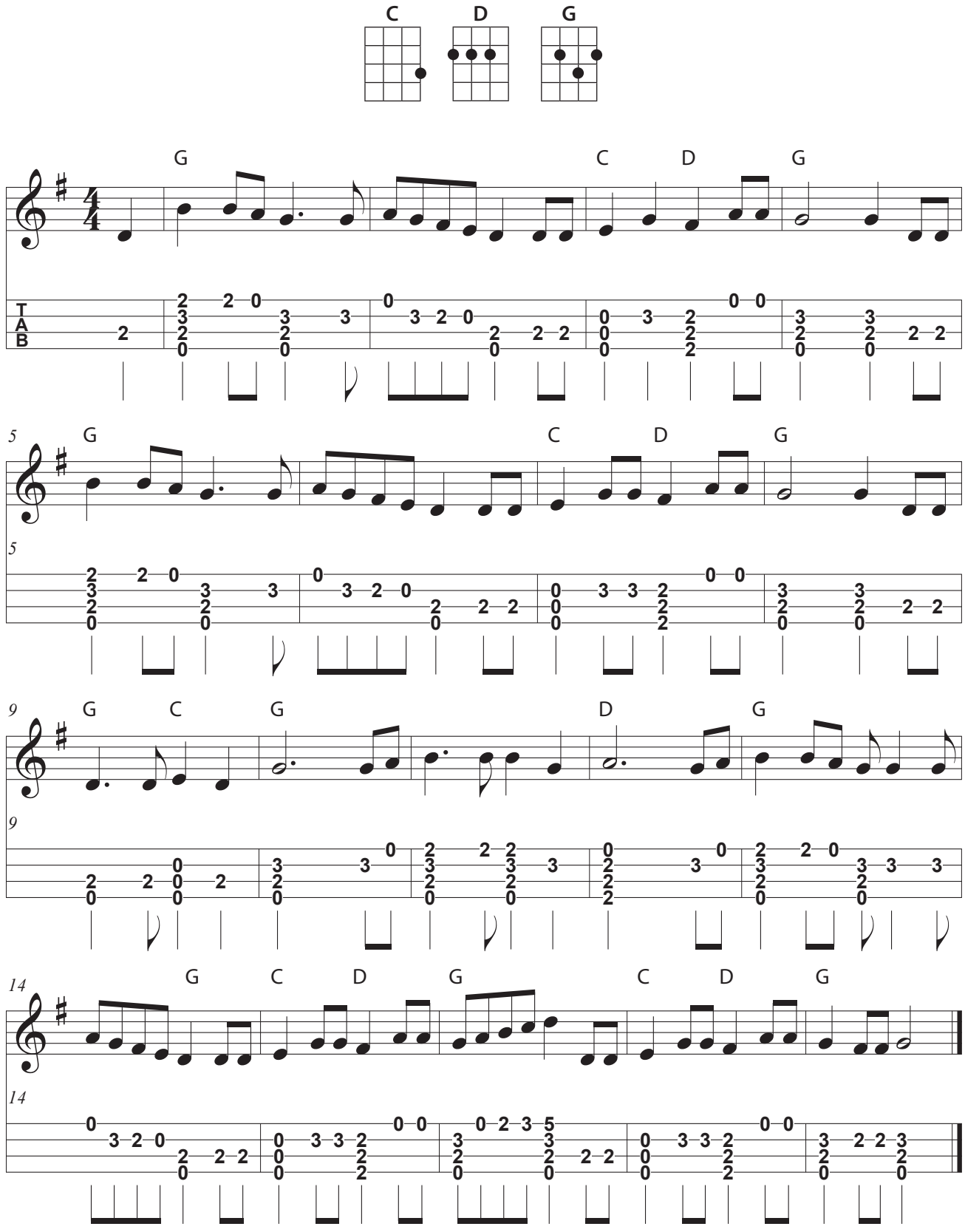
Jamaican



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Mermaid
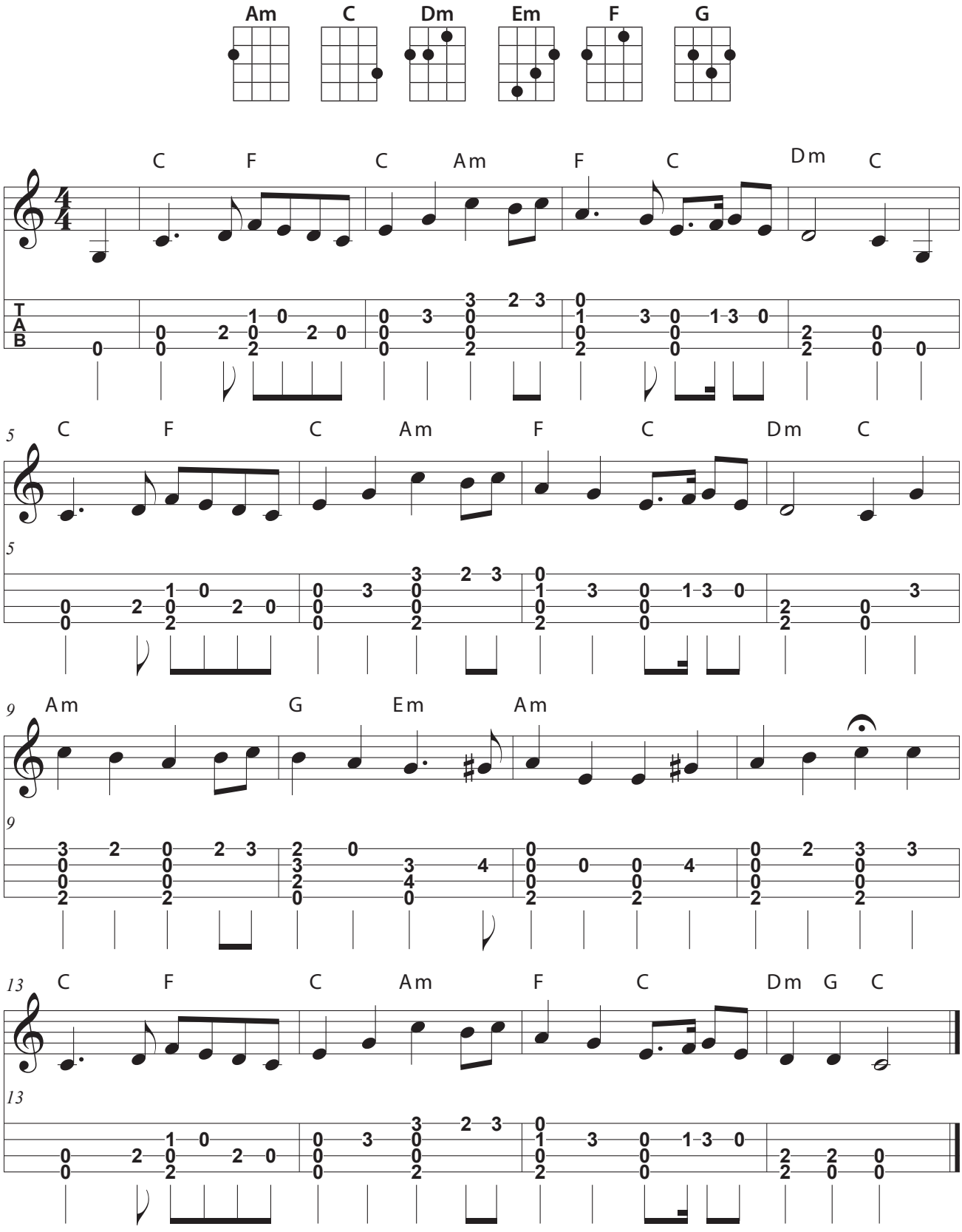
Irish



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Minstrel Boy
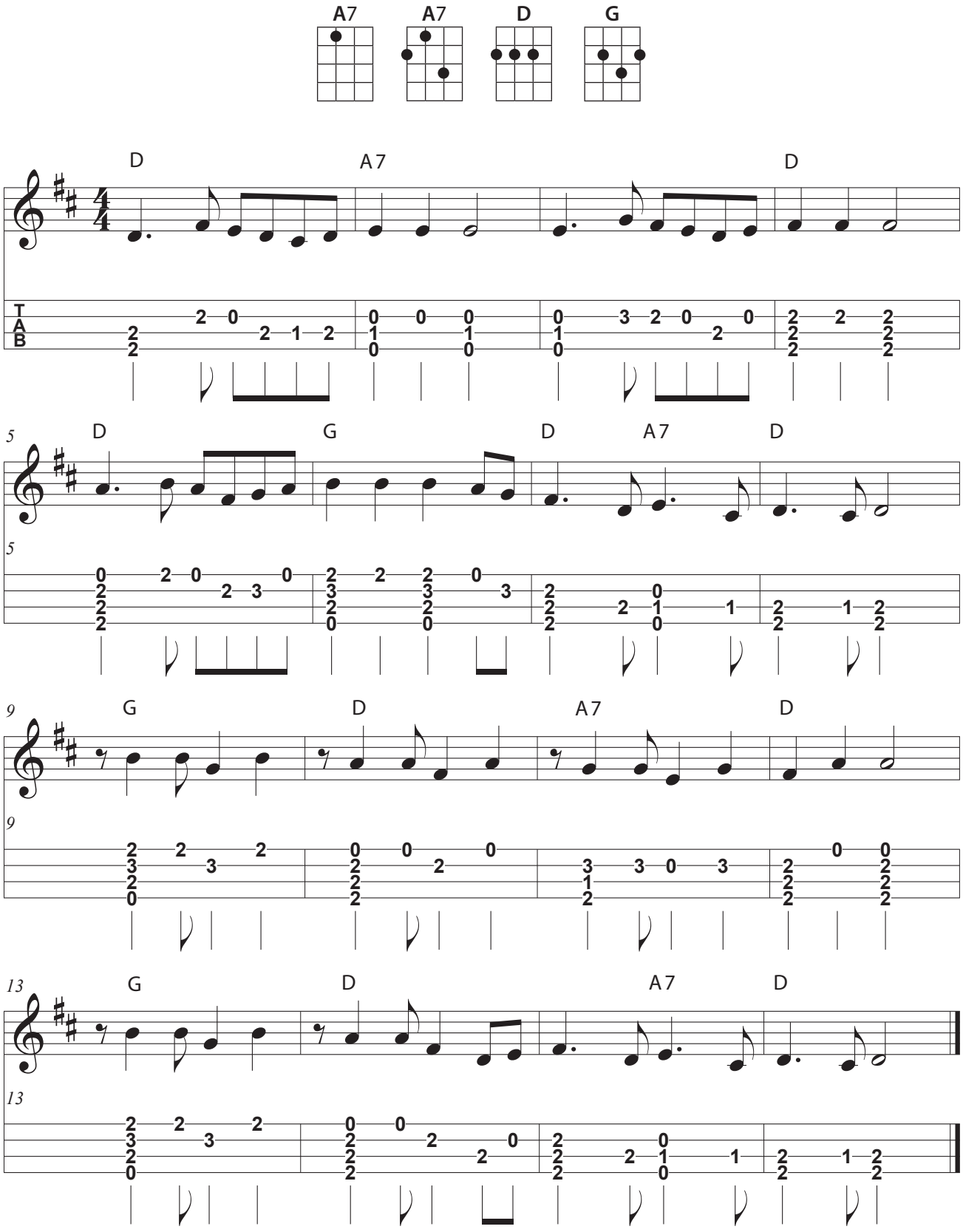
Irish



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Nona Manis
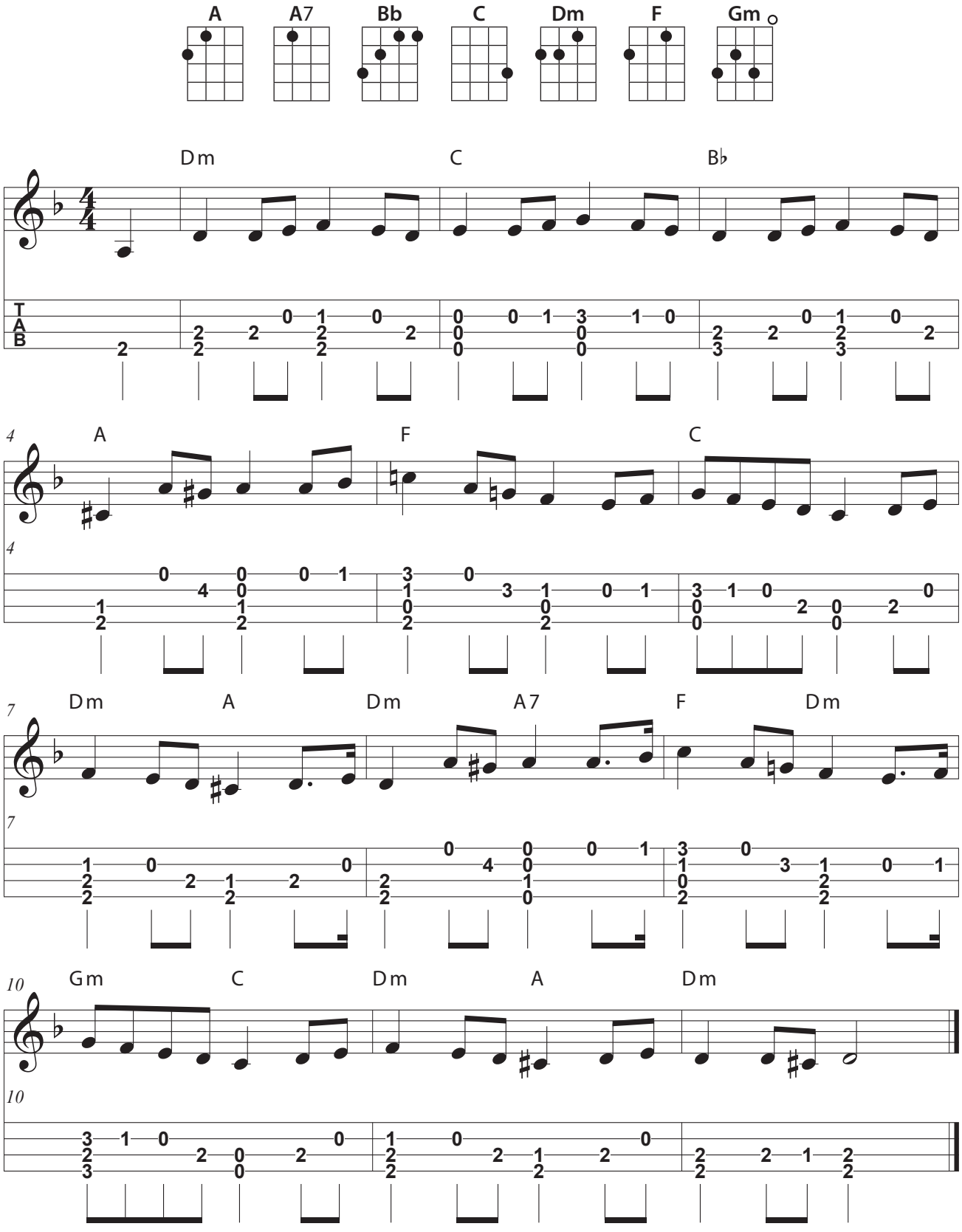
Indonesian



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Oak and the Ash
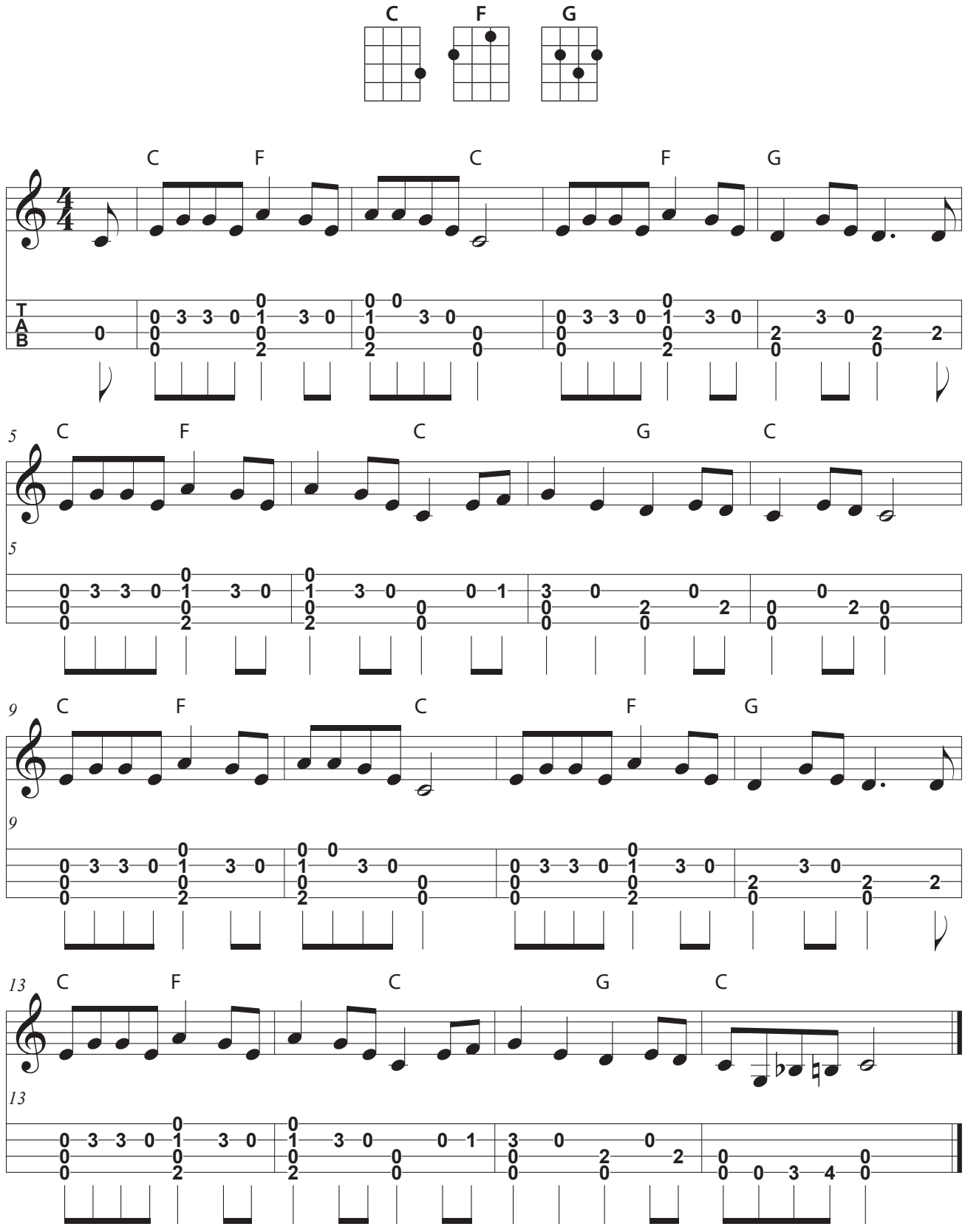
English



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Old Gospel Ship

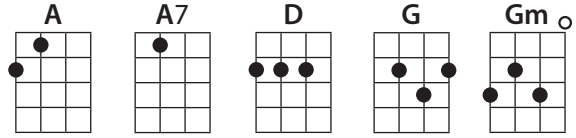
American
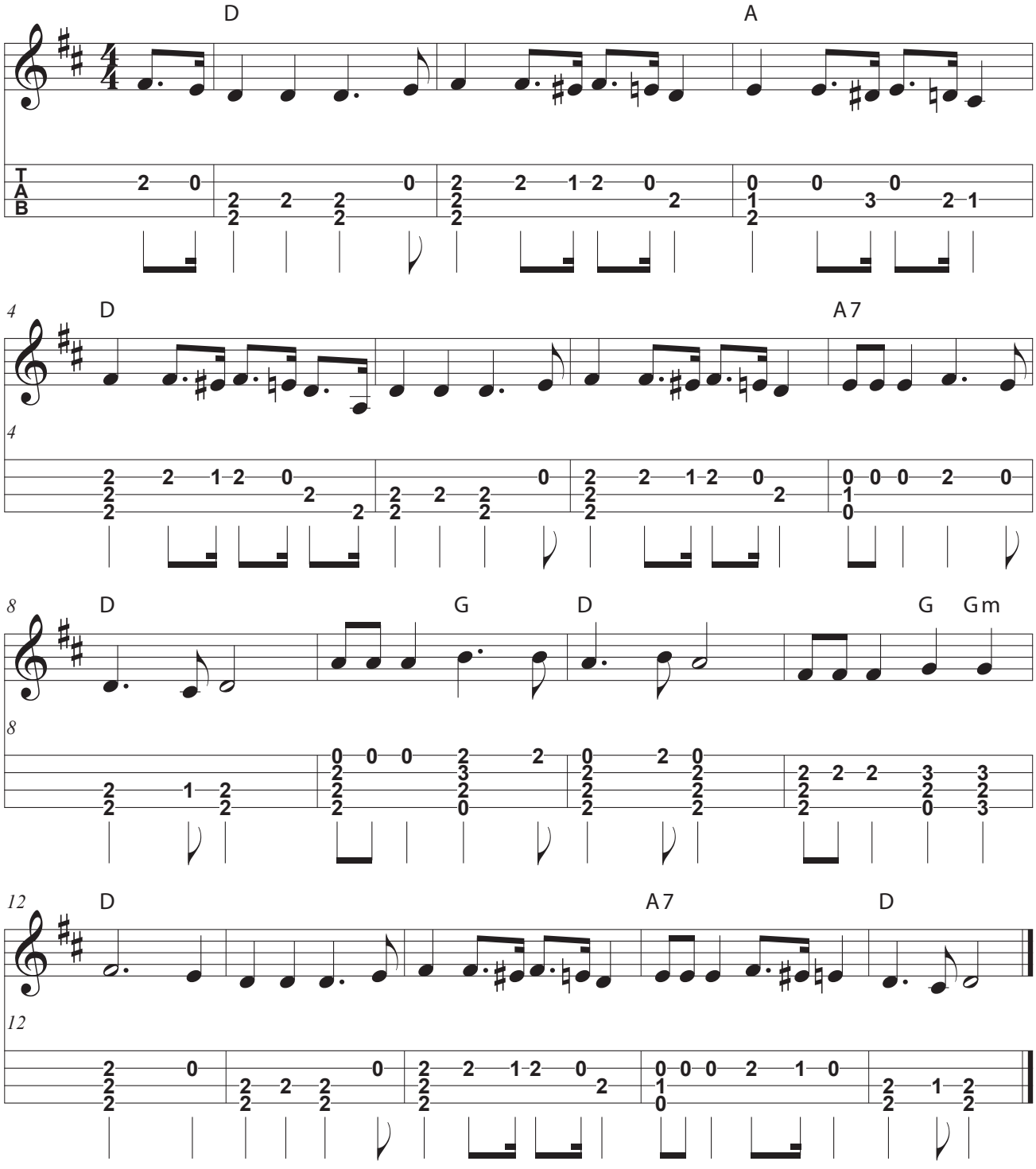


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Old Gray Mare

American
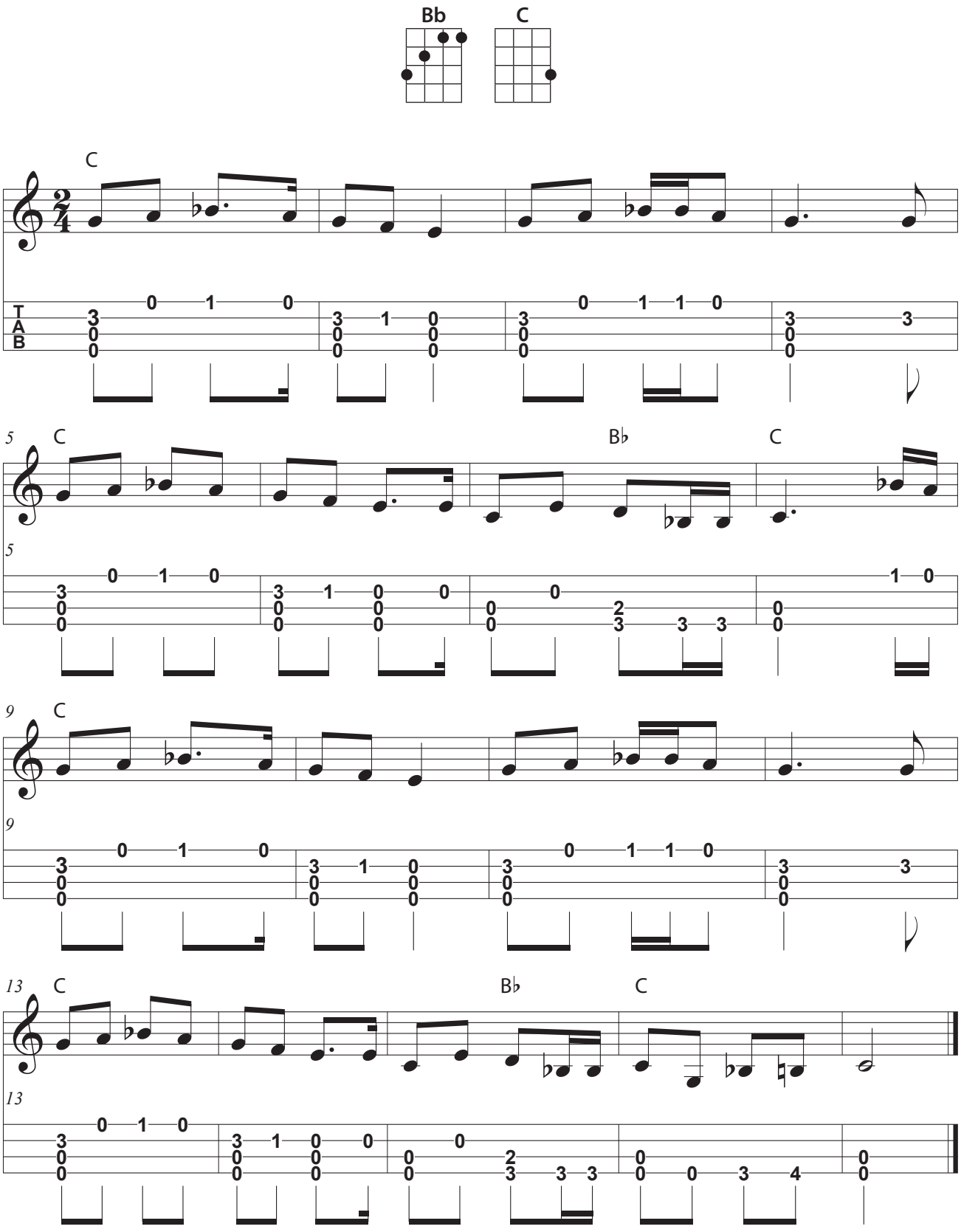




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Old Joe Clark
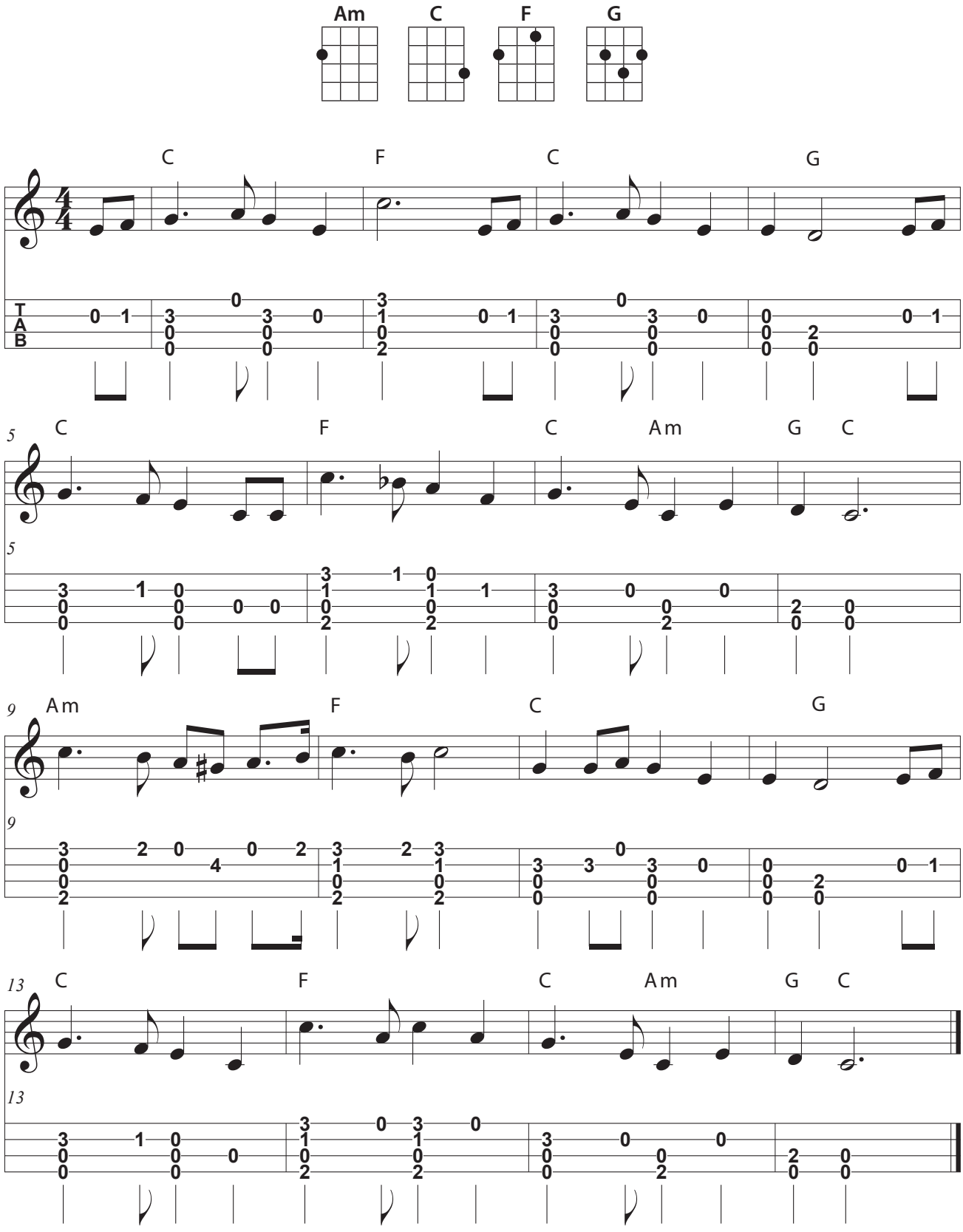
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Overlander
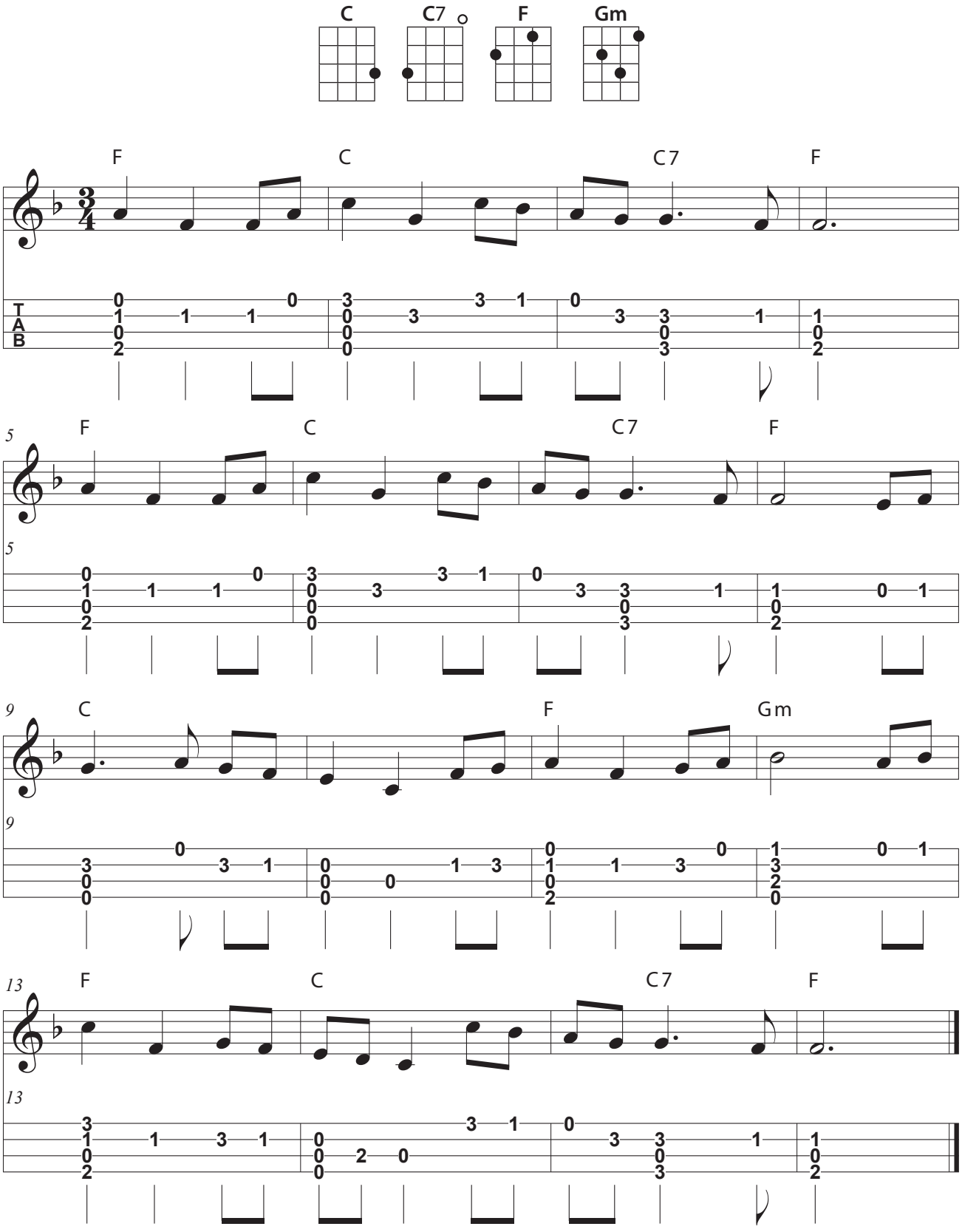
Australian



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Over the Mountains
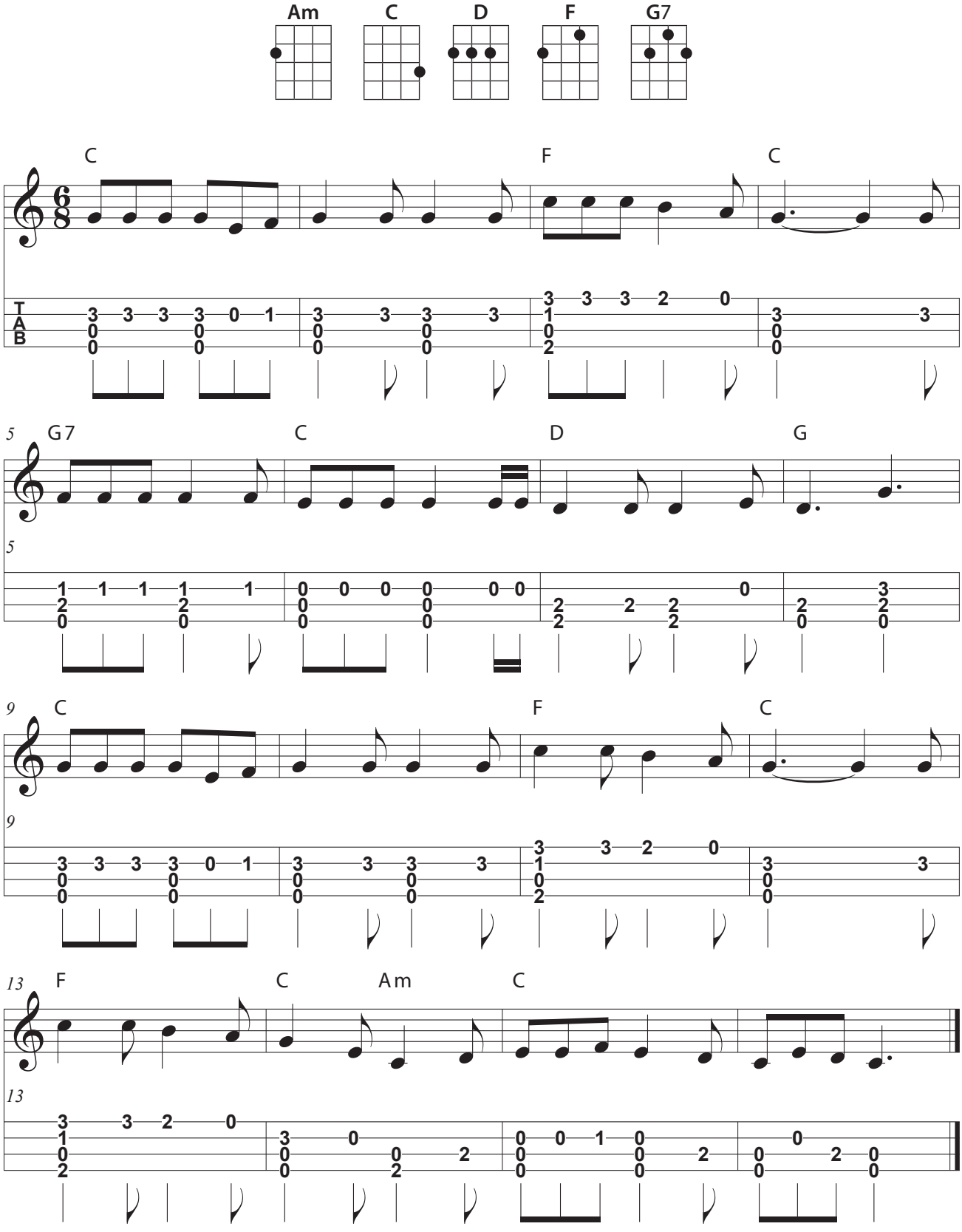
English



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Over the River and through the Woods
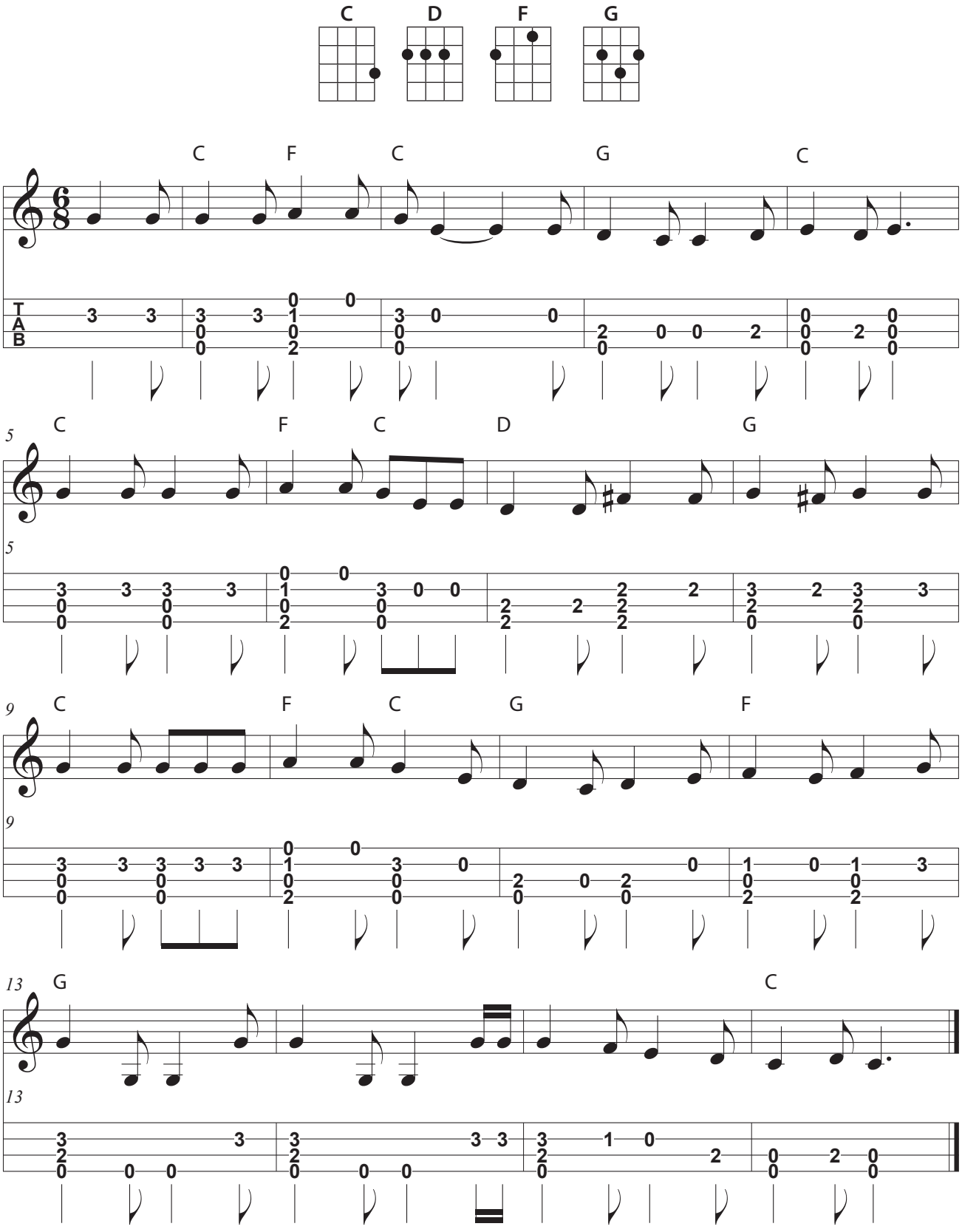
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Portland County Jail
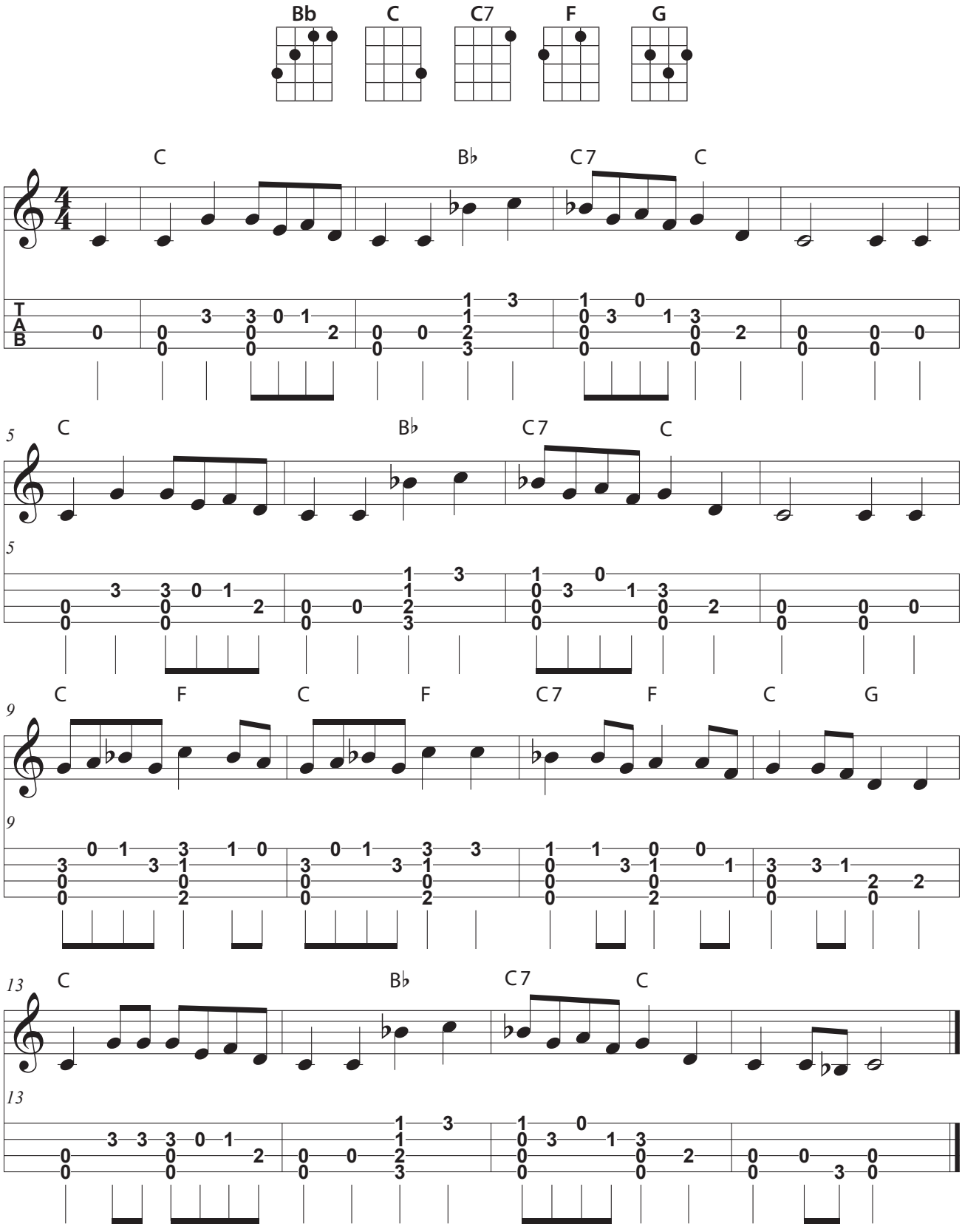
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Rambling Sailor
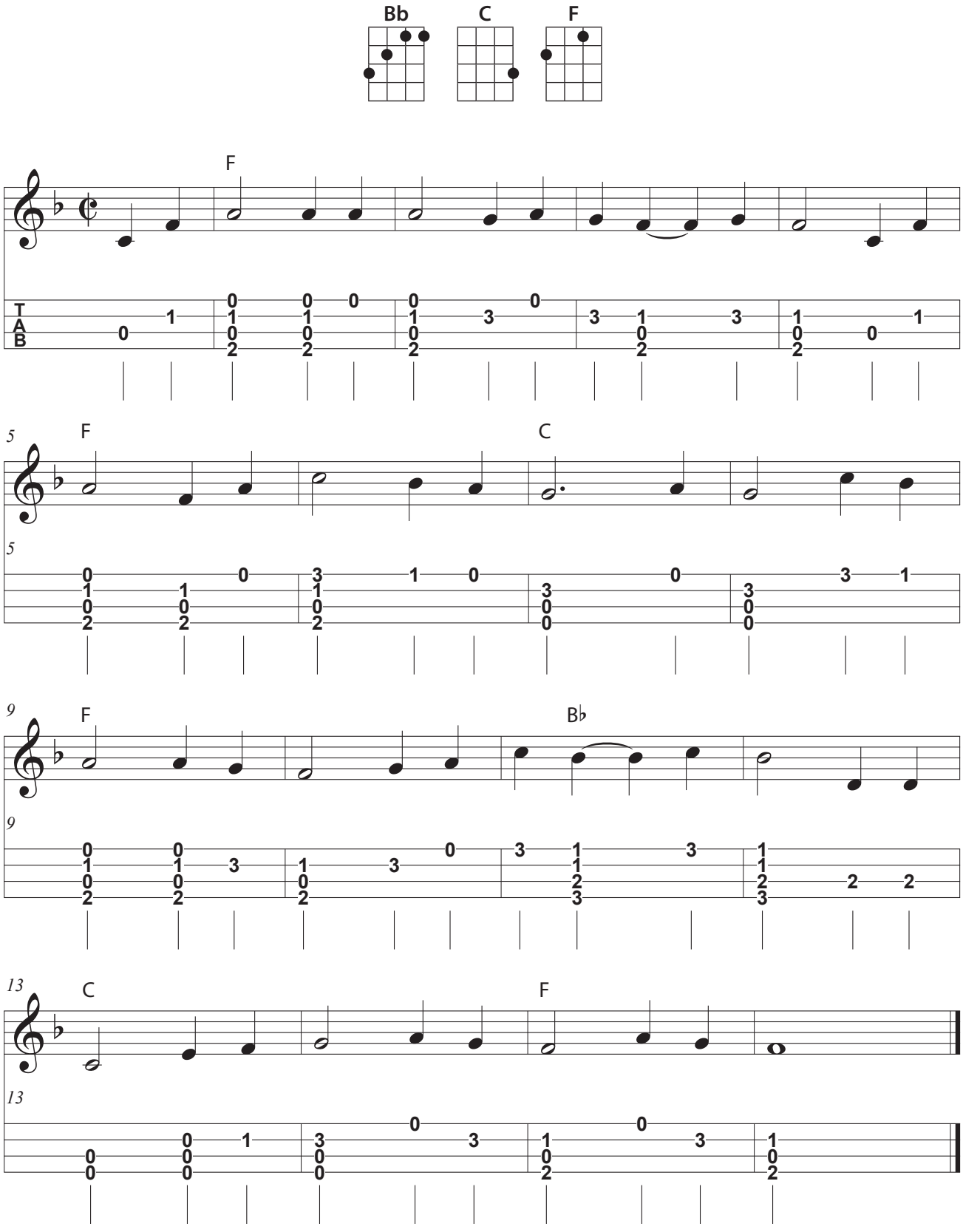
English



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Red River Valley

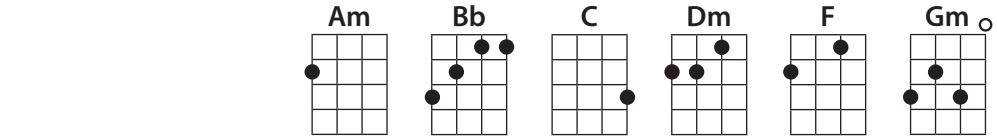
American
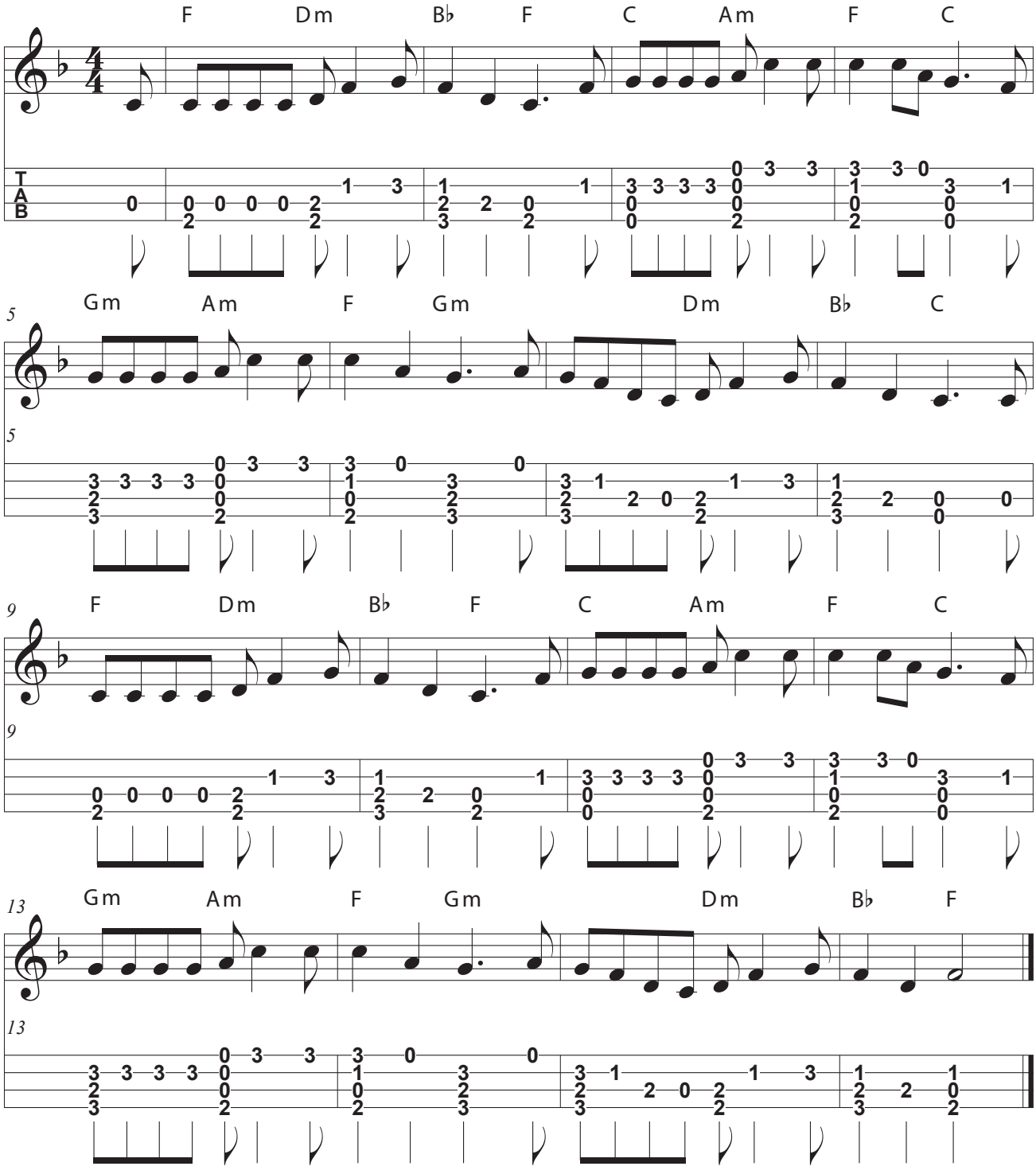


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Riddle Song

English
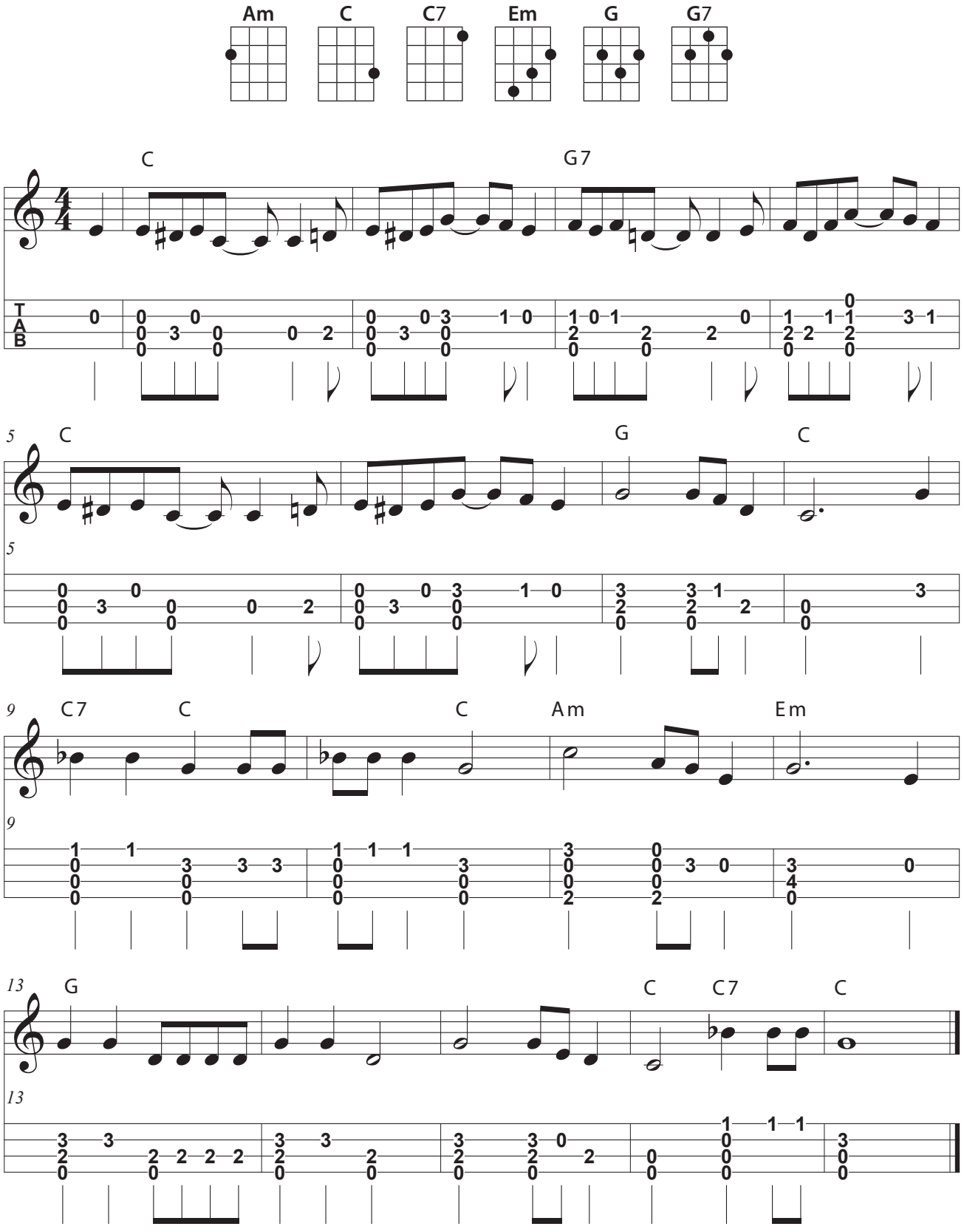




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Rock-a-My Soul

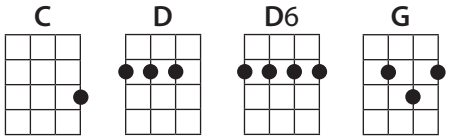
African American
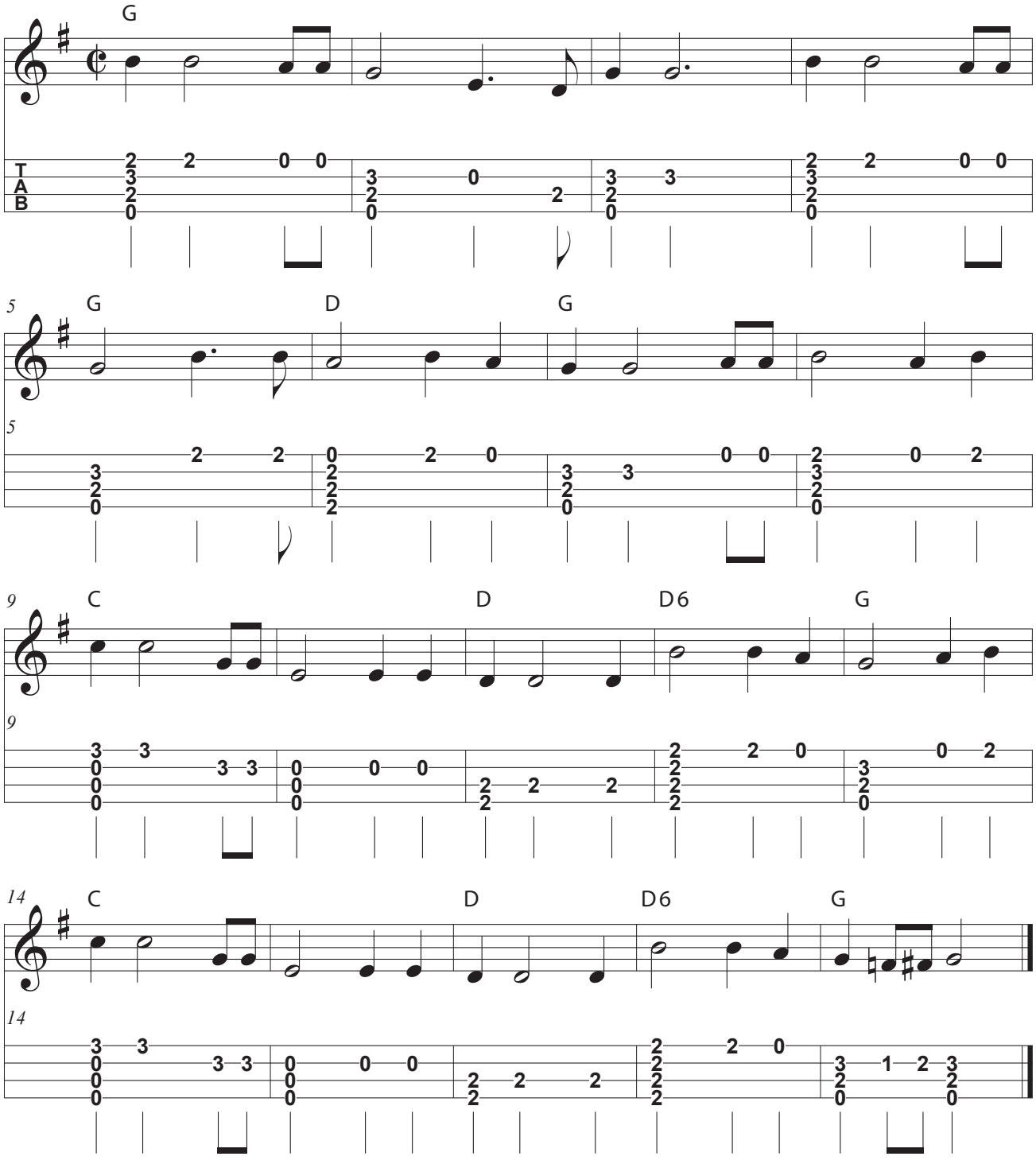


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Roll in My Sweet Baby's Arms

American
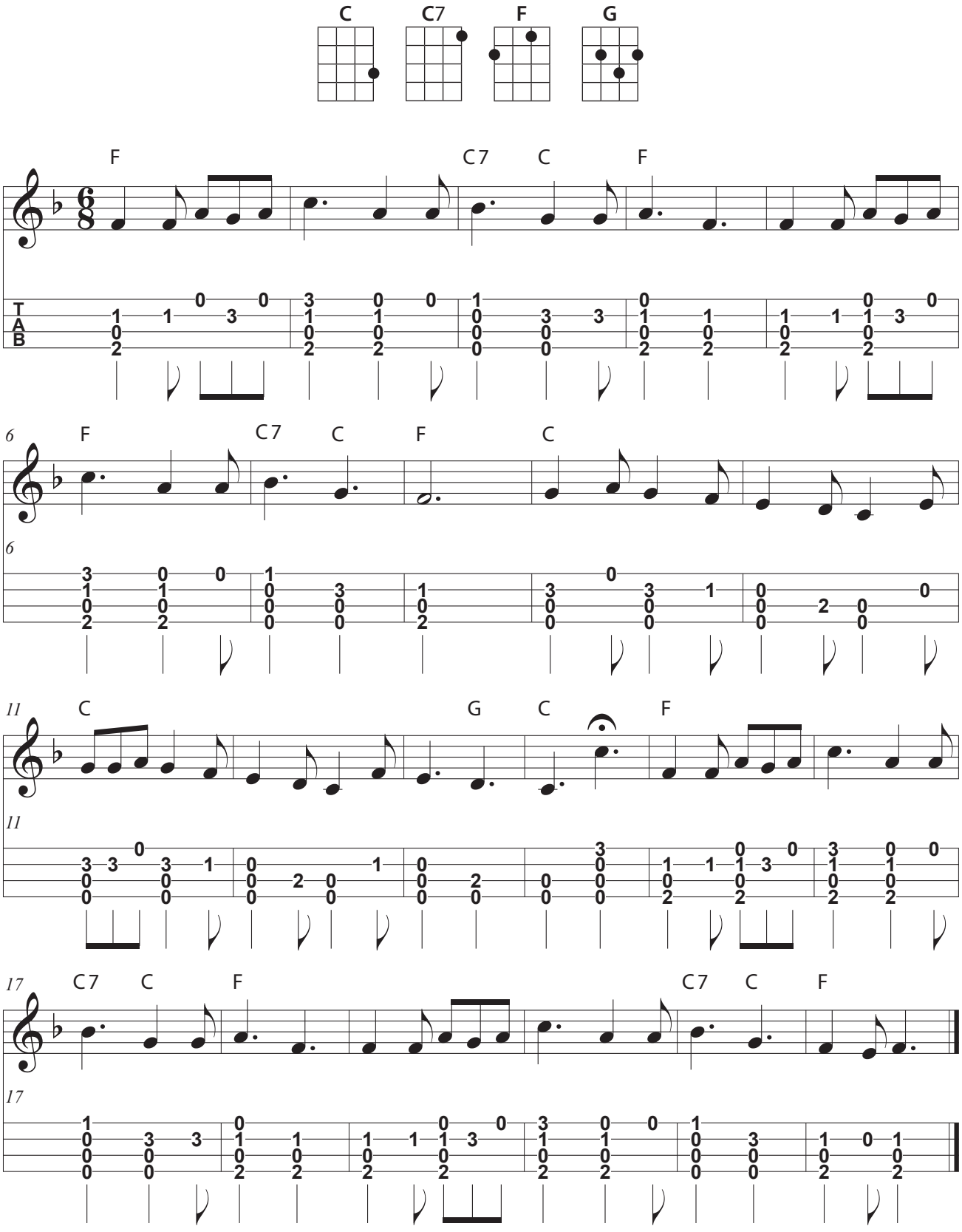




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Rosa

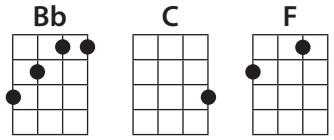
Flemish
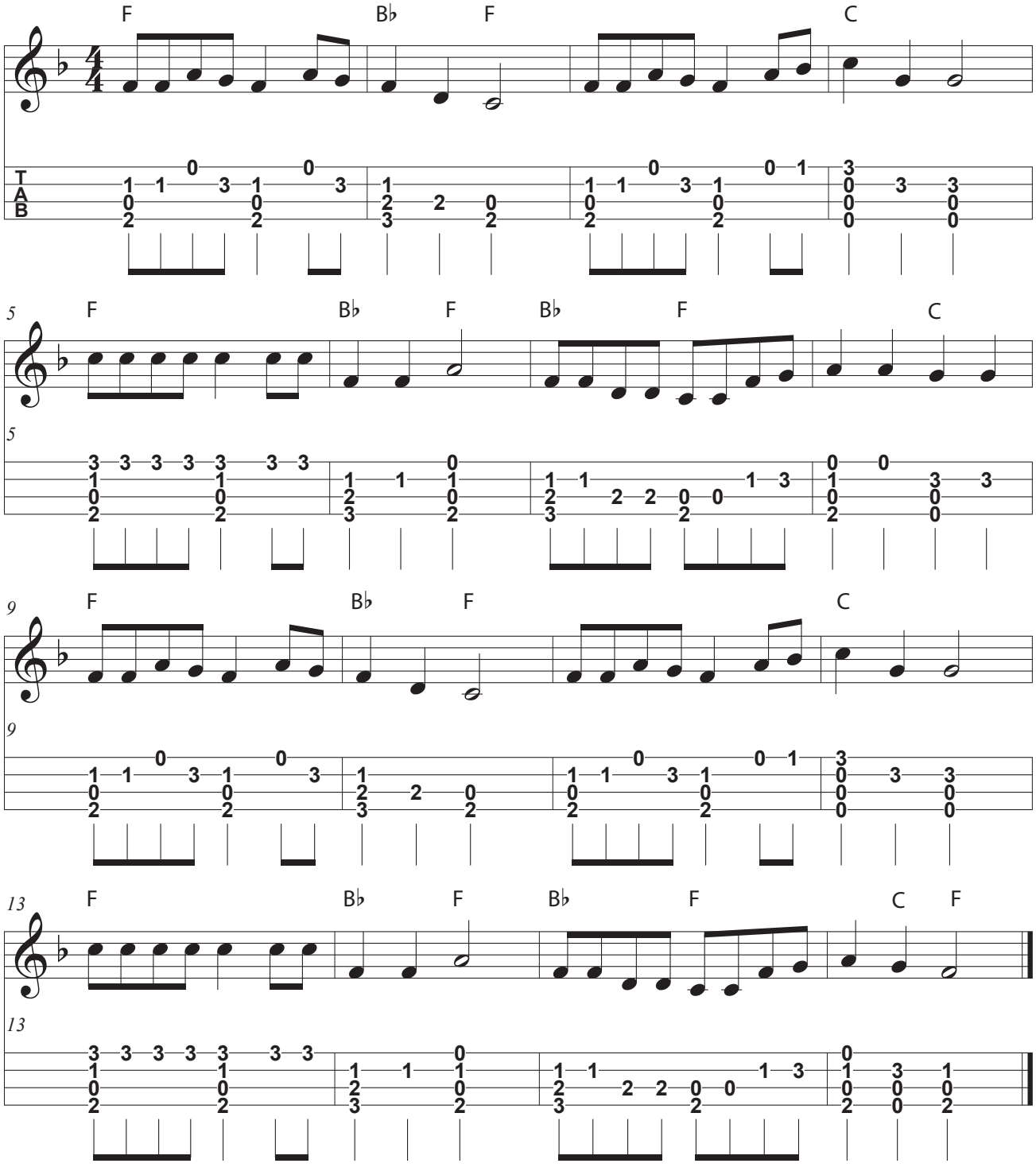


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Sailing in the Boat

American

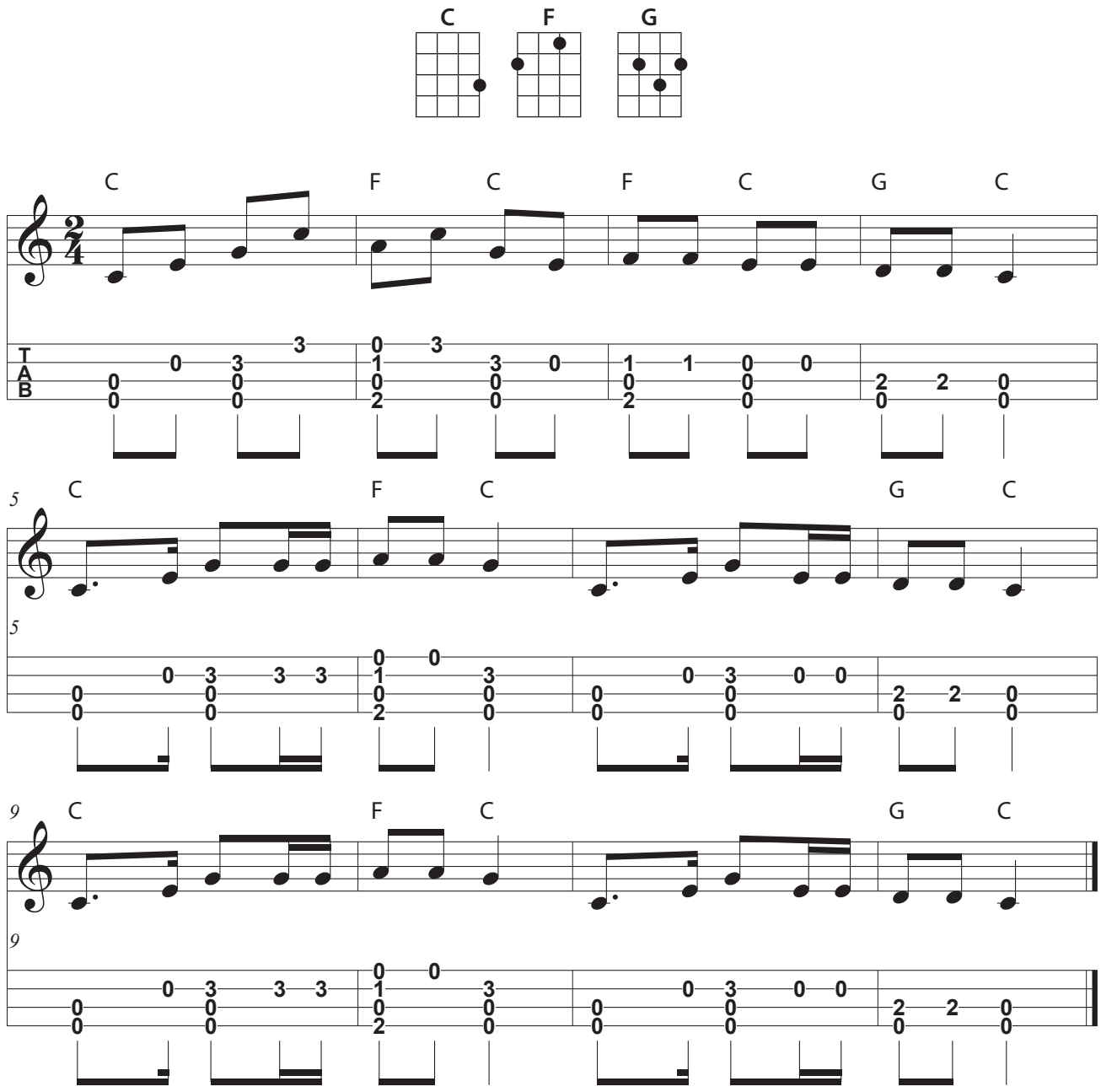




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Schnitzelbank
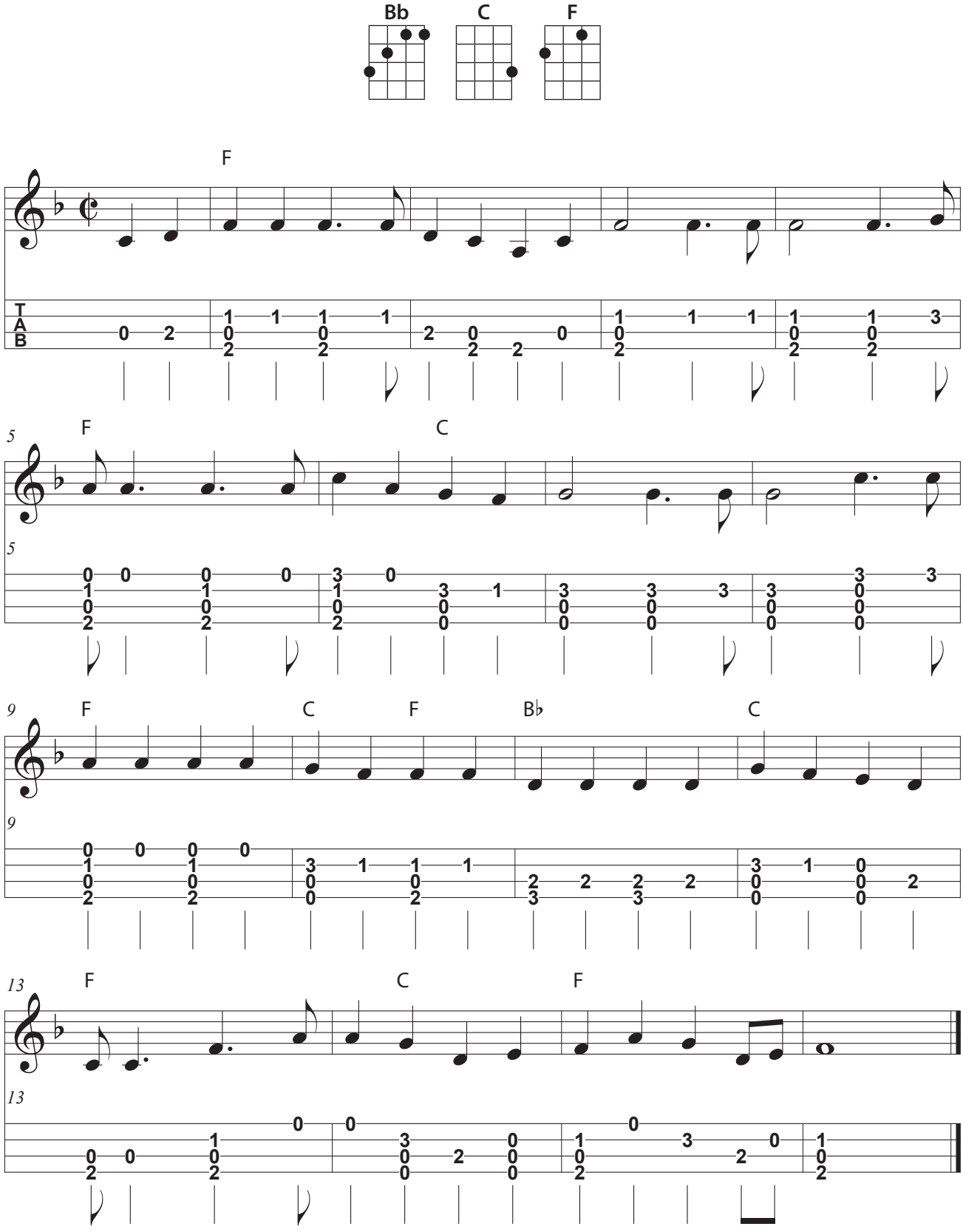
German



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

She'll Be Comin' Round the Mountain
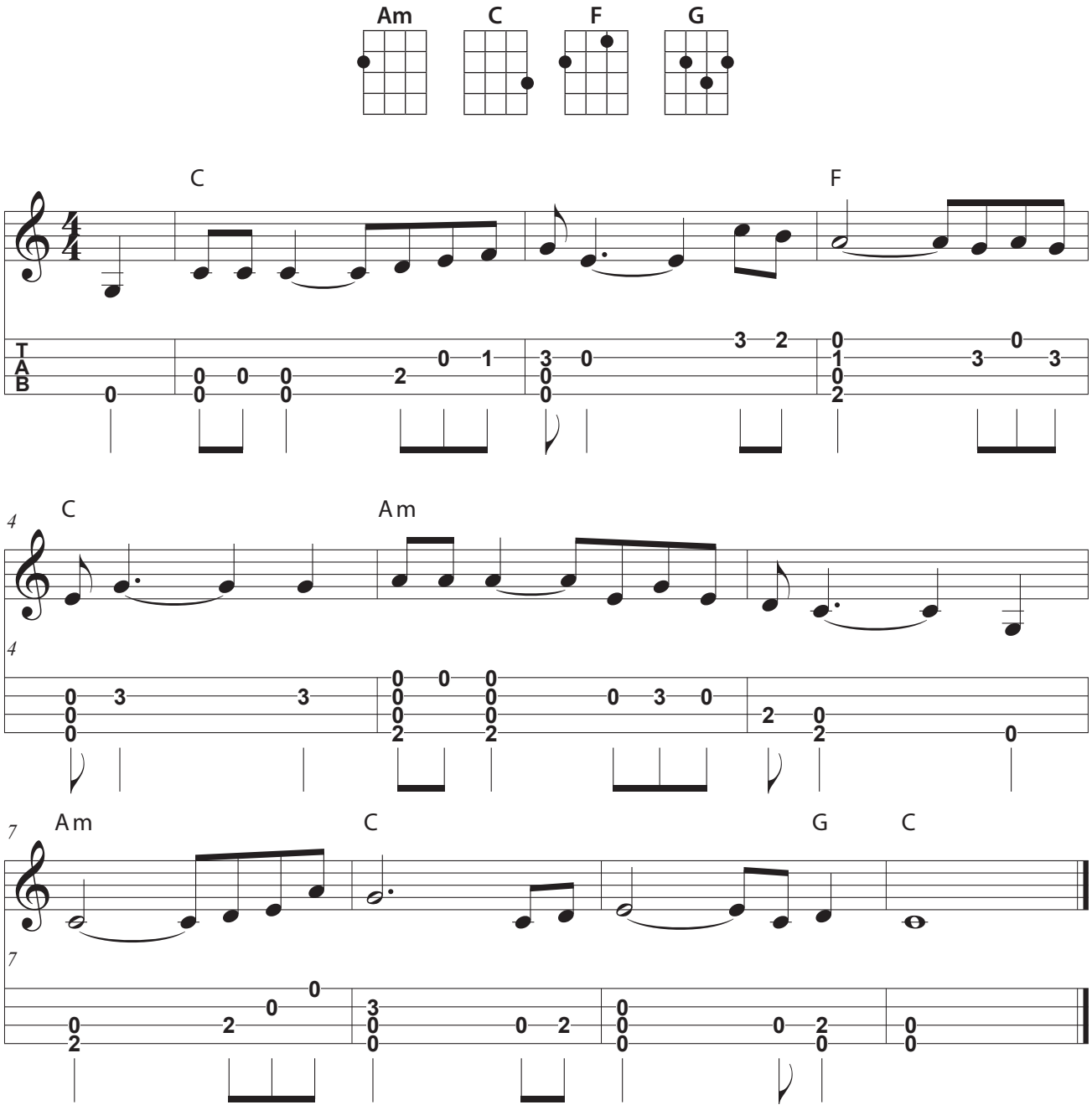
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Shenandoah

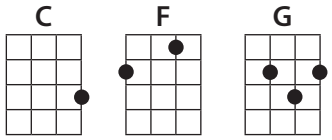
American
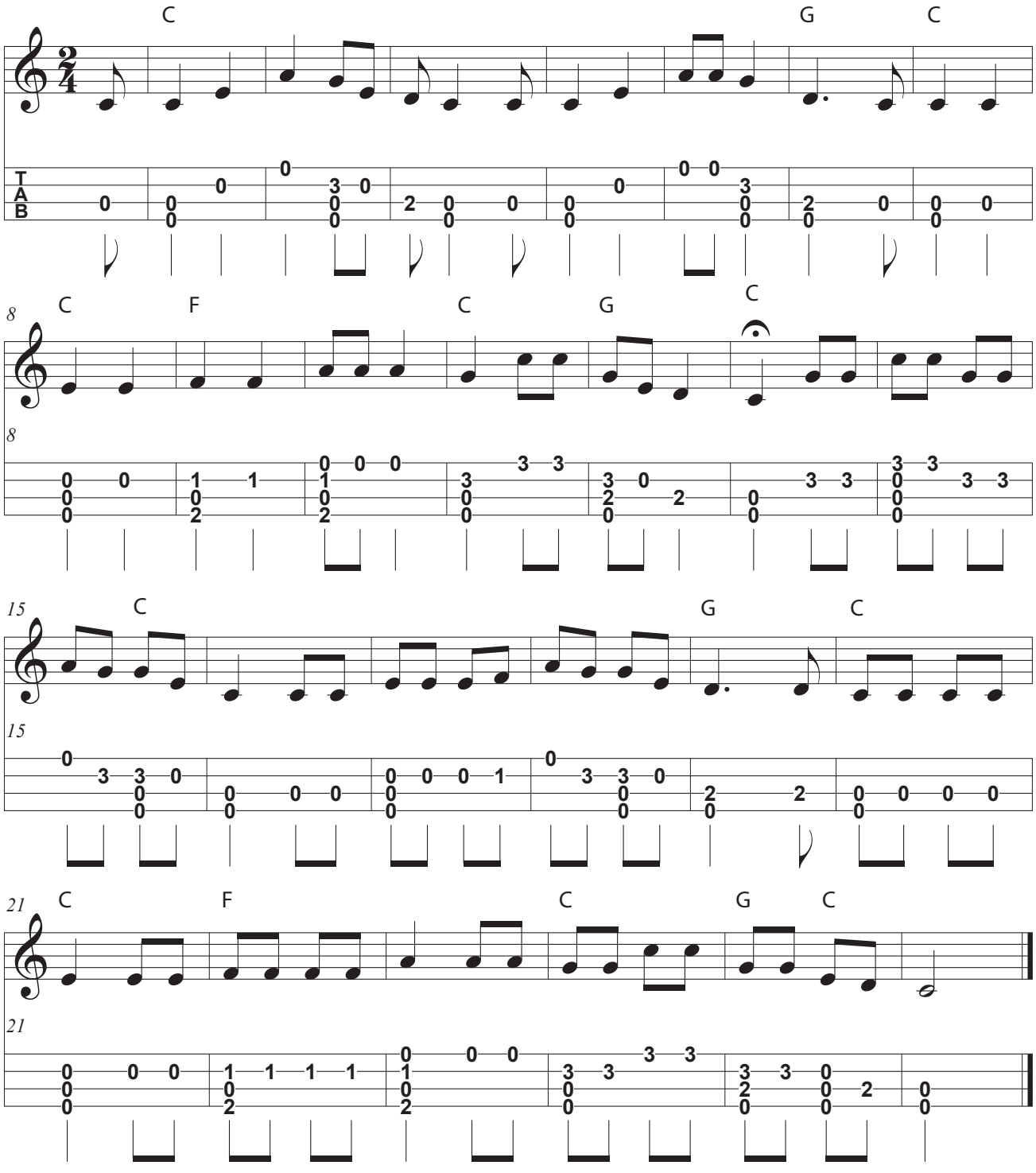


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Shuckin' of the Corn

American
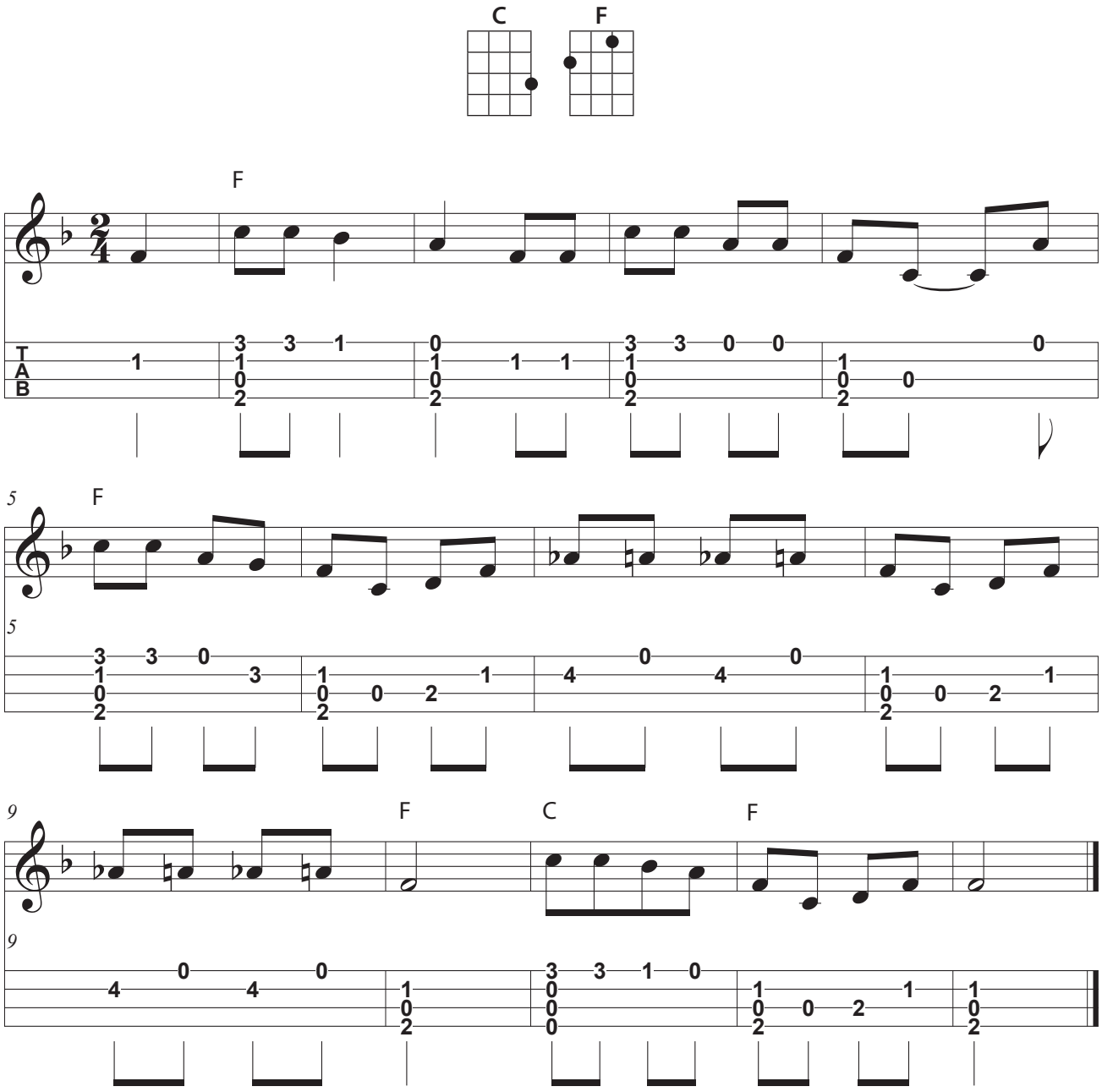




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Skillet Good and Greasy

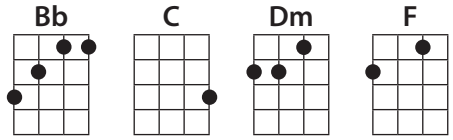
American
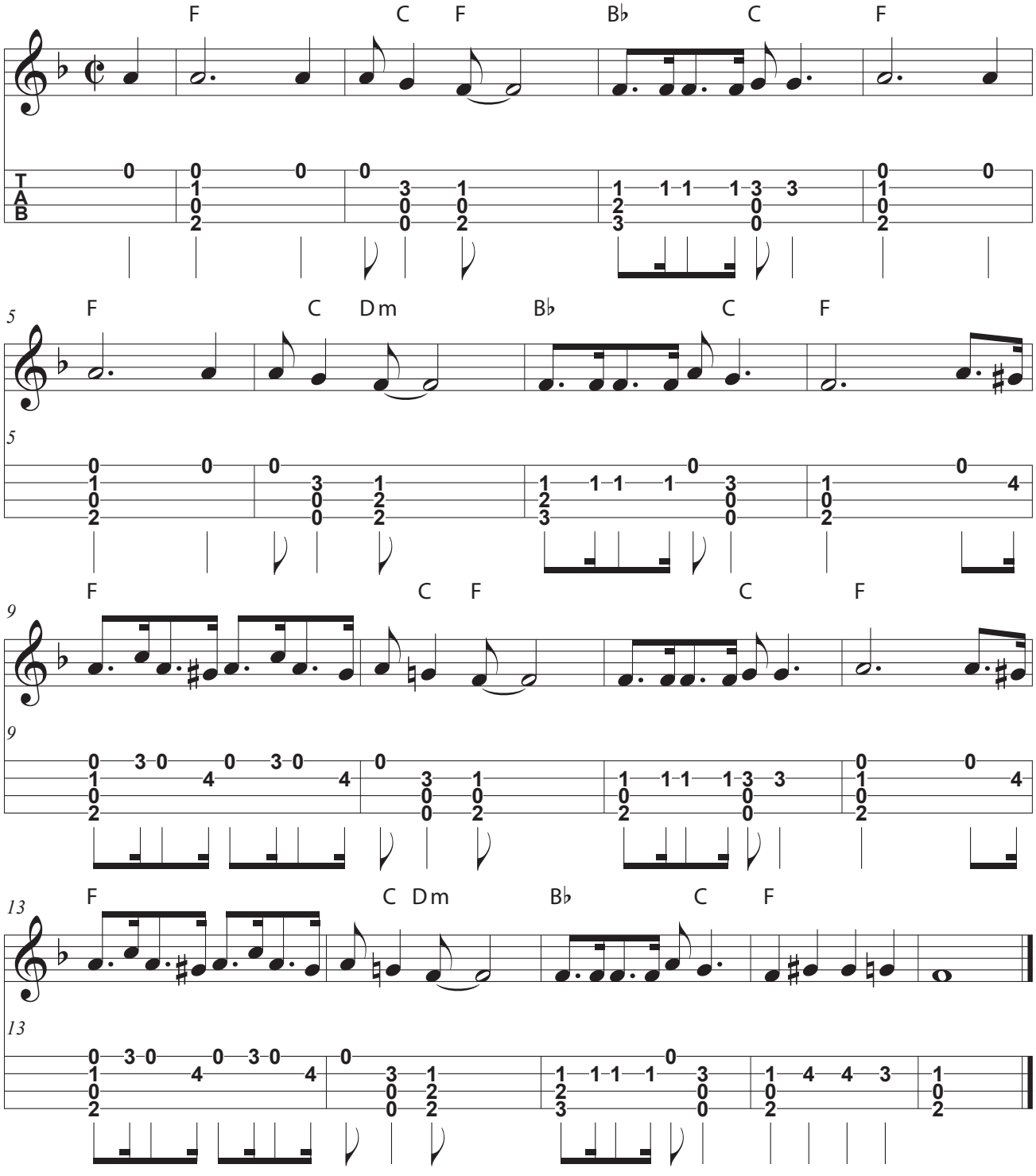


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Standing in the Need of Prayer

African American
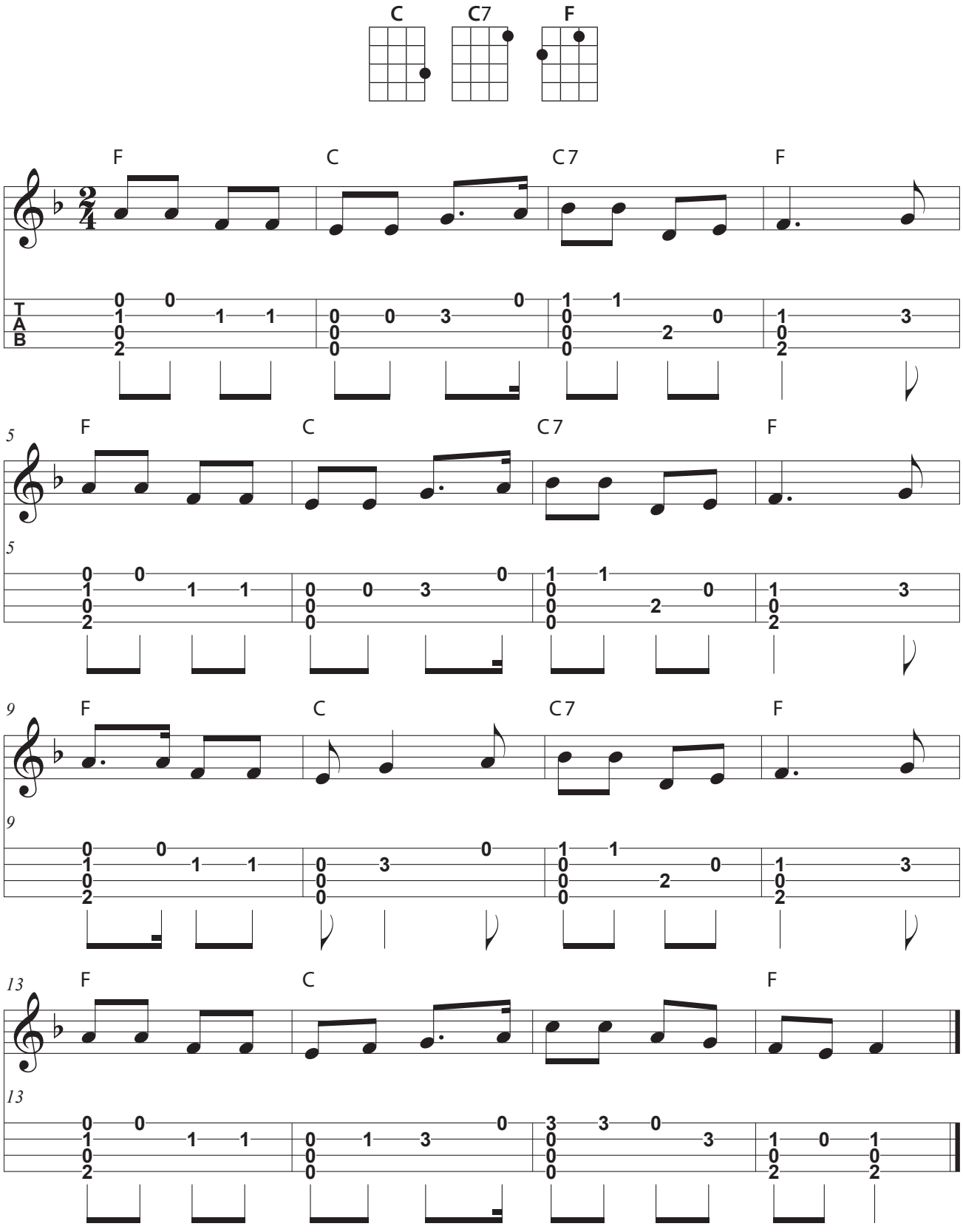




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Stir the Pudding

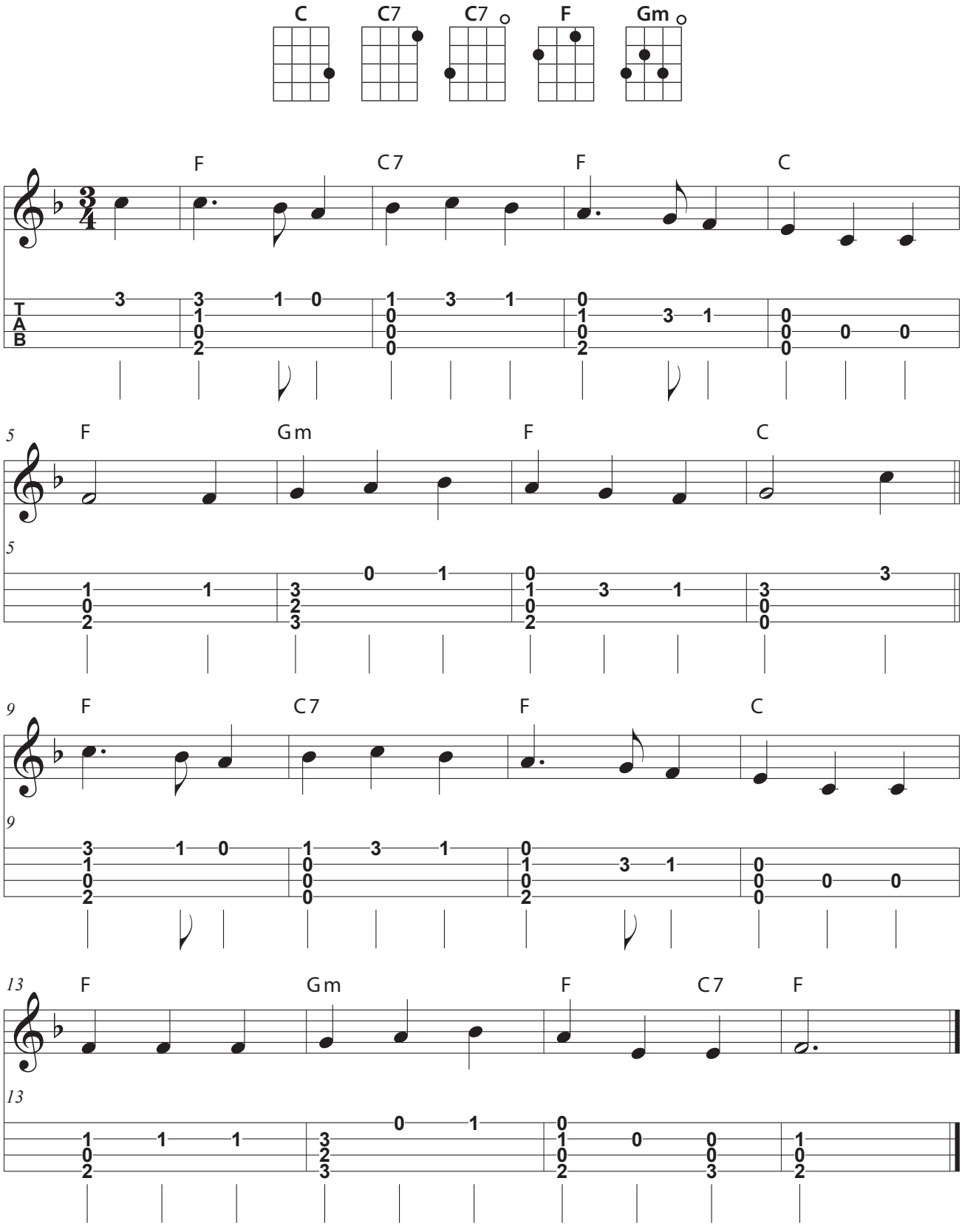
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Streets of Laredo
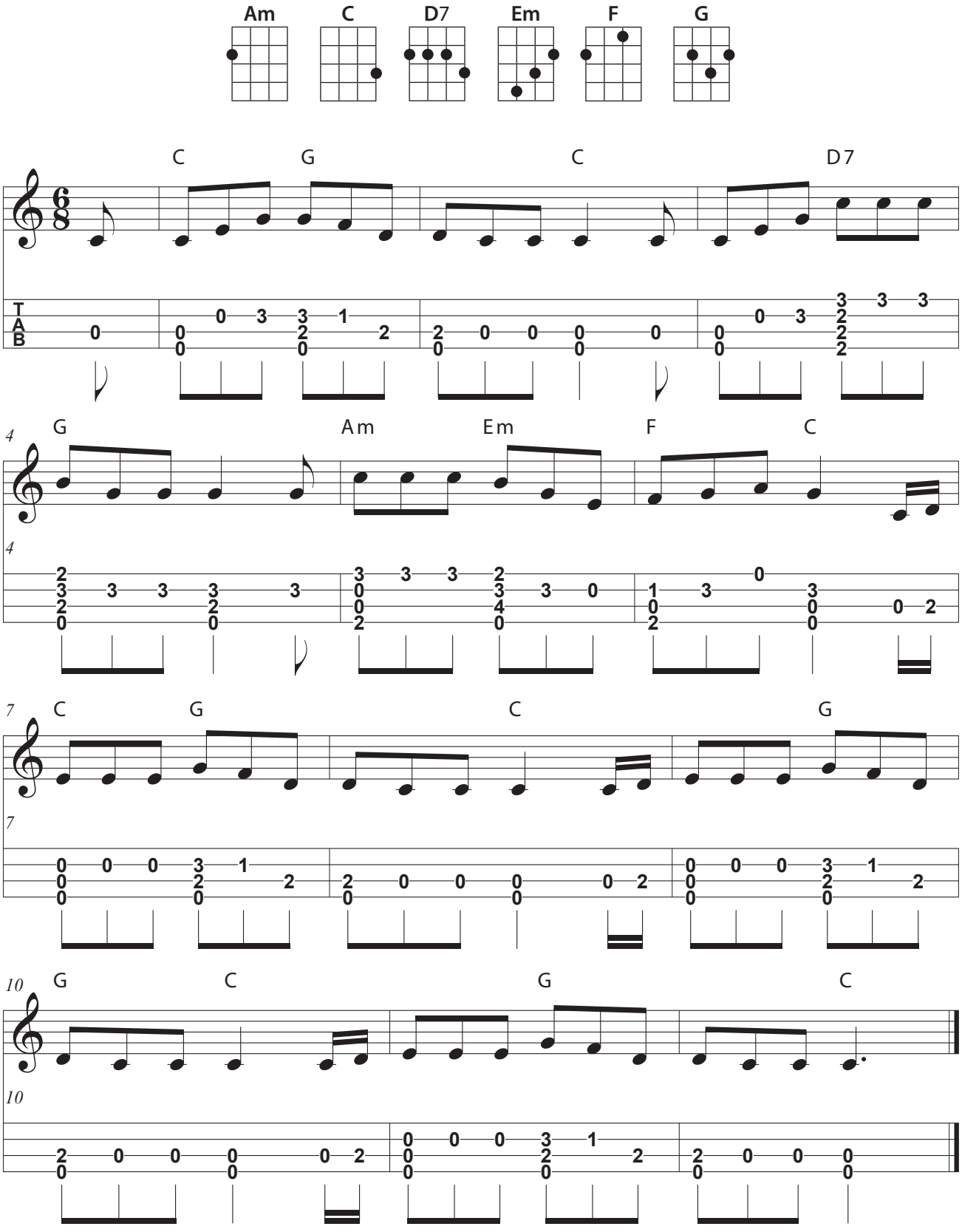
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Sweet Betsy from Pike

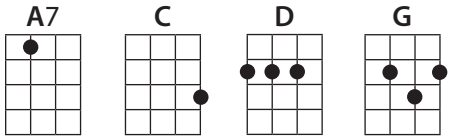
American
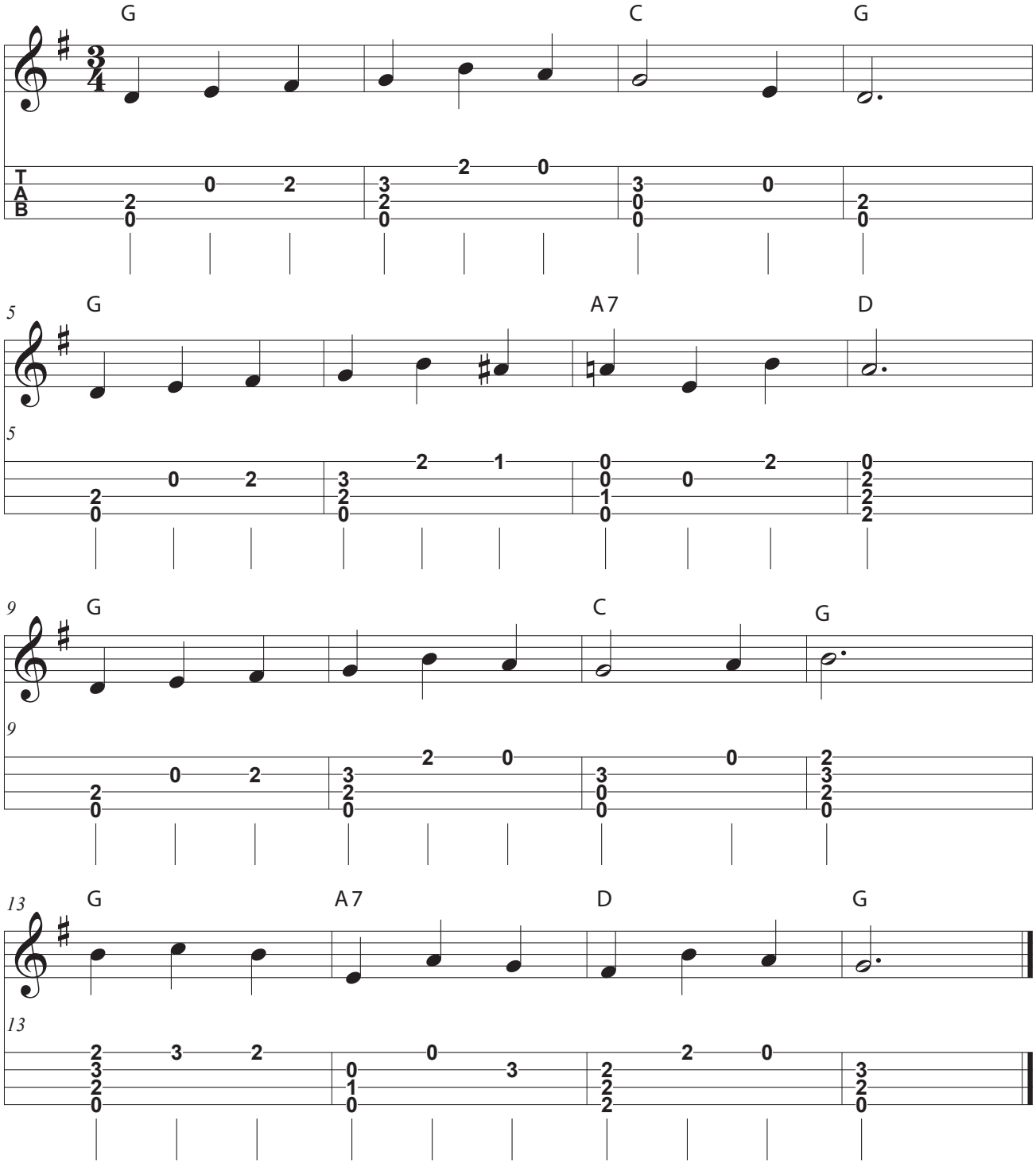


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Tell Me Why

American
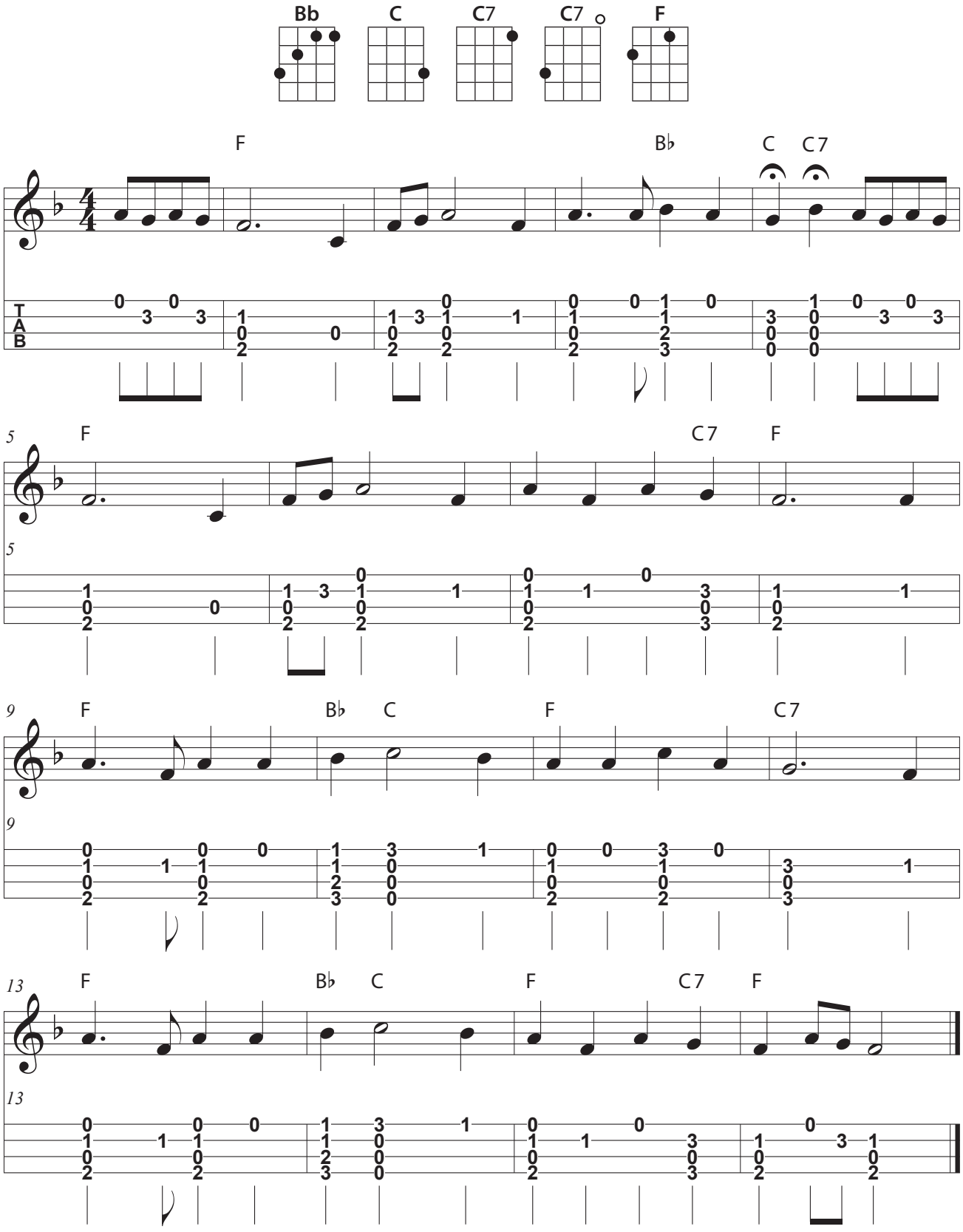




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

There Is a Balm in Gilead

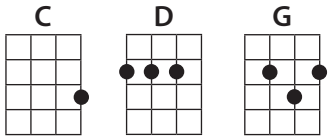
African American
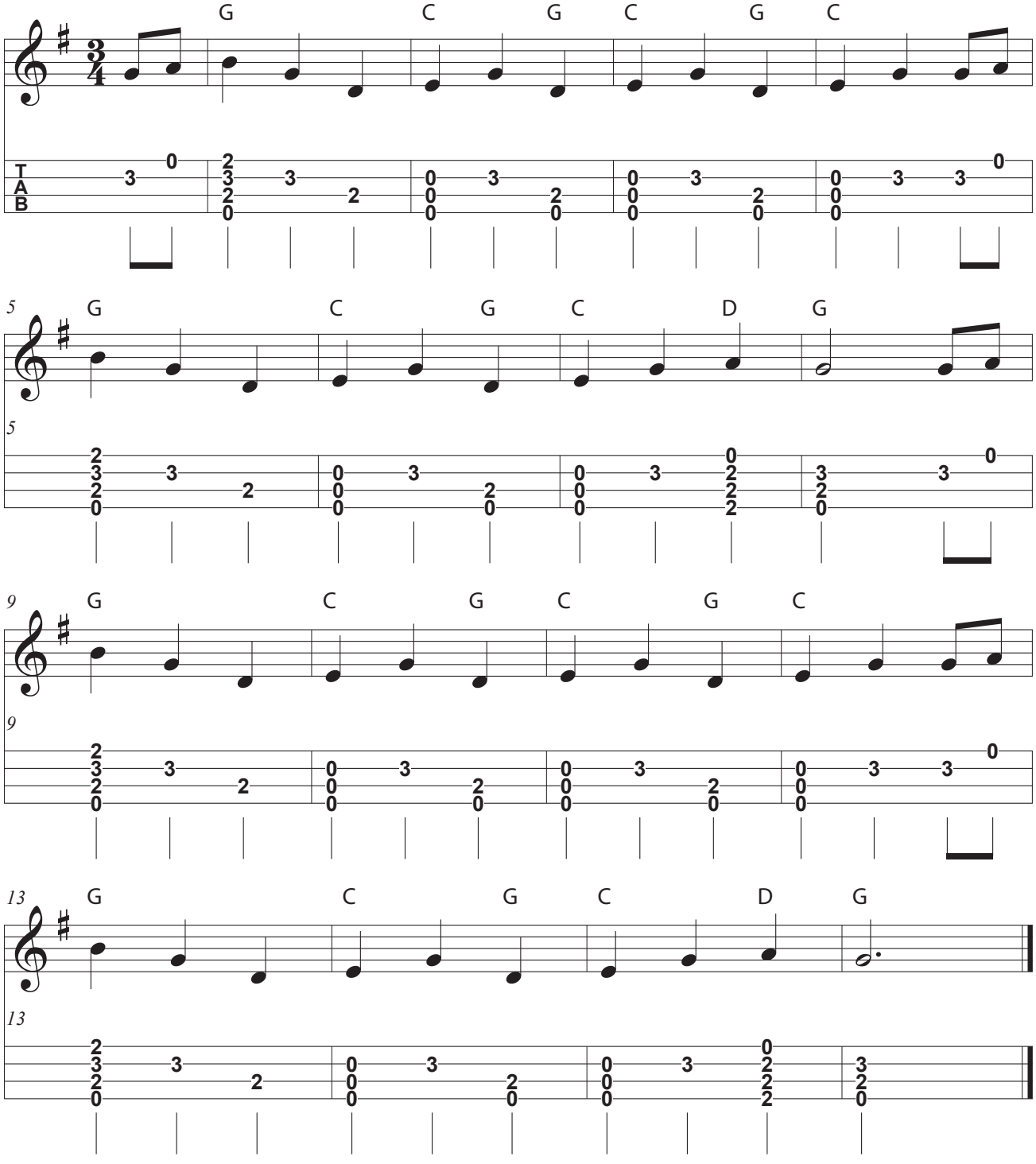


Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

There's a Hole in the Bucket

German American
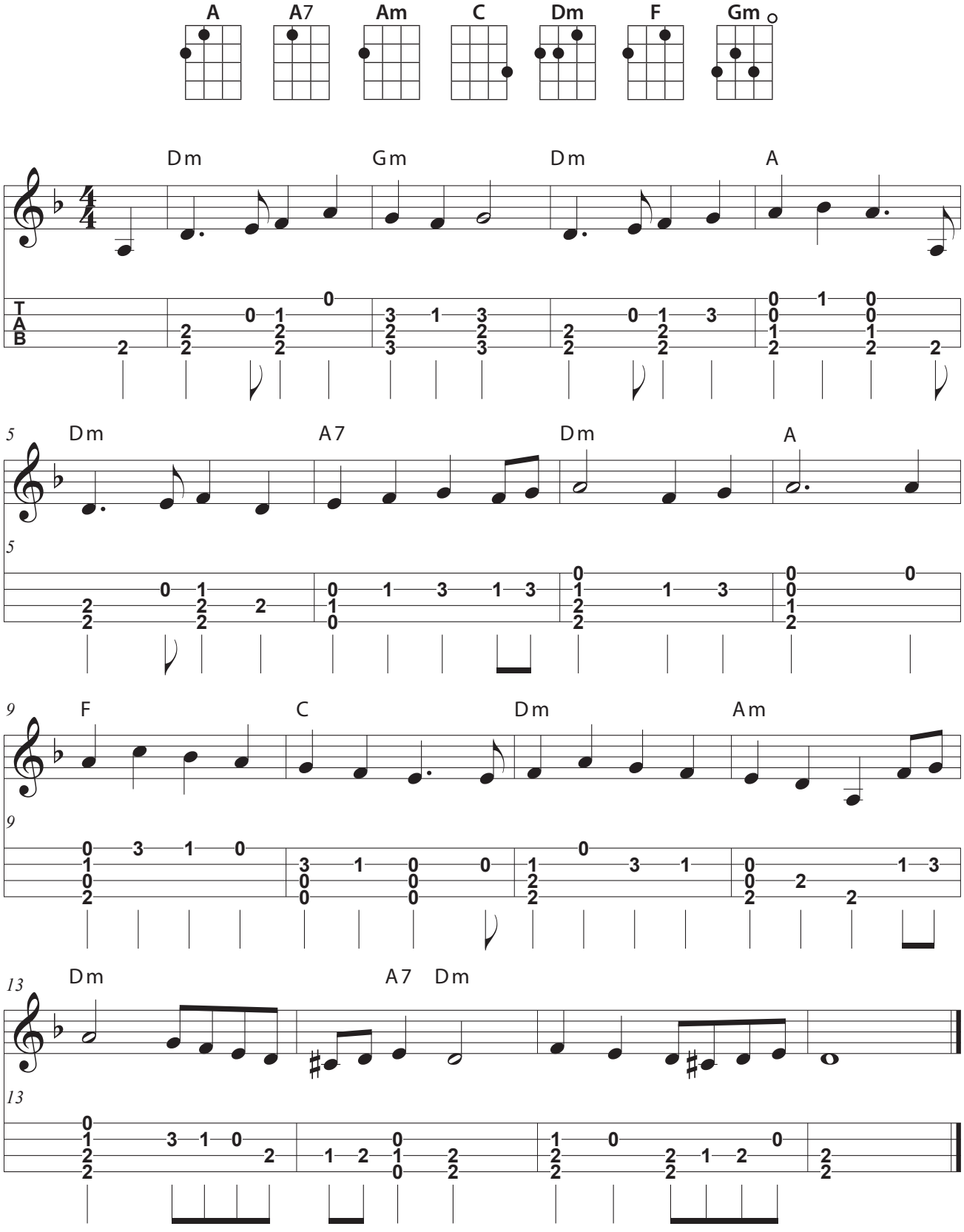




Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Three Ravens
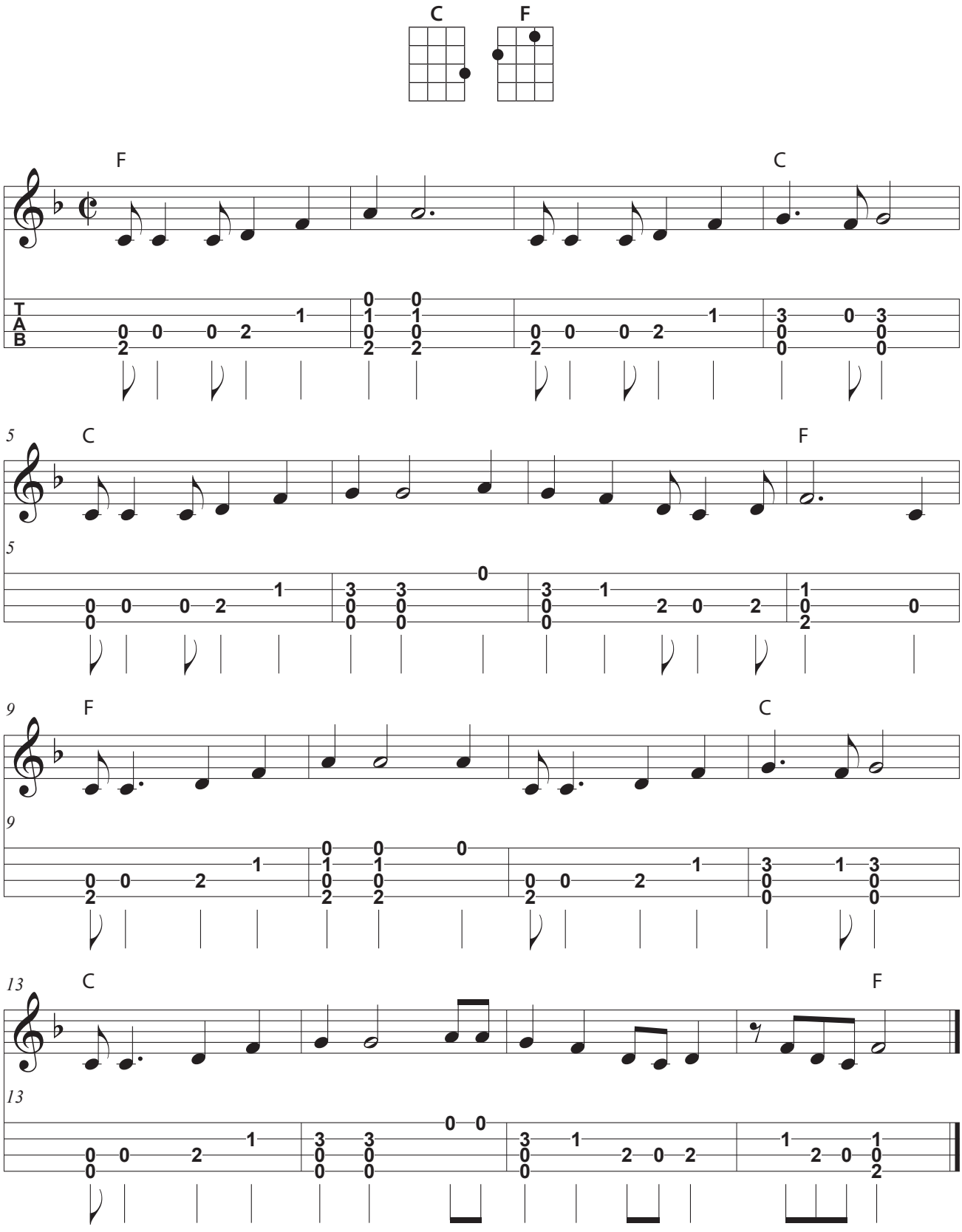
English



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Tom Dooley
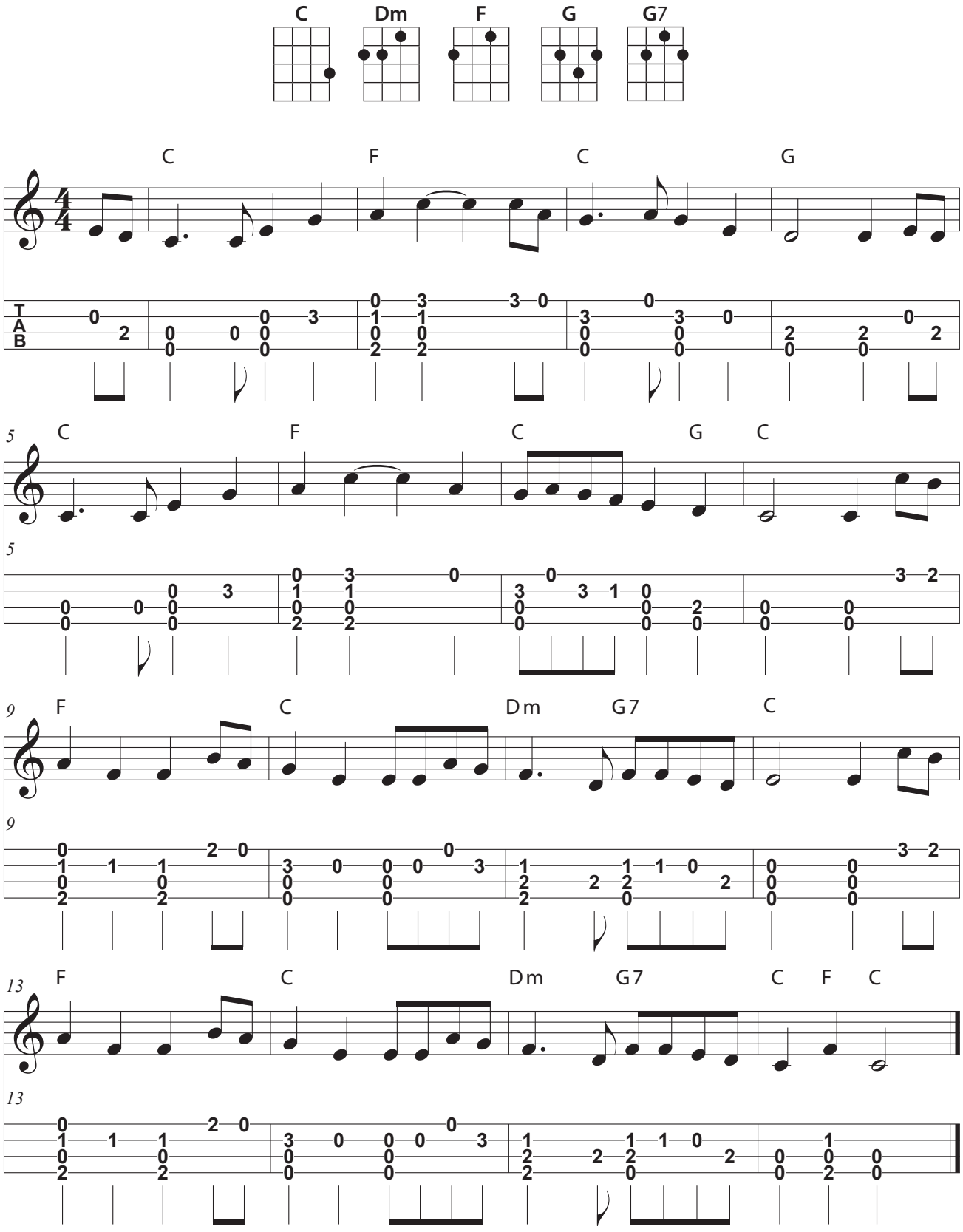
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Trav'lin' Man
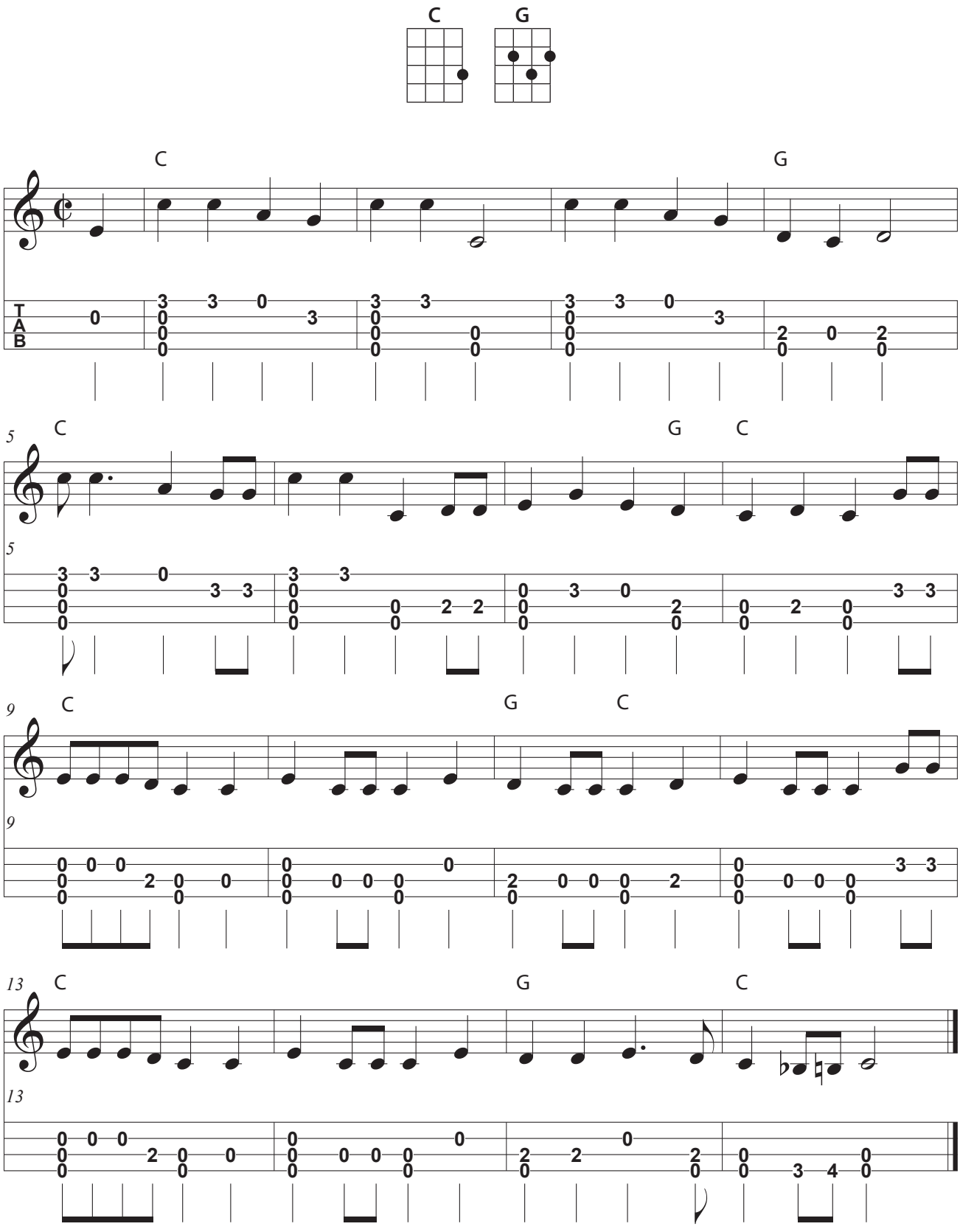
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Uncle Reuben
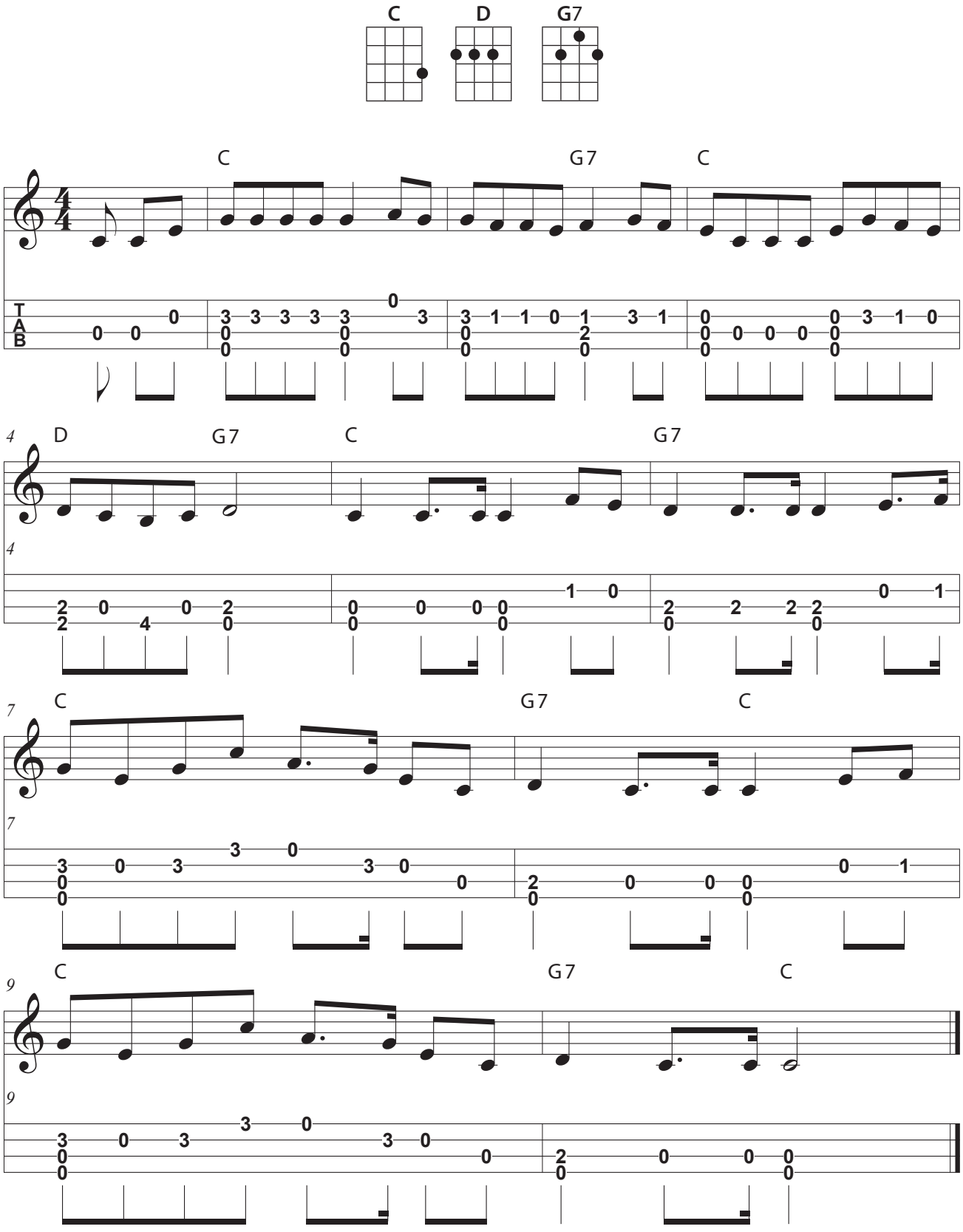
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

The Utah Iron Horse
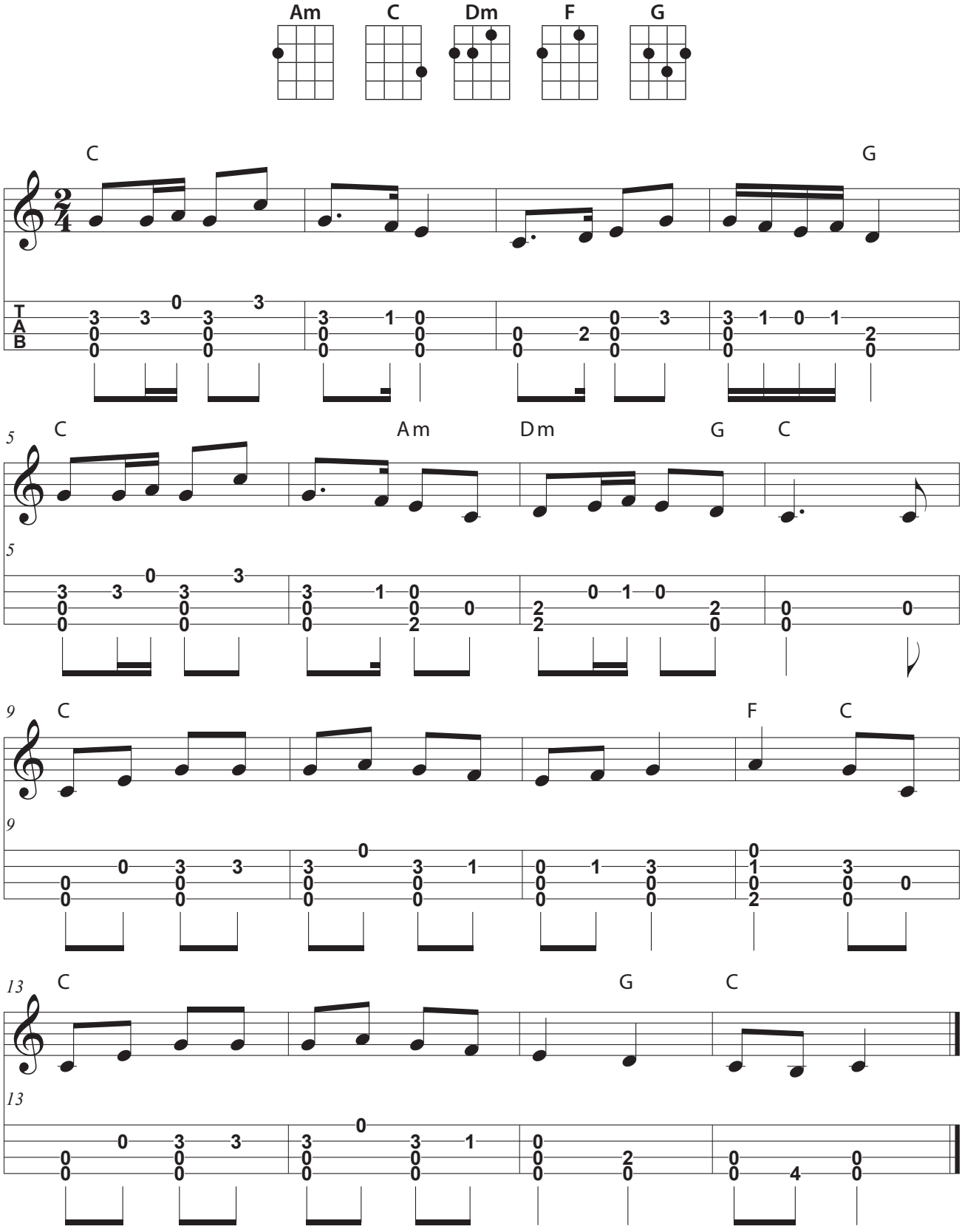
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Vive La Canadienne
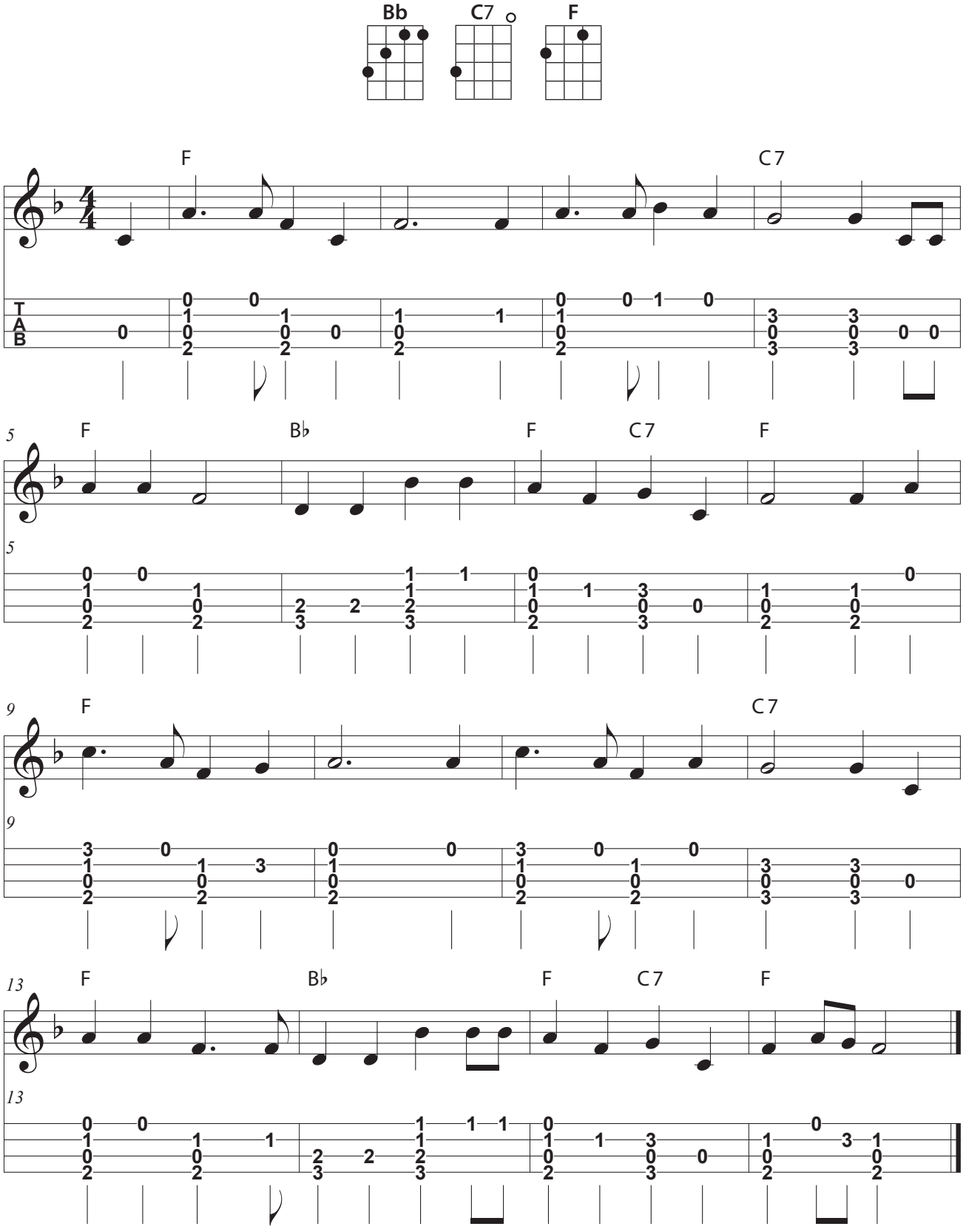
French Canadian



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

We're Coming, Arkansas
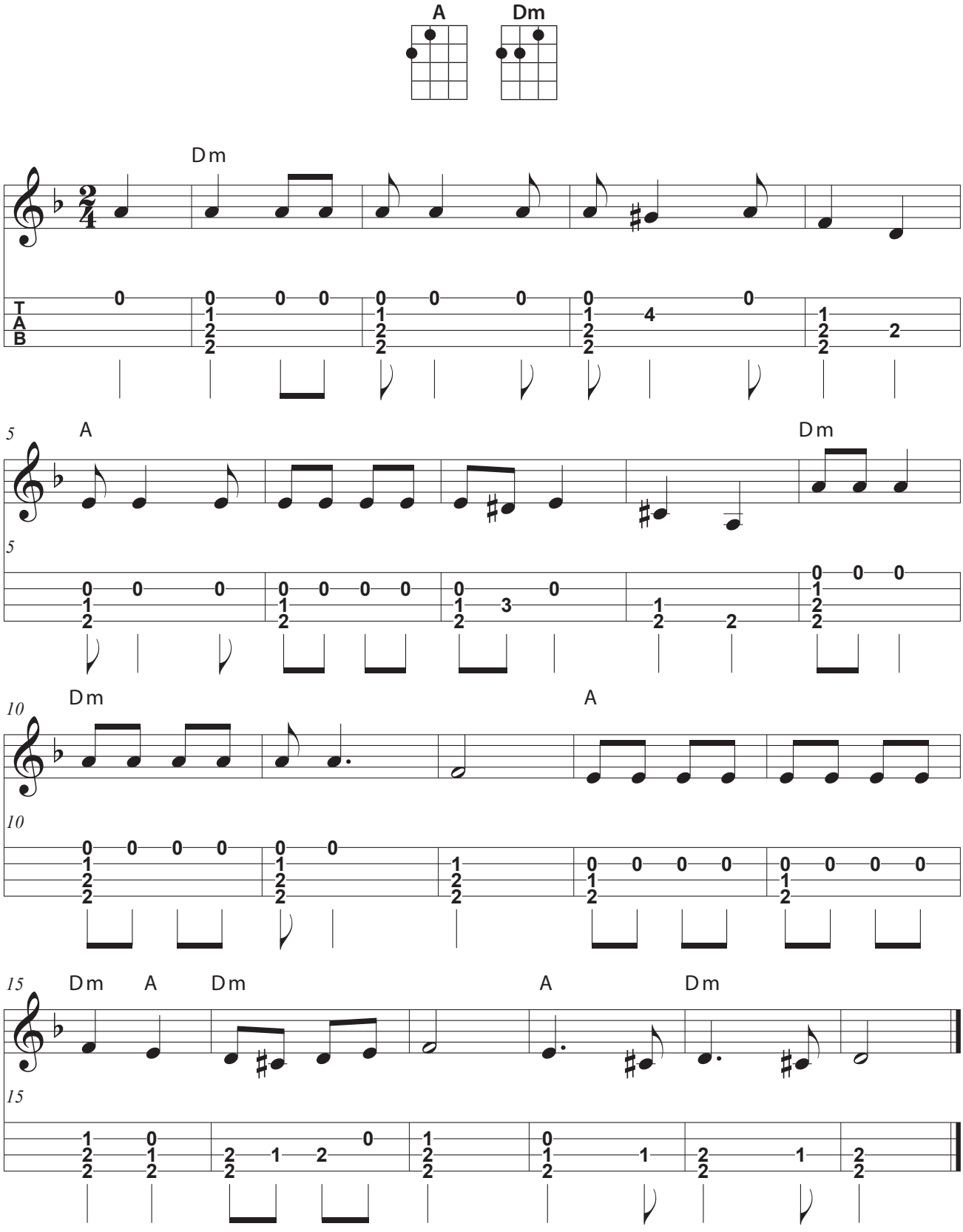
American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

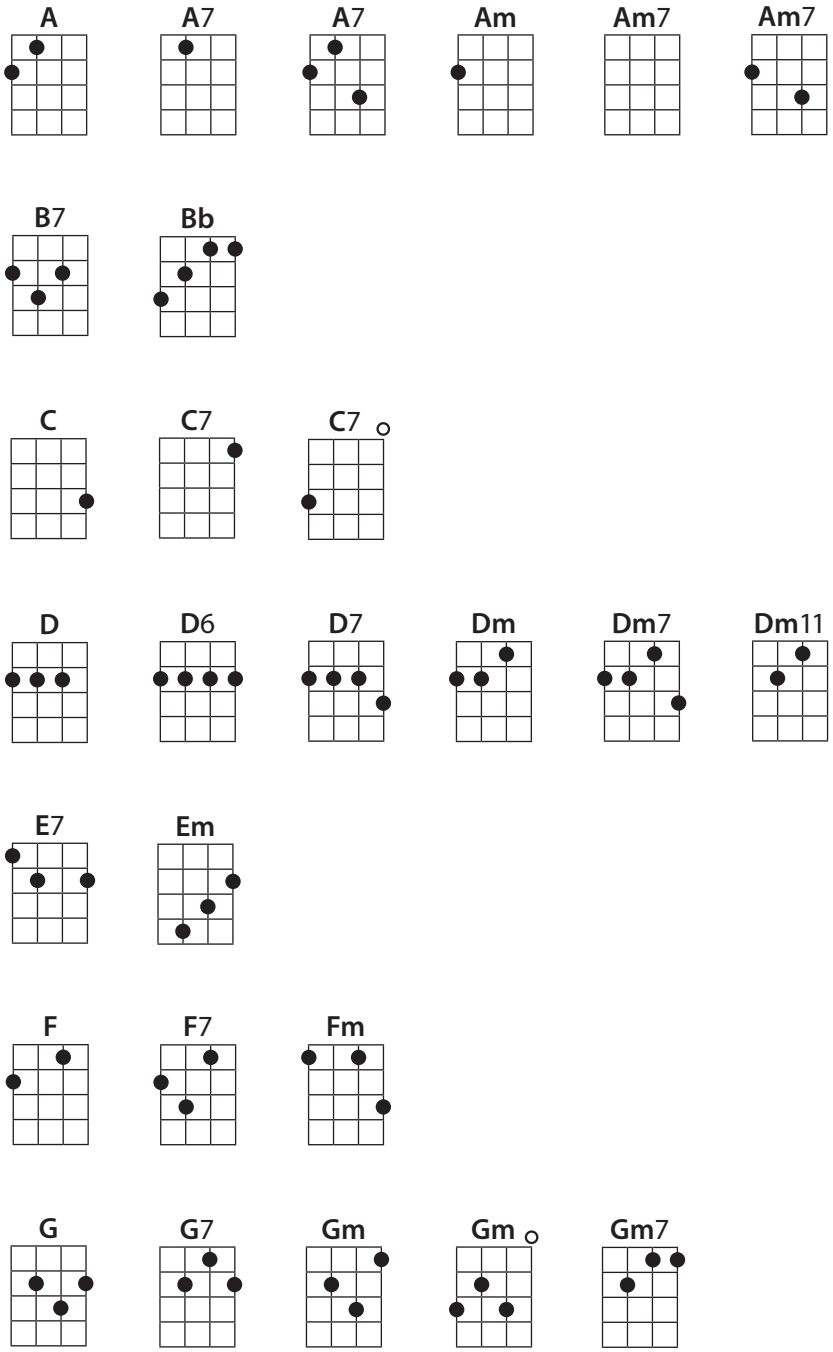
Willie the Weeper

American



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale

Appendix



Copyright © 2021 by Elizabeth Ragsdale